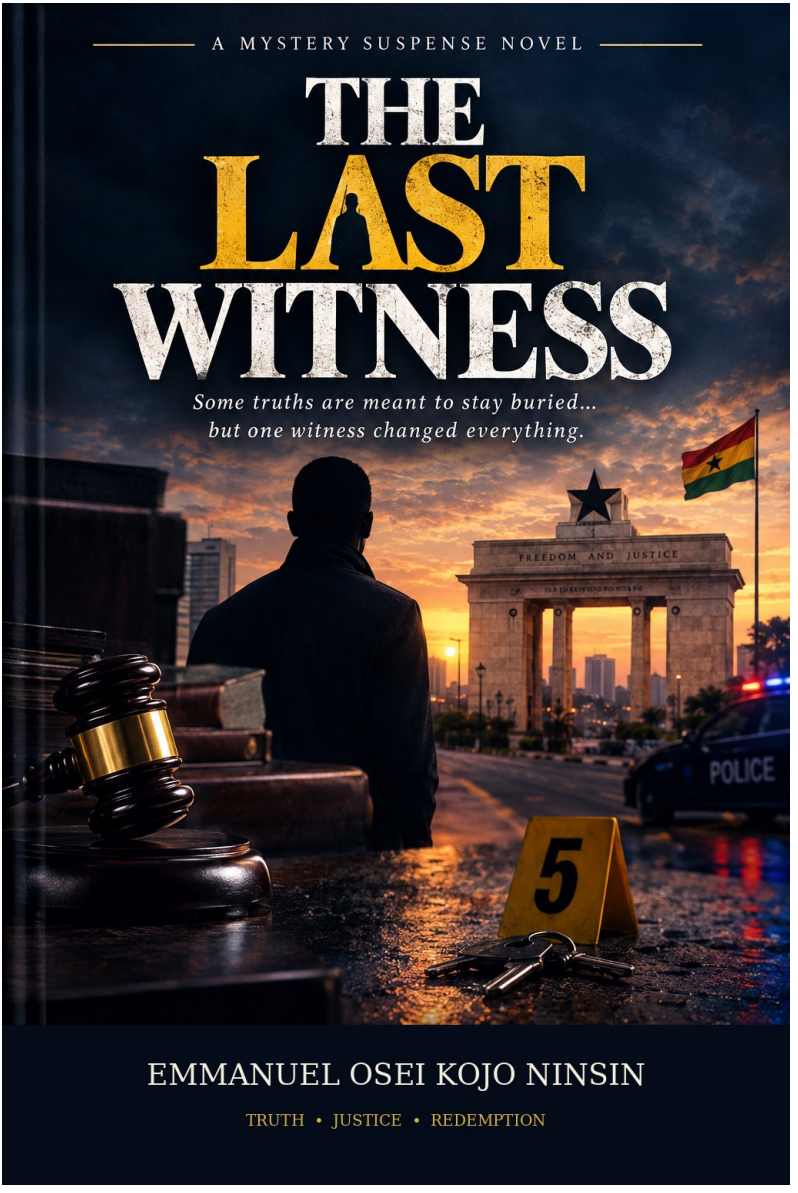

A MYSTERY SUSPENSE NOVEL
THE LAST WITNESS
Some truths are meant to stay buried...
but one witness changed everything.
FREEDOM AND JUSTICE
POLICE
5
EMMANUEL OSEI KOJO NINSIN
TRUTH • JUSTICE • REDEMPTION

THE LAST WITNESS

A Mystery Suspense Novel

Emmanuel Osei Kojo Ninsin

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This is a work of fiction. Names, characters, institutions, events and incidents are either products of the author's imagination or used fictitiously. Any resemblance to actual persons or events is coincidental.

DEDICATION

This book is dedicated to every young person who believes that education can open the door to a better future.

It is dedicated to students who continue to pursue knowledge despite difficulties, to teachers who dedicate themselves to shaping young minds, and to parents and guardians who sacrifice to provide educational opportunities for their children.

Most importantly, this book is dedicated to everyone who believes that learning is not only about passing examinations but about becoming a better, wiser and more responsible person.

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This book is not only a reflection of my own efforts; it is also a reflection of the encouragement and support I have received from people who have contributed to my journey.

May God bless you all.

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PART ONE — THE DEAD JUDGE

CHAPTER ONE

The Locked Study

The rain began shortly after nine o’clock, sweeping across Accra and turning the roads outside Justice Kweku Agyeman’s residence into dark ribbons. The retired judge had spent six years away from the bench, but his name still carried weight. His judgments had ended careers, exposed powerful men and earned him a reputation for incorruptibility. In recent years, however, rumours had followed him: a confidential appointment review, a missing witness, and records from a children’s home that appeared to have been altered.

At 10:06 p.m., the housekeeper knocked on the study door. There was no answer. The door was locked, the windows were secured, and no obvious sign of forced entry could be found. Police eventually broke the lock and discovered the judge dead at his desk. A cup of tea stood untouched beside an open file. The desk clock had stopped at 9:41 p.m.

Detective Superintendent Kwame Badu arrived before midnight. Beneath the desk he found a brass key tagged ROOM FOUR. Between the dead judge’s fingers was a folded paper bearing five names: Kweku Agyeman, Daniel Sarpong, Adwoa Sarpong, Emmanuel Badu and Mabel Owusu. A separate strip of paper was later documented beneath the desk blotter.

The last name belonged to a journalist Badu had never met. The fourth belonged to his own father, who had been dead for years. The locked room was only the first problem. The judge had left a message, and someone had gone to considerable trouble to ensure it would be found.

Outside, the rain softened to a steady hiss. Reporters had already gathered beyond the police tape, their camera lights cutting through the darkness. One called out that the judge had once presided over a corruption case involving senior officials. Another shouted that the killing must be political. Badu ignored them. He knew how quickly a public theory became a substitute for evidence, and how hard it was to dislodge once people had repeated it often enough.
Before leaving, he looked back at the study. The brass key was small, old-fashioned and unusually clean compared with the dust beneath the desk. Someone had placed it where it would be found. Badu slipped on gloves and asked the evidence officer to seal it separately. If the key was meant to direct the police, he wanted to know who had chosen the destination.

Badu stood just inside the doorway while the crime-scene photographer worked. The room smelled of wet wool, old paper and the bitter tea cooling beside the judge's hand. Nothing looked overturned. A pen lay parallel to the edge of the blotter; the reading lamp was still on; a framed photograph of Agyeman receiving an award faced the wall. The neatness felt deliberate. A sudden death rarely left a room this composed. Badu had learned to distrust scenes that looked arranged for an audience.
"Who found him?" he asked.
"The housekeeper," the uniformed officer replied. "She says he locked the door himself after dinner."
"Anyone else in the house?"

“Only the security guard. He was at the front gate.” Badu looked at the clock again. A stopped clock could be a clue, a coincidence or a prop. He asked the photographer to record its position before anyone touched it. Then he examined the folded paper without unfolding it further. Five names. No sentence, no date, no explanation. The dead judge had reduced a complicated history to a list and left Badu to discover why.

Badu asked the scene officer to read the names aloud, slowly, while he studied each one. Agyeman. Daniel Sarpong. Adwoa Sarpong. Emmanuel Badu. Mabel Owusu. The names did not form an obvious family, a list of suspects or a sequence of witnesses. They looked more like pieces of a record someone had tried to keep apart.

“Run all five,” he said. “Current and historical addresses. Court records, police files, missing-person reports. Don’t limit it to the obvious databases.”

The housekeeper waited in the hall with a cardigan wrapped around her shoulders. Her hands trembled when Badu asked about the judge’s final evening. She said he had eaten little, taken one phone call, then gone to the study carrying a brown envelope. She had heard him say, “It cannot remain buried.” She could not be certain whether he had been speaking to the caller or to himself.

“Did you recognise the voice on the phone?”

“No, sir. He spoke quietly. Then he said something about a child.”

Badu looked up. “A child?”

“That is what I heard. I didn’t want to listen.”

Her answer suggested she feared she had already heard too much. Badu thanked her and asked an officer to take a full statement, including the exact words she remembered and the words she was unsure of. In his experience, uncertainty was not a flaw in a witness. It was often the only honest part of a story.

Before he left, Badu examined the study door. The lock had splintered when the police forced it, but the wood around the frame showed no other damage. The windows were latched. He asked the scene officer to preserve the lock and call a locksmith before replacing it. The room was not impossible to enter; someone had made it seem that way. Someone wanted investigators to focus on the door instead of the time, the people and the paper on the desk.

A murder scene offered no orderly narrative, only competing explanations gathered in one room. His job was to resist the first one that felt satisfying.

The housekeeper’s statement added another detail: the judge had asked her to leave the hall light on, though he usually preferred the house dark after nine. It was a small departure from routine, too slight to mean much on its own. Badu marked it beside the stopped clock.

Badu returned to the study doorway. He imagined the judge sitting at the desk, knowing the old file was about to surface. Agyeman had spent decades in rooms where people weighed words before speaking. If he had wanted to reveal the truth, why had he left a clue instead of going to the police? Perhaps he had feared the institution. Perhaps he had been trying to protect someone. Perhaps he had been preparing a defence for himself.

Aidoo, the scene officer, gave Badu the names of the photographer and the scene supervisor. Badu wrote both names into his notebook. The five-name list recovered from the judge's fingers and the narrow strip beneath the blotter were logged as separate exhibits. The strip appeared to be a deliberate message, but its meaning would have to be tested against the rest of the evidence.

"Was it under the blotter when you arrived?" Badu asked.

"Yes, sir. It was there when we photographed the desk. No one touched it before then," Aidoo replied.

"Who handled it before it was bagged?" Badu asked.

Aidoo checked his notes before answering. "The photographer and I saw it first, sir. We photographed it where it lay, then collected it." He handed Badu the sealed evidence bag. Inside was a narrow strip of paper recovered from beneath the desk blotter. It had been folded so tightly that the creases had almost cut through the fibres. The visible words were only three: *Ask the fifth child.*

The guard was waiting in the front room when Badu came out of the study. He was a broad-shouldered man in a rain-darkened uniform, with a small notebook held in both hands. His name, he said, was Samuel Tetteh. He had worked at the residence for nearly four years and had never known the judge to leave the gate unlocked, even for a familiar visitor.

"Start from the beginning," Badu said. "Not from when you heard the police arrive. Start from the last time you saw the judge alive."

Tetteh described the evening in careful blocks. Agyeman had returned from a short drive shortly before seven. He had carried no umbrella and had been annoyed by the rain. At half past eight,

a delivery rider brought a sealed envelope, but the judge collected it himself at the gate. At about nine, Tetteh saw the housekeeper take a tray toward the study corridor. No visitor had signed the book after dinner.

“You saw no one enter?”

“No one through the front gate, sir.”

Badu noted the distinction. “Could someone have entered another way?”

Tetteh glanced toward the rear passage. “The service gate is kept locked. It opens onto the lane. I checked it at nine-thirty, as I always do.”

“Did you see the judge’s car leave?”

“No, sir.”

“Any telephone calls at the gate? Any lights in the garden? Anything out of the ordinary?”

Tetteh said he had heard a vehicle slow outside the wall, then move on. The rain had been heavy enough to blur the sound. He had not seen its registration number or even whether it was a car or a van. He offered the detail as if he feared it was too small to matter.

“Small details matter,” Badu said. “But we must keep them small until we can prove what they mean.”

He asked Tetteh to draw the gate, the guard post, the service lane and the windows facing the garden. The sketch was rough, but it showed that the guard could not see the study windows from his chair. It also showed a stretch of wall hidden by a neem tree. Badu did not call it an entrance. He marked it for a daylight inspection.

When the guard had finished, Badu asked the same questions again in a different order. The answers remained mostly consistent, except for the time he had checked the service gate. First he said nine-thirty; then he thought it might have been closer to nine-forty. He looked embarrassed by the uncertainty.

“Don’t guess to please me,” Badu told him. “If you don’t know, say you don’t know. We can check the duty log and any camera recordings in the morning.”

There was a camera above the front gate, Tetteh explained, but it had been unreliable during storms. The recorder was kept in a cabinet beside the guard post. Badu ordered the equipment secured and the footage copied without overwriting the original. He also asked for the duty log, the visitor book and the names of anyone who had worked the previous two shifts.

Outside, the rain had eased. The house looked ordinary in the wash of the security lights: a clipped hedge, pale walls, a covered veranda and the black mouth of the service lane. Badu walked the perimeter with a uniformed officer. He did not touch the gate or test a latch. He watched where water collected, where shoes might leave marks, and where the lights failed to reach.

At the rear gate, the officer found the chain wet and cold. The padlock appeared intact, but appearance was not proof that it had remained closed all evening. Badu asked that it be photographed and examined in daylight. Near the neem tree, the ground had been churned by rain. Any footprints that might once have been there had become a muddy blur.

The scene gave him no clean answer. It gave him a list of things that could still be checked: the guard’s log, the camera recorder, the delivery envelope, the judge’s phone records, the housekeeper’s account and the lock itself. Each would have to

stand independently. If two witnesses repeated the same rumour, that did not make it two pieces of evidence.

At the station, Badu asked the duty officer to prepare a single chronology without interpreting it. The first entry was the housekeeper's discovery at 10:06 p.m.; the next was the call to the police; the last was the time the first officers entered the study. The clock's 9:41 reading sat in a separate column, labelled 'unverified scene indicator'. Badu wanted the team to see the gap between a thing observed and a conclusion drawn from it. He had watched investigations lose days because someone had turned a convenient time into a fact before checking the source.

Aidoo brought him the initial inventory. The tea cup, open file, folded list, paper strip, phone and clock had each been photographed before collection. The brown envelope mentioned by the housekeeper remained unaccounted for. Badu asked whether the file itself had been disturbed. Aidoo could not say; the pages had been open when the photographer arrived, and no one could establish how they had been arranged before the judge died. Badu added a request for fingerprints and trace examination, but warned the team not to promise results that the material might not yield.

On his way to the interview room, Badu stopped by the window overlooking the rain-soaked car park. The names were already circulating among officers, and he knew that his father's presence on the list would tempt people to connect the case to him. He disclosed the connection again in writing and asked the superintendent to record the decision about oversight. It was uncomfortable to place his own family history in an official file, but the alternative was worse: a later challenge that the

investigation had hidden a conflict. He returned to the board with one rule for the team: no name would be treated as a verdict.

Back inside, Badu paused beside the hall table. The brown envelope the housekeeper had mentioned was not visible among the items already photographed. He asked Aidoo whether it had been found in the study. The officer checked the scene inventory and shook his head. It might have been inside the open file, removed before the police arrived, or never brought into the room at all. For now, it was an absence reported by one witness, not a missing exhibit.

Badu wrote that distinction in his notebook. A case could be damaged by what investigators failed to notice, but it could also be damaged by what they imagined into existence. The judge had left five names and a paper asking about a child. The house offered a stopped clock, a locked door and several ordinary routines that might conceal an extraordinary act. None of them yet told him who had killed Kweku Agyeman.

Before leaving the residence, Badu asked Aidoo to walk him through the first ten minutes after the door was forced. The officer described where each person had stood, who had touched the handle, and when the housekeeper was moved away from the corridor. Badu made him repeat the sequence without looking at his notes. The details stayed consistent, but one omission became obvious: no one had recorded whether a key was in the lock when the door first opened. Aidoo checked the scene log. The entry said only that the door had been forced after repeated calls received no answer.

Badu asked for a supplementary statement, not because he suspected Aidoo of wrongdoing but because memory hardened quickly once a story was repeated. At

the front gate, rainwater ran from the security canopy in a steady silver line. The guard said the camera covering the driveway had lost several minutes during the storm. He could not tell whether the outage had been caused by the weather or a fault in the recorder. Badu instructed the technical officer to preserve the device and obtain the service history. The missing envelope, the uncertain lock sequence and the camera gap were three separate problems. He would not force them into one theory simply because they had surfaced in the same house.

By the time the first uniformed officers had finished photographing the study, Badu had made himself a rule: every object would be treated as ordinary until evidence gave it another meaning. The brass key was conspicuous, almost theatrical. That made it dangerous. Someone might have placed it where it would be found because they wanted the police to follow it. He asked the photographer to take a second set of images with a scale beside the tag, then watched the evidence officer seal it. The chain-of-custody form recorded the time, the officer’s name and every transfer. Badu signed only after checking the number against the label.

In the hallway, the housekeeper remembered another sound: a short scrape sometime after ten, like a chair being dragged across the floor. She could not say whether it came from the study or the room above it. Badu did not write ‘movement in the study’ in his notebook. He wrote exactly what she had said, including her uncertainty. A witness’s confidence could grow with every repetition; Badu had seen memory turn into performance. He asked her to draw where she had been standing and which doors were open. Her sketch was untidy but useful: it

showed that the kitchen door had been ajar, giving her a view of the passage without a view of the study entrance.

Before leaving, Badu walked the corridor alone. A locked door could create the illusion that the answer lay in the lock. But the room had not locked itself, and the person responsible did not need to vanish through a wall. He studied the hinges, the floor beneath the door and the narrow space between the frame and the latch. He ordered that no one try the lock again until a specialist arrived. Then he looked once more at the five names. The case already seemed to be offering an explanation. He would not let it speak in place of the evidence.

The Evidence Room

The next morning, Badu asked the scene team to walk him through the residence again, not to repeat the first search but to identify what each person had actually observed. The housekeeper described the sound of her knock; the guard described the arrival at the gate; the estate manager described the key cabinet. Their accounts overlapped, but none covered the entire interval. Badu wrote the gaps on a separate sheet. A gap was not proof of deception. It marked a question the investigation still had to answer.

The photographer returned with the original image files and explained how each photograph had been taken. The study looked orderly from the doorway, but the close images showed a faint mark on the edge of the desk and a disturbed patch of dust near the bookcase. Neither established a struggle. Badu asked that the details be recorded without interpretation. Later, a

defence lawyer could challenge an officer who had written ‘sign of a fight’ where the camera showed only a mark. Precision, he reminded the team, was not timidity. It protected the truth.

Before leaving, Badu stood at the study entrance and tried to imagine the room from the perspective of someone who had never seen it. The locked door had dominated the first account because it made the best story. Yet the key register, the visitors’ log, and the call records might prove more important. A room could be locked by ordinary means. The harder question was why someone wanted the death to look impossible. He left the room without offering a theory to the waiting officers.

Inside, the housekeeper showed them the route she used when carrying tea to the study. She could see the corridor clock from the landing, but not the face of the study door until she reached the final turn. She remembered hearing a chair scrape and then the generator start again. She could not say whether the sound came before or after the clock struck ten. Badu asked her to demonstrate the route without pretending to remember more than she did. By the time she finished, the scene had become less mysterious and more difficult: several people had witnessed fragments, and none had witnessed the whole.

Badu asked him not to correct the original. Instead, the guard signed a supplementary statement explaining when and why he had completed the line. A photograph was taken of the page, and the book was sealed for examination. The distinction mattered: a late entry was not automatically false, but it could no longer be treated as a real-time record. The second officer noted the same limitation in his own notebook.

At first light, Badu returned to the residence with a fresh notebook and an officer who had not attended the night inspection. He wanted a second pair of eyes on the details everyone had already begun repeating. The gate guard described the rain, the generator’s brief failure, and the moment a delivery rider had asked for directions. Each detail sounded ordinary until Badu asked the guard to place it against the time he had written in the visitor book. The sequence shifted by several minutes. The guard looked embarrassed, not evasive, and admitted that he had filled in part of the entry after the rider had left.

The House After The Rain

The House After the Sirens

By midnight, the rain had thinned to a mist, but the residence remained crowded with people who had no official reason to be there. Uniformed officers guarded the gate while neighbours watched from behind curtains. Badu noticed how quickly grief had become public property. A retired judge had died, and everyone seemed to have an opinion about what his death meant before anyone had established how he had died.

He asked the scene officer to list every person who had crossed the threshold since the housekeeper discovered the body. The list included the housekeeper, the driver, two guards, the first patrol team, a senior officer who had arrived before Badu, and a man who claimed to be a family representative. The last name had been entered without an identification number. Badu circled it. A name without a way to verify it was not yet a person he could account for.

In the study, the judge's papers had been disturbed, but not scattered. That distinction bothered Badu. A hurried intruder might have searched drawers roughly; someone who knew what he wanted could leave the room looking almost orderly. He photographed each open drawer and asked the photographer to

include the surrounding furniture in every frame. A close-up could show a torn edge. A wider image could show whether the torn page had been moved before or after the chair was shifted.

The housekeeper, Esi, stood in the corridor with a folded cloth pressed between her hands. She repeated that she had knocked twice and called the judge by name. Badu did not ask her to repeat the story for a third time. Instead, he asked her to write down what she remembered in the order it came back to her, including anything she was unsure about. When she finished, she stared at the paper as if it belonged to someone else.

“I heard a sound earlier,” she said. “Not a shout. Something like a chair leg against the floor.” She could not give an exact time. The television had been on in another room, and the rain had covered the quieter sounds. Badu recorded the statement without turning it into a fixed point on the timeline. A sound was a lead, not a reliable timestamp.

Before leaving the study, he looked once more at the door. The lock had made the room seem impossible, but investigators should use that word sparingly. Doors had mechanisms, keys, histories and users. People had habits. One of those facts would eventually explain what the others could not.

The Housekeeper’s Second Account

The housekeeper, Ama Serwaa, returned to the station after lunch with a correction she had been too embarrassed to make during her first interview. She had told Badu that she heard a chair scrape shortly before she found the study door locked. On reflection, she could not be certain the sound came from the study. A delivery van had reversed into the compound at almost the same time, and its metal ramp made a similar noise. She

wanted the statement amended before the uncertainty became a fact in someone else’s report.

Badu thanked her for coming back. He asked her to describe the sequence without trying to fit it to the time on the stopped clock. Ama remembered taking a tray upstairs, finding the corridor light on, and hearing the television from the sitting room. She did not remember seeing a person leave the study. The detail she could repeat was smaller: the door mat had been pushed slightly sideways. She had straightened it before calling for help, a choice she now regretted because it meant the position could no longer be documented.

The scene officer added the correction to the interview record and signed the amendment with Ama. Badu refused to let the team call it a contradiction. People often remembered more accurately after they were asked to separate observation from assumption. Still, the detail about the mat went on the board as unverified. It might have been moved by a shoe, the opening door, or Ama herself. A useful investigation, Badu reminded the team, did not need every ordinary thing to become a clue.

CHAPTER TWO

Five Names

By morning, the judge's death dominated the news. Some called it political revenge; others wondered whether a secret had followed him into retirement. Badu disliked the speculation. He wanted evidence, not headlines.

The judge's call records showed a recent call to the Daily Sentinel newspaper. There, Badu learned that journalist Mabel Owusu had been investigating missing public records connected to a confidential judicial appointment review. Mabel had never met the judge, she said, but she believed he knew why official documents had disappeared.

The five names were not a list of five children. They linked people who appeared in different parts of the old inquiry: the judge, Daniel Sarpong, Adwoa Sarpong, Emmanuel Badu and Mabel Owusu. Mabel recognised Daniel's name from an old file, but she could not explain why the judge had grouped them together. When Badu asked about Room Four, she answered no too quickly for him to be certain she was telling him everything.

After he left, Mabel opened an old notebook. Near the back was a date—14 August 2004—and three lines: Haven House. Five children. One name removed. The note suggested a second list, connected to the five names in the judge's hand but not identical to it. She could not remember why she had written it.

At the station, investigators found the same words, ROOM FOUR, faintly written in the judge's appointment book. The brass key did not fit any lock in his residence. Badu returned to the whiteboard and wrote one question beneath the five names: What happened on 14 August 2004?

After Badu left, Mabel went to the newspaper archive and searched her old notes. Her reporting had begun with a tip about a judicial appointment review that had been quietly closed. She had followed the trail to a children's home, then lost access to the records when a source withdrew. At the time, she had blamed exhaustion and moved to another story. Now the date in her notebook seemed to accuse her of abandoning something important.

She called the number that had sent the anonymous email. It had been disconnected. Mabel sat with the notebook open until the newsroom emptied around her. She could not recover the memory, but she could follow the evidence. If the judge had put her name beside four others, she would find out why.

Mabel met Badu in a glass-walled conference room at the Daily Sentinel. She wore the exhausted expression of someone who had spent too many nights arguing with editors and too many mornings pretending the work had not frightened her. She insisted that her investigation had concerned missing records, not the judge's private life.

"Records don't disappear by themselves," she said. "Someone changes a filing code, signs a transfer, or tells a clerk to stop asking questions. Then everyone says the file never existed."

"Who told you that?"

"No one who would put it in writing." Badu showed her the list. When she reached her own name, her thumb pressed hard against the edge of the

paper. She recovered quickly, but he noticed. He asked whether she had ever visited Haven House. She said she could not remember. The answer was honest enough to be more disturbing than a denial.

Mabel Owusu read the first reports at a small desk in the newsroom, where the air conditioner rattled above a row of battered filing cabinets. The judge’s photograph appeared on every screen: silver hair, grave eyes, a black robe that made him seem taller than he was. The headlines called him fearless. One older reporter, passing behind her, muttered that the dead were always made simpler than they had been in life.

Mabel opened a blank document and typed the five names from the police leak. She knew better than to publish a list simply because it had arrived in her inbox. A list could be bait. It could also be the only surviving outline of a story someone had tried to erase.

She searched the newsroom archive for the judge’s name and found references to a judicial appointment review from years earlier. The articles were brief, careful and strangely similar, as if each had been written from the same approved statement. There was no mention of Haven House. No mention of missing children. No explanation for why a retired judge had been reviewing an old file in the final weeks of his life.

Her editor stopped beside the desk. “If you have a connection, prove it. Don’t turn a dead man’s name into a theory.”

“I’m trying to find the connection.”

“Then start with the records, not the rumours.”

After he left, Mabel wrote the date at the top of her notebook: 14 August 2004. Under it she copied the words she had found in

an old clipping: *administrative irregularities at a residential children's facility*. She stared at the phrase until it stopped looking like ordinary bureaucratic language. It was the sort of wording that hid people inside paperwork.

She shut the notebook when a message appeared on her phone from an unknown number: *You are asking about the five names. Stop before someone decides you belong on the list.*

For a moment the newsroom noise seemed to recede. Mabel took a screenshot, forwarded it to a secure account and wrote down the time. Fear was a fact; it was not an instruction.

Mabel closed the notebook and returned to the newsroom archive. She was tired of people treating caution as a reason to do nothing. Caution, properly used, was a method: verify the date, verify the source, verify the gap. The danger lay not in asking questions, but in allowing a powerful person's silence to become the final answer.

Her editor returned before lunch and studied the timeline she had begun. "You have an old institutional story and a dead judge. What connects them now?"

"I don't know yet," Mabel said. "I know the judge was looking at the file again, and I know the date appears in more than one place."

"That is a lead, not a conclusion. Find out what he was doing in the weeks before he died."

Mabel nodded. She would trace each reference to its source before deciding what it meant.

"And keep the five names separate from the five children until you can prove how they connect," her editor added. "A similarity is not yet an explanation."

She pinned the date from August 2004 above the chart, then added only the names and events she could trace to a source.

Mabel built a timeline on the wall beside her desk. Dates ran down one side; names ran across the top. At first the chart looked empty. Then the same initials began to repeat. Agyeman had asked for a record. Asare had requested a delay. Ofori had been present when a witness was interviewed. The pattern proved no collusion, but it gave her specific questions to pursue.

Nana Serwaa showed her how to trace references across old public notices, committee minutes and court calendars. The review had not appeared in a single announcement. It had surfaced in fragments: a postponed hearing, a withdrawn recommendation, a brief correction to an official biography. Each fragment seemed harmless until placed beside the others.

“It is obvious. It is also the difference between a story you can defend and one that gets you sued.”

“That sounds obvious,” Mabel said.

The newsroom’s legal correspondent, Nana Serwaa, listened while Mabel outlined the appointment review. She did not offer a theory. Instead, she asked Mabel to distinguish between a document being missing and a document never having existed.

Nana Serwaa did not let Mabel leave the newsroom with a theory disguised as a timeline. She pulled a chair beside the wall chart and asked her to show the source for every entry. Mabel pointed to the newspaper archive, the appointment calendar and the anonymous message. Serwaa circled the message in pencil. “This is a lead about a source, not proof about the event. If we treat it as fact, whoever sent it gets to write our story for us.”

They began with the appointment review. The public calendar showed that a committee meeting had been scheduled for late August 2004, then postponed without a reason. A short notice

published two weeks later said the review had been “administratively concluded.” No names were given, and no findings were attached. Mabel found the same phrase in a later annual report, copied word for word. The repetition was not evidence of a cover-up by itself; it could have been standard wording. What mattered was that a process important enough to delay a meeting had left no accessible record of its outcome.

Serwaa searched the paper’s old clipping index while Mabel called the office that maintained public notices. The clerk who answered could confirm that the notice had been published but could not say who had supplied it. She advised Mabel to submit a written request for the source file. Mabel did so immediately, asking for the request to be stamped and dated. The clerk warned that older records sometimes took weeks to retrieve. Mabel thanked her and wrote down the reference number before ending the call.

“You see the difference?” Serwaa said. “Now we can prove we asked. We cannot yet prove why the record is absent.”

Mabel looked at the chart. “And if they say there is no source file?”

“Then we record that answer and ask who was responsible for keeping it. We do not leap from an empty shelf to a conspiracy.” Serwaa capped her pen. “The truth can survive patient questions. A weak theory cannot.”

The advice irritated Mabel because it was right. She had spent years learning how institutions used delay to exhaust people who asked difficult questions. Yet she also knew how easily a reporter could mistake suspicion for certainty, especially when the story touched something personal. She added three columns to the chart: verified, reported and unresolved. The names and dates moved between them as she checked each source.

One detail survived the exercise. A note in a clipping file recorded that a request for the Haven House incident report had been referred to a restricted annex. The note carried no author’s name, only a date stamp and a code. Mabel copied the code exactly, photographed the page and asked the archive assistant to certify that the clipping belonged to the paper’s collection. She did not remove it or mark the original.

On the walk back to her desk, she remembered a source from the previous year who had spoken about files being transferred rather than destroyed. She searched her contact list and found the number saved without a name. It rang twice before a recorded message said the number was unavailable. She did not try again. Instead, she sent a brief message asking the person to contact her through the newspaper’s secure channel if they were willing to speak on the record.

By late afternoon, the timeline had become less dramatic and more useful. It did not show who had ordered the review closed. It showed the date of the postponement, the language of the closure notice, the restricted-annex reference and the fact that the judge’s name appeared in a later request for access. Mabel printed the documents and placed them in separate sleeves. Connections were emerging, but she would not draw a line between them until she could explain what it meant.

Before leaving, Serwaa stood beside the chart and studied the five names. “Do not assume they all played the same role,” she said. “A person can be listed because they witnessed something, because they were harmed by it, because they tried to stop it—or because someone wants us to suspect them.”

Mabel’s editor asked her to prepare a short briefing for the newsroom, not a publishable article. She separated what could be said publicly—the judge had died, police were investigating, and

old records were being reviewed—from the claims that remained unverified. She left Daniel's name out of the draft until she understood why it appeared on the list. The editor read the page and asked whether withholding a name could itself distort the story. Mabel replied that identifying a person without explaining the evidence could do greater harm. They agreed to revisit the question when the records had been checked.

Nana Serwaa helped her build a source map. Each document was assigned a date, origin, custodian and limitation. The anonymous message had no verified sender. The old public notice was genuine as a published notice, but its wording did not explain what the committee had decided. The photograph had an apparent period origin, yet the annotations on its back could have been added later. Mabel disliked how many boxes were marked 'unknown', but Serwaa said that was the point of the exercise. A gap honestly recorded was more useful than a blank filled by imagination.

Before going home, Mabel called her mother and asked whether the family still kept any records from 2004. Her mother was quiet for so long that Mabel thought the line had dropped. At last she said there might be a school exercise book and a vaccination booklet in a trunk, but she did not remember what they contained. Mabel asked her not to search alone if doing so upset her; they could look together in daylight. After the call, she wrote down the exact answer rather than its tone. Fear could make a pause feel like a confession, and she would not make that mistake with her own family.

Mabel thought of the warning on her phone. You are asking about the five names. Stop before someone decides you belong on the list. She had read it as a threat. Now she wondered whether it was also an attempt to control how she understood the list. She saved the message with its timestamp, gave a copy to the editor and added a note that its sender remained unknown.

When the newsroom emptied, she returned to the question of the photograph she had not yet found among her belongings. She could not have explained why the phrase “five children” had unsettled her more than the judge’s death. It was not a memory, exactly. It was the sensation of reaching for a word that had once been familiar and finding only silence. She closed the file and went home determined to search without deciding in advance what she would discover.

Mabel's editor, Kofi, listened while she explained the five names. He drew five boxes on a legal pad and asked her to connect each person only to a document she had actually seen. The exercise was irritating because it stripped the case of its dramatic shape. It was also useful. Daniel appeared in the register and in the photograph; Adwoa appeared in a placement note; Agyeman appeared in the restricted catalogue; Emmanuel Badu appeared in a later handwritten correction. Mabel herself appeared only in the photograph and in a statement she could not remember giving. The gaps between those facts were where a reporter could easily invent a story.

Kofi refused to publish the list. He authorised a short piece confirming that the judge had been investigating missing records, but only after their lawyer reviewed the wording. Mabel objected that cautious reporting might give the people responsible time to destroy evidence. Kofi answered that a reckless allegation could give them something more valuable: a reason to dismiss every later discovery as sensationalism. He told her to keep a dated record of each contact, including messages that seemed meaningless. That night, Mabel printed the anonymous warning and placed it in a folder separate from her childhood photograph. She was beginning to understand that the case had two histories: what had happened, and what people had been taught to say happened.

Mabel began with the records most likely to be overlooked: notices of appointments, archived court circulars and the routine

correspondence that survived because nobody had considered it important enough to destroy. She worked in a quiet corner of the newsroom, making a table with three columns—document, date, and what it actually established. A name printed on a notice did not prove that its bearer had attended a meeting. A signature on a receipt did not prove that the signer had read the packet. The distinctions slowed her down, but they also protected her from publishing a claim she could not defend.

Nana Serwaa brought two paper cups of tea and studied the table. ‘You have many dates, ’ she said, ‘but not yet a story.’ Mabel agreed. The missing register mattered because it connected people who had later denied knowing one another. Yet the gap itself could have several explanations: an ordinary transfer, poor archiving, deliberate removal, or a record that had never been completed. She wrote those possibilities down rather than choosing the most dramatic one. When a junior reporter asked whether the judge’s death had confirmed a conspiracy, Mabel told him a death confirmed only that a person was dead. The rest had to be proved.

That evening, she searched the newsroom’s old correspondence archive for the first time her name had appeared beside the appointment review. She found a request for comment that had been logged but never answered. The date was familiar; she had been a young reporter, still learning which questions senior officials could make disappear without issuing a threat. The file contained no explanation for the silence. Mabel scanned the page, preserved the original reference number and sent Badu a note asking whether the request could be relevant. She did not send him her theory. She sent him the document.

The Newspaper’s Duty

Mabel’s editor, Kojo Antwi, read her notes twice and then placed them face down. ‘We can publish that the judge had contacted us, ’ he said. ‘We cannot publish that the call proves he was about to expose a conspiracy. We do not know what he intended to say.’ Mabel disliked the restraint because she could feel the story pulling together, but she knew the editor was right. She rewrote the opening to distinguish the confirmed call from her own questions. The distinction made the article less sensational and more difficult to dismiss.

A young reporter offered to search social media for anyone claiming to have worked at Haven House. Mabel asked him not to contact possible witnesses publicly. A careless message could warn the person who had kept the old records hidden, or turn a frightened former worker into a target of gossip. Instead, she prepared a list of names already present in public documents and sent formal requests for comment. Each request was logged with the time and response. The newsroom became a second kind of evidence room: less secure, but accountable for every word it released.

That evening, Mabel found a message from a reader who said the five names in the old photograph were wrong. The reader supplied no identity and no source. Mabel printed it, marked it unverified, and put it in a folder rather than following the instruction to call a number included at the bottom. The first duty of a journalist, she reminded herself, was not to chase every mystery. It was to know which mysteries could be investigated without making the people inside them less safe.

A call came from a man claiming to represent a former official. He offered an exclusive document if Mabel would publish a claim that Ofori had ordered the identity change. She asked him to send the document through a verifiable channel and

to explain how he had obtained it. He ended the call. Mabel entered the contact in her source log and told her editor. The refusal cost her a possible scoop, but it kept an untraceable accusation from becoming the spine of the article.

They checked every name against two sources where possible. The editor asked whether Daniel had agreed to be identified and whether the photograph exposed other children who had never consented to public attention. Mabel removed the faces of the children whose identities were not central to the story and recorded the reason in her notes. She knew that blurring a face could frustrate readers. It could also prevent a public investigation from becoming another act of harm against people who had been children when adults made decisions for them.

Mabel's editor placed the draft beside the newsroom's legal checklist. The first version opened with the phrase 'A judge killed to protect a secret.' Her editor circled it. They had a dead judge, missing records and several people who had reason to fear disclosure; they did not yet have proof that the murder had been committed for that reason. Mabel rewrote the opening to state what could be established and moved the theory into a paragraph clearly attributed to investigators' questions.

The Newsroom's Rules

The Call That Was Not in the File

Mabel returned to the Daily Sentinel after the newsroom had thinned to a few desks and the hum of the air conditioner. She had asked the records editor to preserve the judge's call note, but she wanted to know why the note existed at all. Agyeman had not called the paper's main line. The switchboard showed a brief connection through an old number used for confidential sources, a number that should have been retired years earlier.

The editor, Kofi, brought out a paper directory from a cabinet. Its pages had softened at the corners, and several

entries were crossed out in different inks. The number was listed beside a name that had been blacked out with marker. Kofi said the directory had survived three office moves because no one had agreed which records could safely be destroyed. ‘A newsroom is an archive by accident,’ he said. ‘We keep what we cannot explain.’

Mabel photographed the page and recorded who had handled it. She did not remove it. The directory could establish that the number had once been assigned to the confidential desk, but it could not identify the person who had used it. She knew how quickly an interesting fact became a false certainty when it entered a headline.

Kofi watched her make a second copy. ‘You are treating this like evidence for the police.’ ‘It may become evidence,’ she replied. ‘And if it doesn’t, I still need to know what it means.’ He reminded her that the paper had received legal letters before, including one from a former official who claimed that a story had ruined his career. Mabel said she would not publish the number or the obscured name until they could verify the connection. The story was not worth sacrificing a person who might have been an innocent source.

Before leaving, she asked the switchboard operator whether the old line had been forwarded. The operator searched a binder of maintenance notes and found an entry stating that calls to the confidential desk had been diverted for a short period during a building renovation. The destination number was missing from the copy. Someone had initialled the change, but the initials were not legible.

Mabel sent Badu a photograph of the entry with a note explaining its limitations. He replied that the police would seek

the original records through the proper process. Their investigations now touched the same gap from opposite directions: he had the judge’s call records; she had the newsroom’s abandoned line. Neither could yet say who had stood at the other end.

The Editor’s Conditions

Mabel's editor, Kofi Antwi, listened to her account without interrupting. When she finished, he closed the office door and asked her to separate what she had seen herself from what other people had told her. She did so on a sheet of paper, drawing a line down the middle. On one side she wrote the photograph, the anonymous message and the reference to Haven House. On the other she listed the claims that still depended on someone else's memory.

“If we publish a name, we must be able to defend why it is there,” Kofi said. “If we publish an allegation, the person accused must have a fair chance to answer it. And if a child was involved, even years ago, we do not turn that person's private life into a spectacle merely because the public is curious.” His caution irritated Mabel at first, then steadied her. The story was bigger than a headline. It could also injure people who had never chosen to be part of it.

They searched the newspaper's archive for every reference to the judicial appointment review. The first results were ordinary announcements: a meeting postponed, a panel reconstituted, a statement from the relevant office. But the dates formed an odd pattern. Two notices had been corrected after publication, and a third had disappeared from the digital index while remaining on a microfilm reel. The corrections were too small to prove a conspiracy, yet they suggested that someone had cared about the wording long after the notices were issued.

Mabel requested the original print sheets rather than relying on the online archive. The records clerk warned her that the microfilm machine sometimes distorted faint type and that a missing line could be a copying defect. She wrote that warning in her notebook. She had learned as a child that adults could use uncertainty to dismiss a truth; she had also learned that certainty could be manufactured by people who wanted a convenient answer.

Before she left, Kofi asked her to send him a brief note after every meeting and to keep copies of the source material in a secure place. He would not promise to publish the story, he said, until the evidence justified it. Mabel accepted the condition. Since the judge's death, the work had felt like chasing a warning; now it felt more like building a case that could withstand someone determined to pull it apart.

The Editor’s Rule

Mabel returned to the newsroom after the first interview with a notebook full of statements that did not fit neatly together. One witness had said the judge’s study door was locked before the housekeeper called for help. Another remembered hearing the latch after the shouting had stopped. A third was certain the corridor clock showed a quarter past nine. None of them could explain why the clock in the study had stopped several minutes earlier.

Her editor, Kwarteng, read her notes without touching the photograph she had placed beside them. ‘You have a murder, a missing file, and a man whose name appears in records that should never have met,’ he said. ‘You do not yet have a single sentence that proves they belong to the same story.’

‘They may belong to the same story even if I cannot prove it today.’

‘That is why you investigate before you publish.’ He slid the notes back. ‘A headline can turn a possibility into a verdict in the public mind. If you write that Ofori killed the judge, readers will remember the accusation long after a correction. If you write that the archive proves a conspiracy, they will not notice the word “may” buried in paragraph twelve.’

Mabel disliked being cautioned by someone who had not stood in the archive or watched Adwoa struggle to separate what she remembered from what she had been told. Yet she knew Kwarteng was right. Her own history made the temptation worse: she had spent years believing that one carefully preserved memory could correct an entire institution. Memory mattered. It was not the same as corroboration.

She divided a clean page into three columns: confirmed, reported, and unresolved. The photograph belonged in the second column until its date and source could be established. The Room Four account was a lead, not a complete reconstruction. The name Emmanuel Badu was a documented overlap, but the reason for it remained unknown. Ofori’s movements were reported by witnesses whose accounts still needed testing.

Before leaving, she asked Kwarteng to hold any headline until she had spoken to Badu. He agreed on one condition: she would not promise him silence if the evidence became public, and he would not promise her that every official source would cooperate. They were not allies in the simple sense. They were two professionals trying to keep a difficult story from becoming a convenient one.

That evening Mabel wrote the first paragraph of her article and then deleted it. It began with the judge’s death and ended by naming the man she suspected. The replacement began with a question: what happened to the record that should have explained why five children had been placed in a room and one name later disappeared? It was less dramatic. It was also closer to what she could defend.

The Cost of a Headline

At the newsroom, Mabel’s editor placed a draft headline on her desk: JUDGE’S SECRET FILE LINKED TO MURDER. It was sharp, readable and premature. Mabel crossed out the words linked to murder and replaced them with questions about the missing Haven House records. Her editor complained that readers wanted a clear accusation, not a filing history. Mabel replied that the filing history was the story. If they published a claim they could not prove, the people responsible might use the error to dismiss the evidence that was real.

She built a source table with four columns: what the source said, what could be independently checked, what remained disputed, and what would be unfair to publish. The table made the article slower to write, but it exposed how many statements depended on one person repeating what another had told them years earlier. The photograph could support a location and a possible date; it could not identify every child. The transfer form showed a movement of paper; it did not show who had ordered the change.

Her editor read the revised draft in silence. At last he asked whether caution would make the article dull. Mabel told him that a false certainty could destroy a witness’s life and the paper’s credibility at the same time. He kept the headline, but agreed to wait for a response from the officials named in the records. Mabel sent the questions through the paper’s formal channel and saved a copy of every version. After days of urgency, the story felt less like a race and more like work.

CHAPTER THREE

The Photograph

Mabel searched her old emails and found an anonymous message sent eleven months earlier: the records she wanted had not been destroyed but moved. It warned her not to trust the names on official copies and claimed that the fifth child was the reason the judge would die.

That evening, an unknown caller told her she had already forgotten once and must not make the mistake of remembering. Shaken, Mabel searched a box of childhood belongings. At the bottom was a photograph of five children outside Haven House Children's Home. She was one of them, though she had no memory of visiting the place.

Four names on the back had been crossed out. The fifth, EMMANUEL, was circled. Beneath them was the date 14 August 2004 and a message: "If the judge is dead, find the child who was never registered." The handwriting and ink looked newer than the photograph itself, suggesting that someone had added the marks and message later.

Mabel called Badu. The photograph linked her personally to the investigation, but it answered none of the most important questions. Who were the other children? Why had the names been crossed out? And what had happened that day? Badu promised to examine the photograph as evidence. Mabel understood that her investigation was no longer merely professional. Something from her own childhood had returned, and someone wanted it to remain forgotten.

That night, Mabel dreamed of a narrow corridor and a door with a number painted on it. Voices rose and fell on the other side. One voice said a name had to be removed. Another answered that a child was standing close enough to hear. She woke before dawn with the phrase still in her mind, but she could not tell whether it was memory or imagination.

She wrote the words in her notebook and underlined them once. Then she called Badu and asked him to preserve the photograph formally. She would not publish it yet. If the image was authentic, it could help identify the children; if it had been planted, publishing it could give whoever planted it exactly what they wanted.

The photograph showed the children standing beneath a sign whose paint had begun to peel. Mabel recognised the shape of her own face, but not the feeling in it. She looked solemn, almost angry, while the other children seemed to be watching someone beyond the camera. The child at the far end had been partly cut off when the photograph was printed.

She took the picture to a retired archivist who had helped her with earlier stories. He examined the paper, the fading ink and the handwriting on the back. The photograph had likely been developed in 2004, he said, but the names could have been written later. The circles and crossed-out lines were not part of the original image; they had been added with a ballpoint pen. “Someone wanted a record of the children,” he said, “but did not want all their names to survive.” Mabel asked whether that meant the photograph was

evidence. He told her it was a lead. Evidence would require a chain of custody, corroboration and someone willing to explain how it came into her possession. It was a distinction she had spent years insisting other people respect. Now she had to apply it to her own past.

The next morning, Mabel brought the photograph to the newsroom in a clean evidence sleeve. She had found it among her childhood belongings, but she did not know who had added the marks or message, or when the photograph had been placed with the family pictures.

A closer scan showed five children standing in front of a low concrete building. One girl rested a hand on another child’s shoulder; the smallest boy squinted into the sun. A tree partly obscured the sign, but the remaining letters identified Haven House. The image itself showed no names; the crossed-out names and circled “EMMANUEL” had been added to the back.

Mabel felt a pressure in her chest that was not quite memory. The girl in the photograph had her eyes, or seemed to. The angle of the face was wrong for certainty; the years had changed everything. Still, she knew the tiny scar above the child’s eyebrow. She touched her own brow without thinking.

She took the picture to an older photographer who had worked for the paper in 2004. He held it by the edges and leaned toward the light.

“This was taken on film,” he said. “Not a recent copy made to look old. The grain and the paper are consistent with the period.”

“Can you tell who took it?”

“Not from this. But the building had a side entrance. Whoever took this was standing near the gate, not inside the compound.”

Mabel asked him to scan both sides at high resolution. She kept the original in the evidence sleeve, then checked the sleeve and the storage box for any note about its earlier location. There was nothing that established who had added the writing or how the photograph had been kept for so long.

Back at her desk, she placed the photograph beside her notebook. The child’s expression was not frightened. It was watchful, as though someone had told the children to smile and one of them had decided not to pretend.

Mabel did not yet know whether she had been a witness, a victim or merely a child who had stood too close to a secret. She knew only that somebody had kept the photograph for twenty-two years—and had chosen this week to return it.

Before bed, she placed the Haven House photograph inside a folder and labelled it *Unverified personal connection*. The words looked cold on the page. They were also the only honest description she could give it.

Mabel did not accuse her. She photographed the old family pictures and put them away. Then she wrote down the conversation, including the exact question and the answer. If she was going to investigate her own history, she needed to be more rigorous, not less.

Her mother sat down. She said Mabel had spent a short period in the care of relatives while the family dealt with a difficult time. She denied knowing anything about Haven House. She spoke firmly, but not angrily. Mabel realised that she had not asked a question; she had opened a door and both of them were standing on opposite sides.

“That isn’t what I asked.”

“You were too young to remember much.”

Her mother stopped folding a cloth. The pause lasted only a second, but Mabel saw it.

“Did I ever live anywhere before I came home with you?”

The comparison was not enough to establish identity. It was enough to make her ask her mother a question she had avoided for years.

She opened a box of childhood photographs. Most were ordinary: school uniforms, birthday cakes, cousins lined up against a wall. In one, she stood beside her mother outside a rented room, wearing a yellow dress she remembered because she had spilled orange drink down the front. The scar above her eyebrow was visible. So was the same small gap between her front teeth as the girl in the Haven House photograph.

At home, Mabel set the photograph on the table and looked at it under the bright kitchen light. She had spent the day telling herself that the girl in the picture only resembled her. Now, without the newsroom noise, she could no longer dismiss the feeling as easily.

Mabel returned to the photograph the following morning with a list of questions rather than a conclusion. She had placed it in a sleeve, recorded when she had found it and noted every person who had handled it since. That record was imperfect: she could account for the previous evening, but not for the years before the photograph had appeared in the box. She wrote that limitation plainly. A careful record of what she did not know might matter as much as the image itself.

At the newspaper, the photographic desk made two high-resolution scans, one of the front and one of the reverse. The technician saved the files with the date and the equipment details,

then generated checksums so later copies could be compared with the originals. Mabel watched without touching the controls. The scan revealed no hidden writing on the front, only the uneven edge of the print and a pale mark where the paper had been pressed against something damp.

The technician warned her that the marks on the reverse could not be dated reliably from a scan. The ink looked darker in some strokes than others, but lighting, pressure and the paper’s age could all affect the appearance. Mabel asked for that uncertainty to be included in the note. She did not want a future reader to mistake “looks newer” for a scientific finding.

She called Badu and told him what had been done. He asked her to preserve the original and offered to arrange a formal examination through the police evidence unit. Mabel hesitated at the word evidence. The photograph had been part of her private belongings, and handing it over would mean surrendering the one object that seemed to connect her to the missing years. But keeping it from investigators could also weaken the inquiry. She agreed to transfer it under a written receipt and asked for a copy of every report made about it.

At home, she sat with her mother at the kitchen table. This time she did not begin by showing the picture or asking whether the woman recognised it. She asked for the names of the relatives she had stayed with as a small child, the dates of those visits and whether any family papers had been kept elsewhere. Her mother answered some questions directly and paused over others. She remembered a period when Mabel had been looked after away from home, but the dates were uncertain. She did not remember Haven House.

“I am not asking you to guess,” Mabel said. “If you don’t remember, tell me that. I need to know what you remember and what you were told later.”

Her mother folded her hands. “You were little. There were adults who said they were helping. I trusted them because I had reasons to trust them then. That does not mean I knew everything they were doing.”

“Who were they?”

“I will have to think. I don’t want to give you a name and find out I have mixed up two different visits.”

It was not the answer Mabel had wanted, but it was the first answer that did not attempt to close the subject. She wrote down the distinction after the conversation: her mother remembered a period of care by relatives and other adults; she did not confirm a stay at Haven House. The gap remained. Mabel would not fill it with an assumption simply because the photograph seemed to invite one.

Later, she compared the image with dated family photographs. The scar above the girl’s eyebrow appeared in two pictures taken years apart, but such a mark could not establish that the children were the same person. The shape of the ears and the angle of the jaw were similarly inconclusive. Mabel sent the copies to a forensic image specialist recommended by the paper, asking only whether a comparison was possible—not for a definitive identification from an old photograph.

The specialist’s reply was restrained. The images might support a qualified comparison, but differences in lighting, lens, age and pose limited what could be said. The specialist could not authenticate the names written on the back or establish who had added them. Mabel printed the response and put it with the scan record. It did not settle the question of her identity. It made clear what the next examination would need to address.

That evening, she noticed that the box of childhood belongings had been moved from the shelf where she had left it.

The lid was closed, and nothing obvious appeared to be missing. She did not assume that an intruder had entered; someone in the house might have moved it while cleaning. Still, she photographed the box in place, checked the window latches and told her editor what she had noticed. She also asked a neighbour whether anyone had come by. No one had seen a visitor.

Badu arranged for the photograph to be scanned at high resolution and recorded its condition before any further examination. The image showed five children, but the crop at the edge meant the photographer might originally have framed more people. A specialist could assess the print and paper, not identify every person from facial resemblance alone. Mabel watched the technician work and found herself wanting the scan to reveal something decisive. Instead, it revealed ordinary imperfections: dust, a crease, a faint chemical stain. The past did not become clearer simply because she wanted it to.

The technician asked where the photograph had been stored and whether anyone else could have accessed the box. Mabel described the shelf, the lid and the recent discovery that the box had moved. She was careful to distinguish the box’s position from proof of a break-in. The technician wrote down her account without embellishment. Mabel was grateful for the discipline and frustrated by it at the same time. If the photograph had been planted, the route by which it reached her mattered. If it had been kept by her family for years, that history mattered too.

That evening, she made a list of people who might have known her as a child: relatives, former teachers, neighbours and staff from any institution she had attended. She did not contact them all at once. First she asked her mother for permission to check the old family records, and then she requested her own childhood school file through the proper channel. The request felt strangely intimate, as if she were applying to meet a stranger who happened to share her face. She sealed the notebook and

decided that memory, if it returned, would have to be compared with records rather than allowed to replace them.

Badu advised her not to confront anyone or attempt to investigate a possible entry alone. He arranged for an officer to record her account and reminded her that the box’s position was an observation, not proof of interference. Mabel disliked being told to wait, but she understood the distinction. If she was to expose people who had manipulated records, she could not let fear turn every unexplained movement into a confirmed act.

Before sleeping, she copied the phrase from the photograph into her notebook: “find the child who was never registered.” She wrote two questions beneath it. Was the message an instruction left by someone who wanted the child found, or bait left by someone who wanted the police to follow a particular path? And why had the writer chosen to deliver it now, after the judge’s death? She had no answer. For the first time, she allowed the uncertainty to remain on the page without trying to solve it before morning.

The next morning, Mabel visited the studio named on the photograph's paper sleeve. The shop had changed owners twice, and its present proprietor kept old customer ledgers in a cupboard because no one had told him they were disposable. He allowed her to examine the entries under supervision. The date on the photograph did not appear, but a batch number led to a receipt issued three days later. That did not prove when the picture had been taken; film could be developed long after exposure. Still, it gave her a traceable starting point. She photographed the ledger page with permission and recorded the proprietor's name and the time of the visit.

Outside, she called Badu and explained the distinction between the date written on the photograph and the date on the processing receipt. He thanked her for not treating them as interchangeable. When she returned to the newsroom, a message

waited from an address made of random letters. It contained no threat, only a sentence: The fifth child was not the only child who was renamed. Mabel forwarded it to the investigator and resisted the urge to answer. The message might have come from a witness, a prankster or someone attempting to scatter their attention. She added it to the chronology with a note: source unknown; claim unverified.

The photograph looked different under a proper light. Its edges had yellowed, and the faces at the back of the group were blurred by the limitations of the camera, but the date written on the reverse remained legible. Mabel photographed both sides, then placed the print in a protective sleeve. She noted who had handled it and when. Daniel watched the procedure with impatience that he tried to disguise as indifference. To him, the picture was not an exhibit. It was one of the few objects that suggested his childhood had belonged to a real sequence of events.

‘If it proves nothing, why keep it?’ he asked. Mabel answered that a document could be valuable without proving the first thing someone believed about it. The photograph might establish that certain people were present together; it could not, by itself, establish what they knew or why they had gathered. Daniel turned away. He had spent years treating the blank spaces in his history as a personal failure, as though he should have remembered what adults had hidden from him. Mabel told him that memory was not a test he had failed. Records could be manipulated, and children depended on adults to tell them the truth.

A conservator later confirmed that the paper stock was consistent with the period, but that finding did not authenticate the handwriting on the reverse. The note could have been added years afterward. Mabel included that qualification in her file. The detail disappointed Daniel, yet it also changed the question. Instead of asking whether the photograph proved the secret, they

now needed to learn who had written the note, when it had been added, and whether the original negative or another print survived.

The Photograph Under Light

The forensic imaging specialist examined the photograph under several wavelengths and produced a report describing what the process could and could not reveal. The image had been folded, exposed to humidity and handled many times. A pale rectangle on the back might have been left by a label, but there was no reliable way to reconstruct the words that had once been there. Mabel was disappointed until the specialist explained that the paper stock and the stamp could still be compared with other material from the institution. A photograph could be weak evidence of a name and useful evidence of a place and time.

Badu arranged a comparison with a dated group photograph held in a former staff member’s album. The curtains, floor tiles and damaged window latch matched. The match strengthened the conclusion that both pictures came from Haven House, but it did not prove that every child had been identified correctly. Daniel studied the images without touching them. He recognised the green door and the narrow strip of light beneath it, then admitted that he could not remember who had stood beside him. His uncertainty was entered into the notes as carefully as his recognition.

When Mabel asked whether the photograph should be published, Daniel said he did not want his childhood used as a puzzle for strangers. She agreed that the original image would remain with the investigators and that any public version would need a clear reason. It was the first time Daniel had set a condition and seen an adult accept it without bargaining. That small change mattered to him more than the laboratory report. The investigation was about restoring a record, but it could not restore dignity by taking away his choices again.

Outside, Daniel asked whether finding a second copy would prove which child he had been. Mabel said it could help establish where the photograph came from and who had handled it, but the faces and dates would still need corroboration. Daniel absorbed the answer quietly. He had once believed a document would settle everything. Now he understood that a reliable record was not a magic object; it was a claim that had to survive questions.

They photographed the inventory entry and requested permission to inspect the surviving boxes with the family present. The nephew insisted that no original leave the shop until an archivist could identify it. Mabel agreed. She had learned that possession was not the same as ownership and that an image could be genuine while a story attached to it was false. The job number might lead to a negative, or it might lead to a blank sleeve and another dead end.

Mabel visited the photographer’s former shop, now operated as a phone-repair business by his nephew. The nephew remembered boxes of negatives stored above the ceiling before a leak damaged the room. He would not promise that the Haven House image survived. With Mabel watching, he checked an old inventory book and found a reference to a contact sheet made during the August 2004 visit. The entry included no names, only a job number and the words ‘five children—office copy.’

The Photograph’s Other Copy

The Photograph’s Missing Frame

Mabel took the childhood photograph to a professional lab that still processed old prints. The technician, a quiet woman named Esi, placed it under a magnifier and examined the edges before discussing the faces. The paper had been cut unevenly along the right side. A faint strip of adhesive suggested that the print might once have been mounted beside another photograph or fixed inside a file.

‘I can tell you it was trimmed, ’ Esi said. ‘I cannot tell you who trimmed it or what was removed.’ She photographed the front and back, then made a high-resolution scan. Under angled light, a shallow impression appeared beneath the handwritten date. It resembled part of a number, but the strokes were too incomplete to read.

Mabel asked whether the image could be enhanced. Esi explained that contrast adjustments might reveal details already present, but they could not recover information that the photograph did not contain. She kept the original untouched and saved each digital version with a note describing the changes. Mabel appreciated the discipline. In her profession, people often wanted a picture to confess more than it knew.

On the way home, Mabel stopped at the building where she had lived as a child. The caretaker did not remember her family, but an older neighbour recalled a week when adults had come to the flat asking questions about a missing file. The neighbour could not remember the exact date. She remembered only that one visitor had carried a brown envelope and that Mabel’s mother had refused to let him inside.

The neighbour’s recollection was useful precisely because it was incomplete. Mabel wrote it down as an unverified account and asked whether the woman would speak to an investigator. The woman hesitated, then agreed to consider it after talking to her children. She did not want to be drawn into a dispute between officials she had never understood.

That night, Mabel placed the photograph, the lab report and the neighbour’s contact details in separate sleeves. The cut edge might connect the image to a larger document, but it could also be an ordinary act of trimming. The real lead was not the mysterious impression. It was the possibility that the photograph

had once belonged to a file that someone had carried from one office to another.

That evening, Mabel wrote two columns in her notebook: what the photograph supported, and what it did not. It supported a plausible connection to the Haven House building. It did not establish the date, the identity of every child, the reason the photograph had been taken, or the identity of the person who had sent it. The distinction felt slow and unsatisfying. It also kept the investigation from becoming another story built on a confident guess.

She contacted the former printer listed in the annual report’s production notes. The man remembered the job because the photographs had arrived late and the director of the home had insisted that the captions be changed before printing. He could not recall the wording of the first captions, nor could he say whether the children in the newly received photograph were the same children. He did remember that the final proof had been approved by a person from an office outside the home. His memory was old, and Mabel marked it as such. She asked whether he had kept any proofs or invoices. He promised to look, but warned that his business had moved twice and that many files had been discarded.

“I know,” Mabel replied. “But it may tell us where to ask the next question.”

“If this is from the same building, it still does not tell us when it was taken,” Tetteh said. “And if it is from the same day, it does not tell us what happened before or after.”

Tetteh searched the paper’s physical archive for the annual report. The relevant issue had survived in a bound volume, its

pages brittle and marked by old adhesive. A photograph on page twelve showed the same corridor, though taken from the opposite end. The floor tiles and window frames appeared similar. Mabel recorded the publication date and the page number, then photographed the comparison with a ruler beside the print for scale. She made two copies and labelled them separately so that the original would not become a working surface for every person who wanted to inspect it.

Under a magnifying lamp, the image resolved into a corridor, a doorway and a group of children standing in a loose line. The print was faded at the edges. One child’s face was turned away; another was partly hidden behind an adult’s sleeve. At the far end, a door bore a small rectangular sign. The lettering was too soft to read, but the shape matched the sign visible in a photograph from Haven House’s old annual report. Mabel resisted the urge to call the resemblance proof. It was a comparison worth checking, not a conclusion.

The archive manager, Mr Tetteh, had worked at the Daily Sentinel long enough to distrust any object that appeared at precisely the moment a story needed it. He examined the sleeve rather than touching the print. There was no return address on the envelope, only a postmark blurred by rain. The stamp was ordinary. The envelope had not been sealed with tape, and its flap showed no obvious sign of being opened and closed again. None of those details identified a sender. They only narrowed what Mabel could responsibly say.

Mabel did not take the photograph straight to the newsroom the next morning. She placed it in a clean paper sleeve, wrote the date and time of receipt on a separate evidence note, and asked the newspaper’s archive manager to witness the opening of the envelope in which it had arrived. The procedure was not a police chain of custody, and she did not pretend it was. It was simply a

way to preserve what she had received and to make later claims about its handling more honest.

The Photograph’s Journey

A Photograph’s Chain of Custody

Mabel took the original photograph to a preservation specialist recommended by the newspaper’s legal adviser. The specialist handled it with cotton gloves, recorded its dimensions and photographed both sides before placing it in a clear sleeve. She explained that the marks on the back might have been made at different times. The date could be contemporary with the image, or added years later by someone trying to identify it. Even the paper stock offered only a range, not a calendar date precise enough to settle the question.

Mabel watched as the specialist compared the image with a scan from the newspaper archive. A crease crossed the wall behind the children in both copies, but one version had a faint border that the other lacked. The specialist said this could result from cropping or copying, not necessarily tampering. Mabel wrote the explanation in her notebook rather than the more dramatic theory that first came to mind. If the image was to matter in court, its history would matter as much as its contents.

Before leaving, she signed a receipt confirming that the photograph remained her property and that the specialist had made a working scan. She asked whether the image could be enhanced to reveal a face in the corridor. The specialist said enhancement might clarify contrast but could not create information that was not present. Mabel left with no new identification, only a better description of what the image could and could not prove. That was less satisfying than a revelation, but it was honest.

CHAPTER FOUR

The Name Beneath the Ink

Badu and Mabel compared the photograph with the surviving records. The date on the back matched an entry in the judge's restricted files. A catalogue at the records office referred to a Haven House incident report personally restricted by Justice Agyeman. The report itself was missing, but an annex was listed in a government archive.

The brass key opened a cabinet in a disused archive. Inside lay an old register wrapped in brown paper. On the page dated 14 August 2004, five children were listed. One name had been scraped away and replaced with EMMANUEL BADU. Beneath the overwritten ink, the original name remained legible: EMMANUEL SARPONG. Later records linked that child to the person who grew up using the name Daniel Sarpong, though the surviving documents did not explain every step in the change.

Badu felt the discovery like a blow. Emmanuel Badu was his late father's name. The altered entry did not prove that his father had changed it; someone might have used the name to misdirect investigators or to hide the child's identity. What it proved was that the name had been inserted into a record connected to Haven House, and that the judge had later restricted the file that might explain why.

Among the papers, separate from the register, was a sealed envelope addressed to Kwame Badu, marked to be opened if the truth ever came looking for him. An archive intake slip showed that Emmanuel Badu had deposited it under restricted access in 2008. Inside, his father warned that official seals did not guarantee honest records and that the person who kept a secret was not necessarily the person who created it. The handwriting was familiar from birthday cards and notes left on the kitchen

table. His father had known enough to be afraid, but the letter made no direct accusation and offered no clear account of his own part.

The archive clerk, Mrs Nartey, said she had been told not to discuss the annex. An old access log showed that someone had enforced the restriction, but the signature was smudged and she could not identify the visitor. Badu photographed the pages, recorded the register’s condition and requested an independent document examination. He also logged his family connection with his superior and asked another officer to verify the relevant personnel records.

The document examiner arrived two days later with a portable case, a camera and a set of gloves. Badu had arranged the examination through his superintendent, making certain that the request recorded his relationship to the name written across the register. He watched from the other side of the table while the examiner checked the seal on the evidence envelope and compared its number with the receipt. The process seemed slow beside the urgency of the case, but Badu knew that a discovery which could not be defended in court might become another rumour buried in a file.

The examiner photographed the page under ordinary light first, then under angled illumination that made the scraped fibres more visible. She did not promise that the original name could be recovered in full. Some of the ink had penetrated the paper; some of the surface had been damaged. The surviving strokes were consistent with the letters Badu and Mabel had noticed, but she explained that a consistent reading was not the same as identifying the person who had written them. She would need to compare the writing with known samples and report the limits of the comparison.

“Can you tell us who altered it?” Badu asked.

“Not from the page alone,” she said. “I can describe the alteration, assess the sequence of the marks and compare handwriting if you provide suitable samples. I cannot tell you what the writer intended, and I cannot turn an uncertain letter into a certain name simply because the case needs an answer.”

The caution disappointed him, though he respected it. He had seen witnesses pushed toward certainty by questions that already contained the answer. He asked her to record the difference between what was visible, what was probable and what could not be established. She added the request to her notes and sealed the register again after the photographs were taken.

Mabel received permission to inspect a certified image at the public counter. She had hoped the photograph would settle the matter, but the magnified image made the alteration look both clearer and less conclusive. The original name was legible enough to justify further inquiry; it was not enough to prove Daniel’s identity without corroboration. She wrote that distinction at the top of her notebook so she would not forget it when the story became more dramatic in the telling.

At the archive exit, the man with the newspaper had disappeared. Mabel asked the clerk whether visitors were required to sign in. The clerk said researchers signed the public register, while officials with restricted access used a separate book kept by the supervisor. Mabel requested the public entry for the day and noted that the restricted book was not available to her. She did not accuse the clerk of hiding anything. Instead, she sent her editor a written request for the archive’s access policy and asked the paper’s lawyer to advise on a formal information request.

That evening, Badu and Mabel compared their notes in a crowded café, choosing a table within view of the entrance. They agreed on the central fact and listed their differences. Badu had the original register and a chain-of-custody record; Mabel had the catalogue trail and her own observations. Neither had proof of who made the alteration. They decided to keep their materials separate but cross-check dates and names, so one person’s recollection would not quietly become the other person’s evidence.

Before they left, Mabel asked whether Badu could continue investigating his father’s connection. He told her he had disclosed it and requested independent oversight. “That doesn’t remove the conflict,” she said. “No,” he replied. “It means other people can see where it is and check my work.” By then, she felt the investigation might survive the pressure gathering around it. It would have to be disciplined enough to withstand not only the people who wanted the truth hidden, but also the people who wanted the truth to be simpler than it was.

Mabel pursued the same trail from the public catalogue. A clerk eventually allowed her to inspect the register under supervision. The scraped paper and overwritten surname suggested deliberate alteration; cramped initials and a transfer note were not enough to identify the person responsible. She requested a certified image and the access history, insisting that the date of her request be recorded even if the archive took weeks to respond.

The archive supervisor met Badu and Mabel in a room where no original document could leave the table. He explained that the register had been moved twice during reorganisations, and that some transfer sheets had been indexed by the office that sent them rather than the office that received them. The system was

imperfect, but imperfection did not by itself prove a plot. Badu asked for the names of the staff who had signed each movement. The supervisor agreed to provide a certified list and warned that one signature was too faint to identify without comparison material.

They examined the altered entry beside an earlier page whose ink had not been disturbed. The pressure marks on the paper suggested that writing had once been present where the surname was now obscured, but the examiner could not yet reconstruct the original letters. Mabel asked whether the alteration could have been a routine correction. The supervisor said corrections were allowed, but should be dated, initialled and supported by a source document. This entry did not show a clear correction note. It was a procedural irregularity, not yet proof of who had caused it.

Outside the archive, Badu asked Mabel what she thought the evidence meant. She said the system had accepted a name without preserving a clear explanation for it. Badu agreed, but pointed out that a missing explanation could have several causes: deliberate concealment, negligent recordkeeping or a later transfer that lost the supporting paper. They would investigate each possibility. Mabel wrote down his wording, then added her own reminder: the question was not merely who had written over the name, but who had benefited when everyone else stopped asking.

On her way out, Mabel noticed a man near the entrance pretending to read a newspaper. He lowered it as she passed. She did not confront him. Outside, she wrote down his clothing, approximate age and the time, sent the note to her editor and arranged to leave with a colleague. The observation was troubling, but she treated it as a lead rather than proof that the man was connected to the case.

By evening, the altered surname appeared in both Mabel’s notes and Badu’s evidence file. They had reached the same discovery by separate routes. The register established that a child’s identity had been changed; it did not yet establish who ordered the change, why the name Emmanuel Badu had been used, or whether the detective’s father had consented to it. Those questions would have to be answered by more than the ink on one page.

The archive supervisor refused to let Badu handle the register without a second officer present. A camera recorded the examination, and every page turned was entered on a handling sheet. The procedure slowed the work, but Badu welcomed the delay. If the register was challenged later, its value would depend partly on whether anyone could show that it had been altered after discovery. The examiner compared the scraped entry under magnification and found pressure marks from an earlier inscription. The letters were not all recoverable, and the examiner would not claim that the visible traces alone identified a person. The surviving sequence was consistent with the name already found beneath the replacement ink.

Badu asked whether the page had been replaced. The examiner said the binding and paper edges offered no immediate sign of substitution, but a full assessment would require comparison with the register's manufacture and other pages. A conclusion would come later. On the drive back, Badu kept thinking about his father's name written where another child's name should have been. He had to remind himself that a name on a page could indicate a deliberate substitution without explaining who ordered it. He wrote three questions in his notebook: who made the change, who approved it, and who benefited from it? Until those questions were answered separately, the discovery would remain powerful but incomplete.

The document examiner did not announce a conclusion after a single glance. She placed the register under magnification,

compared the disputed entry with the surrounding lines and asked for the original binding, not merely a scan. Ink could be compared, paper fibres examined and the sequence of entries assessed, but no instrument could answer every question. A later addition might be detected without identifying the person who made it. A signature might be genuine while the statement above it was false. Badu listened as the examiner described what each test could and could not establish.

The archive supervisor produced a movement ledger from a locked cabinet. Several entries were neat and complete; others recorded only a department, not an individual. One line showed a packet transferred on a date that matched the altered register. The receiving signature was partly obscured by a fold. The supervisor said the fold had been there when the ledger was found. Badu asked that the book be photographed before anyone attempted to flatten it. The original would remain in controlled storage, and the team would work from a verified copy unless a further examination required otherwise.

The examiner’s preliminary note was cautious: the disputed entry appeared to have been made separately from the surrounding entries, but the available sample was insufficient to date the ink precisely. It was a lead, not a verdict. Badu copied the wording into his notebook without sharpening it. A qualified finding might sound weak at a press conference, Badu knew, but its strength lay in surviving challenge. The question was no longer simply who had altered the register. It was who had possessed the register, who had authority to change it, and who benefited from the altered identity.

The Register Examination

The document examiner laid the register beside the duplicate page recovered from the annex. Under magnification, the ink strokes showed different pressure and a slight variation in the way the number seven was formed. Those features were

consistent with more than one writer, but the examiner refused to name a person from handwriting alone. The paper had also been cut and reattached along one edge. That suggested deliberate handling, yet the examiner warned that alteration could have occurred during copying or later storage. Badu asked for the report to state each conclusion separately so that a strong finding would not lend false certainty to a weaker one.

An archivist explained the old filing system: entries were copied by hand, bundles were tied with cotton tape, and transfers were sometimes logged in a separate ledger. The system was imperfect, but imperfection did not mean every missing page had been stolen. The team compared the register number with a surviving receipt and found a sequence gap. A receipt for the same date had been filed under a neighbouring case reference. The mistake could have been routine, or it could have been a way to hide the transfer. The next step was to find who had authorised the filing and who had access to the shelf.

Badu refused to let the discovery become a headline before the provenance was secure. He asked the archive to provide a signed account of how the register had been stored and who had handled it since recovery. Mabel watched him seal the evidence bag and realised that the slow work was not an obstacle to the story. It was the only thing that might allow the story to survive a challenge in court.

Mabel noticed a tiny pencil mark beside the number five. The examiner photographed it under magnification but declined to identify it as a symbol. It might be a page reference, a clerk’s mark or a later annotation. Badu ordered no one to erase or clean the page. The team now had a procedure for dealing with uncertainty: preserve the mark, document its location and let a qualified examiner compare it with known examples.

Badu asked the supervisor to explain the old system rather than interpret it for him. Entries were sometimes copied into a daily book before being transferred into the permanent register.

A missing daily book could therefore create a gap without proving that the permanent entry was invented. The team requested the storage list, the transfer receipts and the audit report from the year the books were moved. Each request was logged separately so that an unanswered request would not be mistaken for a negative finding.

The archive supervisor arranged a supervised comparison of the disputed register with the duplicate index. Two staff members read the entries aloud while a third recorded the page numbers and photographed each opening. The disputed line was not the only irregularity. Several corrections had been made in different inks, and one page carried a pencil notation that did not appear in the official index. The examiner warned that different ink could reflect routine work performed on different days; it could not, by itself, establish tampering.

The Archive’s Second Register

A Register Under Examination

The archive supervisor would not allow Badu to handle the register again until a conservator had assessed its condition. The book was placed on a foam cradle beneath a camera, its cover supported so the spine would not bear its own weight. Each page was photographed under ordinary light before any special examination. The conservator explained that ink could appear different because of age, paper treatment, pressure from the writing instrument or the angle of the light. A darker line did not automatically mean a later hand.

Mabel watched the process from the other side of the table. She had expected the examination to reveal a dramatic mark, something like a signature hidden beneath a fingerprint. Instead, the conservator spoke in cautious measurements. The disputed entry had been scraped or abraded, but the paper fibres were not uniform across the damaged area. Some marks could have

resulted from erasure; others might have come from the page being pressed against a rough surface while the book was closed.

“Can you tell us who changed it?” Badu asked. The conservator shook her head. She could describe the physical alteration and compare writing features, but she could not identify a person from the damage alone. A qualified handwriting examiner would need known samples, and even then the conclusion might be limited. Badu requested a formal report and asked that the original remain sealed whenever it was not under examination.

The archive's access ledger created a separate problem. Three entries used the same abbreviated initials, but the ink and handwriting differed. The clerk who had copied the ledger into a digital system admitted that he had expanded the initials from a staff list, not from an identification document. His software record was therefore an interpretation of the old book, not an independent confirmation of it.

Badu ordered both versions preserved. He knew the mistake could be innocent, but the distinction mattered. If investigators treated a modern transcription as proof of who had entered the archive, they might build their entire timeline on an assumption made by a clerk years later. The register remained a powerful clue, but it was not a confession, and it could not speak beyond the limits of its paper.

The Archivist’s Objection

The archive supervisor formally objected when a junior officer described the altered register as a forged original. She said the team had not yet established which version had been created first or whether the surviving volume had been rebound. Her objection irritated Badu because it sounded like delay, but she brought out a catalogue card showing that the register had been repaired after water damage. The repair record did not explain the scraped entry. It did explain why a page edge and a

binding mark could not be treated as proof of when the alteration occurred.

The supervisor arranged a meeting with the conservator, the document examiner and the officer responsible for the evidence log. They agreed to describe the physical findings in separate language: the paper had been abraded; replacement ink appeared on the affected line; the handwriting comparison was inconclusive; and the repair history complicated any claim about sequence. No one was permitted to write that Ofori had altered the register unless evidence could connect him to the act itself.

Badu accepted the wording and asked for a signed copy. The supervisor, who had expected another argument, looked at him more carefully. “You understand that accuracy can protect the guilty as well as the innocent,” she said. “It can also stop you accusing the wrong person.” Badu answered that he understood. On the drive back, he considered how often a correct procedure felt like an obstacle when it was actually the only thing preventing the case from becoming another unreliable official story.

CHAPTER FIVE

The First Lie

Badu's father's letter described a meeting after the Haven House incident. Several people had agreed to preserve an account that was not entirely true. The letter did not identify who ordered the change. It did insist that the child must not be blamed for the identity assigned to him.

Badu searched his father's old diary. Several pages from 2004 had been carefully removed. The surviving entries referred to Daniel Sarpong, Adwoa Sarpong and an officer identified as K. B. M. One entry said the judge had insisted that the record remain sealed, supposedly to prevent further harm. Badu could not tell whether his father had helped conceal the truth, tried to resist it, or been trapped between the two.

Badu laid the diary beside his father's letter and the photograph from Haven House. He had expected the objects to fit together like pieces of a puzzle. Instead, they raised more questions. The letter warned him not to confuse the keeper of a secret with its author. The diary named people but omitted the very pages that might have explained what they had done. The photograph showed five children, yet even the child he suspected was Daniel could not be identified from the image alone.

He called his aunt, who had helped clear his father's house after the funeral. She remembered the diary but not the missing pages. His father had kept old notebooks in a locked drawer and disliked anyone rearranging them. She also remembered that, in the final years of his life, he had received occasional calls that left him quiet for the rest of the evening. She could not say who called or what was discussed. Badu asked her to write down what

she remembered in her own words, without trying to fill the gaps for him.

The next morning he took the diary to the document examiner. She inspected the binding and the edges of the remaining pages, then explained that the missing leaves had been removed with care. The binding showed no clear sign of a recent tear, but the diary had been handled and stored for years. She could not date the removal from appearance alone. Badu asked her to preserve the physical findings and avoid conclusions about motive. The missing pages were a lead, not a confession.

His superintendent called him in after reviewing the disclosure form. The superintendent was direct: Badu could not be the sole officer deciding which evidence concerning his father was relevant, and he could not interview relatives without another investigator present if their accounts became material to the case. Badu agreed. He asked that the independent officer receive copies of the diary, letter and register report, and that every later decision about those items be documented. It was humiliating to be reminded of rules he taught younger officers, but he knew the rules mattered most when they inconvenienced him.

On his way out, he passed the case board. The names seemed less like suspects than a map of overlapping loyalties. Agyeman had restricted the report. Asare had signed an appointment-review document. Ofori had handled a witness statement. Mensah had retained copies. His father’s name appeared in the altered register, but that could mean involvement, misuse or an attempt to protect someone. Badu added a column marked “What would disprove this?” and wrote a question beside each connection. He wanted the investigation to be capable of proving him wrong.

The unknown caller's warning arrived again that night, this time as a short message from an unregistered number: Some debts are inherited. Badu forwarded it to the technical unit and did not reply. The wording could have referred to the case, his family, or nothing more than an attempt to unsettle him. He resisted the urge to interpret it as a hidden confession. Whoever sent it wanted him to feel that his father's past belonged to him. Badu decided he would answer with records, not fear.

Before sleeping, he read the letter once more. His father had not asked him to defend the family name. He had warned him that a name could be used as a shelter for one person and a cage for another. Badu placed the letter in a clear evidence sleeve and wrote a note for the independent investigator: no conclusion should be drawn from the family connection until the original records and the testimony of other participants had been tested. It was the first instruction in the case that cost him something personally, and the first one that made him feel he was finally doing the work properly.

K. B. M. proved to be retired Inspector K. B. Mensah, whose service file had been restricted after an internal review. The appointment-review documents also referred to a witness whose identity had been removed from accessible copies. Badu placed Mensah's name on the case board, alongside Deputy Commissioner Asare and Yaw Ofori, but marked each connection according to its strength: confirmed, reported or unverified.

That night an unknown caller warned Badu not to damage the reputation of a dead man who had once tried to protect him. The caller also referred to his other parent, though Badu could not tell whether this was a genuine warning or a tactic designed to unsettle him. He recorded the call and sent it to the technical unit. It suggested that someone was monitoring the investigation; it did not establish who had made the call.

The independent officer assigned to review Badu's family connection interviewed him as a witness before discussing the contents of his father's service file. Badu answered questions about his father's posting, the period when the diary pages were missing and the first time he had heard the name Daniel Sarpong. He did not try to interpret the gaps. The officer recorded that Badu had no direct knowledge of the 2004 transfer and had disclosed his personal interest voluntarily. The process felt cold, but its coldness reassured him: the inquiry was no longer relying on his private judgement alone.

At home, Badu laid out the surviving diary pages in date order. The entries did not form a complete narrative. A note about a meeting was followed by a shopping list; a reference to a child appeared beside an unrelated duty reminder. He had once read the fragments as clues deliberately left for him. Now he considered the possibility that he was imposing a pattern on ordinary notes. He photographed each page, numbered the images and sent copies to the examiner. The original remained untouched in a protective sleeve.

His aunt called after learning that investigators had requested the family records. She was angry that his father's name had become public conversation, but she did not ask him to stop. She said the old man had believed that keeping quiet could prevent a young person from being harmed. Badu asked whether his father had ever explained whom he meant. She answered that he had not. Badu recorded the statement with her consent, then asked whether she would be willing to repeat it formally. She said yes, though she could not promise the memory would become clearer under questioning.

The diary's missing pages might contain useful impressions, so Badu asked a document examiner to inspect the binding and the pages beneath. He also requested a formal review of his father's service history.

His superintendent warned him that a family connection could compromise the investigation if it was not disclosed. Badu agreed and asked for independent oversight. “It already is personal,” he said, “but that does not make the evidence less real.”

On the case board he added a separate heading: PEOPLE WHO KNEW. The person who altered the register might not be the person who murdered Agyeman. The person who concealed the record might not have created the original lie. Badu decided that every new fact would be tested against those distinctions, even if the answers became harder to bear.

The document examiner returned the diary with a short preliminary note. The pages had been removed cleanly, but the binding showed no evidence of a recent tear. The examiner could not establish when the pages had been taken or by whom. Badu read the note twice. It denied him the neat answer he had secretly hoped for, but it also protected him from building a case on an assumption. He placed the diary in a sealed evidence bag and arranged for an independent officer to catalogue his father's service papers. From that point, Badu would not keep original documents at home or examine them without a witness.

That evening, he visited his father's old colleague, retired Sergeant Lartey, who agreed to speak only after Badu explained that he was gathering background rather than asking him to identify a suspect. Lartey remembered Emmanuel Badu as a careful officer who disliked signing a document he had not read. He also remembered a period when his friend became unusually quiet and began refusing invitations. Lartey had never heard him confess to changing a child's identity. He had once heard him say, ‘A signature can make a lie look official.’ Badu wrote the words down but did not present them as proof. They were a recollection from years ago, without a date or context. They might help explain his father; they could not decide the case.

Badu returned to his father’s diary with a different question. He no longer asked whether the missing pages contained a confession; he asked what ordinary habits might explain their absence. His aunt remembered that his father sometimes removed pages to give a child a clean sheet for schoolwork, but she could not recall him doing so from the diary. She also remembered him keeping loose papers inside the back cover. That detail had seemed insignificant when Badu was younger. Now it offered a practical possibility: the pages might have been separated from the book rather than torn away and destroyed.

They searched the family’s stored boxes together, labelling each container before opening it. Inside an old envelope were receipts, a faded photograph and a list of telephone numbers written in his father’s hand. None referred directly to Haven House. One number, however, matched a contact on a retired office directory. Badu photographed the list and recorded where it had been found. His aunt watched him work and asked whether the investigation had made him distrust his father. He said distrust was not the same as refusing to ask questions. If his father had been involved, he needed to know the extent of it; if he had been used by others, that too deserved the truth.

The directory entry belonged to a former records clerk who had died several years earlier. It could lead nowhere, but Badu refused to dismiss it because the person could no longer be questioned. He asked the team to check whether the clerk had left a family archive or deposited papers with a public institution. He also told his superintendent that he would not personally handle any evidence recovered from his father’s possessions. The boundary was uncomfortable, but necessary. A detective investigating family history had to be more careful than anyone else about confusing emotional certainty with proof.

The Aunt’s Boundary

Badu’s aunt asked him to meet her at the family house rather than discuss his father over the telephone. She had kept a small tin of letters and receipts that she had never considered important enough to catalogue. Before handing it over, she wanted him to promise that he would not turn every family memory into evidence against his father. Badu told her he could not promise that, but he could promise to label memories as memories and documents as documents.

Inside the tin were birthday cards, bank slips, an expired staff identity card and a letter from a colleague whose name appeared in the old review file. Nothing was a confession. One receipt showed that his father had travelled to the district office in the week after the Haven House incident, but it did not establish why. His aunt remembered him returning tired and unusually quiet. She had assumed a work dispute was responsible because he refused to explain himself.

Badu recorded the source of each item and asked his aunt to write down the memory in her own words before discussing the documents further. She found the request cold, then admitted it was fair. She did not want her affection to become a shield for him, and he did not want his suspicion to become a verdict on her. When he left, she kept the tin at home and allowed the investigators to take certified copies of the relevant papers. The boundary was painful, but it kept their relationship from being swallowed by the case.

Retired Inspector K. B. Mensah watched the news of Agyeman’s death in silence. He had spent years trying to put Haven House behind him, but the judge’s face brought back the meeting in which Agyeman argued that some truths could damage innocent people. Mensah had disagreed. His career had never recovered from the inquiry that followed.

An anonymous caller warned him to remain silent. Mensah answered that a child’s name had been changed and silence had protected no one. He retrieved a personal file containing copies of documents bearing the signatures of Agyeman and Deputy Commissioner Asare. The papers suggested that senior officials had managed the official account, though they did not reveal who first proposed the alteration.

Badu arranged to meet Mensah at a café. The retired inspector confirmed that five children had been connected to the Haven House incident and that records were changed after an initial report was submitted. Before he could explain more, he received a message and abruptly left. Beneath his untouched tea, Badu found a note with only two words: Find Adwoa.

Badu later visited Mensah at home. The sitting room was crowded with newspapers and old court calendars. Mensah unlocked a metal box containing photocopies, a carbon sheet and a photograph of officials outside a government building. The papers had been wrapped carefully and labelled with the year 2004.

“I kept copies because the official file changed after the inquiry,” Mensah said. “Pages were renumbered. A witness statement vanished. The final report made it look as if everyone had agreed.” He could not say who had ordered the changes. He had memories and documents,

he explained, but not the authority to make the country believe him.

Badu photographed the papers and asked Mensah to distinguish what he had seen from what he had heard. One sheet contained Adwoa Sarpong's old address and the note: She took the boy home. She knows what the register cannot tell you. Another photograph showed Yaw Ofori at the edge of a group of officials. Its date placed Ofori near the inquiry, but it did not prove that he had altered the record.

Mensah agreed to give a sworn statement if an independent officer recorded it. He admitted that he had once challenged the officer who prepared the final report. The man had said the matter was settled and reopening it would harm people who had done nothing wrong. Mensah had a family, a career and a pension to lose. The threat had not needed to be explicit.

When Badu returned with a list of dates, Mensah corrected one important point. The meeting had taken place on the night of 13 August, not the night of the 14th; the register was changed the following morning. The correction made the timeline more precise, but Mensah still could not identify the person who gave the order. He promised to attend a formal interview the next day.

Badu returned to the station with Mensah's papers sealed in a clear evidence envelope. He had photographed them at the retired inspector's home, but photographs were not a substitute for originals. He logged the time of receipt, listed every sheet, and asked an officer unconnected with the investigation to witness the seal. The procedure seemed slow beside the urgency of the case. That was why he followed it. A defence lawyer would be entitled to challenge any document that appeared to have passed through too many hands.

The oldest page was a carbon copy of a report about Haven House. Its top corner had been torn away, removing part of the

reference number. The typed summary described a routine review of children’s placements. In the margin, someone had written, ‘Five interviewed separately; accounts do not match.’ A second hand had drawn a line through the sentence. The ink was darker than the typewriter ribbon and the stroke crossed a later date stamp, suggesting that the deletion had not been made when the report was first prepared.

Badu asked the records officer to compare the page with the surviving register. The officer warned him that old government files were often copied, re-bound and re-numbered; a mismatch alone did not establish deliberate tampering. They would need to identify the document’s origin, compare paper and typewriter features, and locate the corresponding entry in the archive. Badu added each task to the case log. The file was beginning to tell a story, but it was not yet telling him who had written it.

At the formal interview the following morning, Mensah arrived with his own lawyer and a list of dates he had prepared overnight. He was less certain than he had sounded in private. He remembered a tense meeting, a child crying in the corridor and an instruction to wait outside Room Four. He did not remember seeing anyone alter the register. When Badu asked whether Ofori had ordered it, Mensah paused before answering.

“I saw Ofori speak to the people responsible for the review,” he said. “I saw him carry a folder away. I did not see what was inside it, and I did not hear him give an order to change a name.” He insisted that the distinction be written into the statement. Badu respected the insistence. Suspicion could guide an inquiry, but it could not be allowed to turn a witness’s uncertainty into a fact.

Mensah’s account also complicated the date. The meeting on 13 August had ended before midnight, but he could not say

whether the register was changed that night or during the next morning’s administrative shift. He had learned about the alteration only when a copy reached his desk. The person who delivered it had since died, and the office diary that might have identified the courier was missing from the archive catalogue.

Mensah returned to the station the following day with a list of the offices he remembered visiting in 2004. Some had closed; others had merged into newer departments. He drew the route from Haven House to the district office, then marked the place where he had been asked to sign the cover sheet. Badu compared the sketch with the old file movement record. The route was plausible, but several dates were based on memory rather than contemporaneous notes. They arranged to verify the office names and locations before treating the sketch as corroboration.

During a break, Mensah admitted that he had once believed a senior officer’s assurance that the register would be corrected later. He had not asked for the assurance in writing. He had also failed to interview the staff member who objected to the transfer, telling himself the objection was an administrative matter outside his remit. He did not ask Badu to excuse him. ‘I thought the right person would deal with it,’ he said. ‘That was how it was allowed to become everybody’s problem and nobody’s responsibility.’

Badu asked him to separate what he remembered hearing from what he had personally witnessed. Mensah took time with each answer. He had heard that a child’s name would be restored; he had not seen a correction order. He had seen a cover sheet; he had not verified every page behind it. He had heard Ofori mentioned at a meeting; he could not swear that Ofori had altered the register. The distinctions made his statement less dramatic, but they also made it more credible. Badu asked the

clerk to preserve the original recording and provide Mensah with an opportunity to correct any transcription errors.

When the interview ended, Mensah asked whether his statement would be made public. Badu explained that it would be handled according to the investigation's rules and that he could not promise secrecy if the matter reached court. The old inspector nodded, disappointed but not surprised. "For years I thought keeping the copies was enough," he said. "Now I understand that a paper can survive and still be useless unless somebody is willing to explain exactly what it proves."

Before leaving, Mensah handed over a second envelope. Inside was a small, faded visitor slip bearing a date, a time and the initials 'A. S.' He believed the initials belonged to Adwoa Sarpong, but he had never asked her. The slip did not establish that she had taken Daniel from Haven House. It did, however, place someone using those initials in the building on the morning the register changed. Badu arranged for the slip to be examined and added Adwoa's name to the list of people whose accounts needed independent verification.

Mensah agreed to identify the signatures on the copies he had kept, but he insisted on seeing the originals before making a formal identification. The prosecutor approved a controlled comparison. Under supervision, Mensah examined the pages and pointed out a flourish he remembered from Asare's signature. He then stopped himself. 'Remembering a man's handwriting is not the same as proving he signed this page, ' he said. The prosecutor noted the caution and arranged for a qualified examiner to review the documents. For the first time since the inquiry began, Mensah seemed relieved

that someone was willing to slow the process down rather than demand a confession from him.

Before he left, Mensah disclosed another detail: after the incident at Haven House, he had been told to deliver a sealed envelope to an administrative office, not to the police archive. He could not remember the room number, but he remembered a brass plate beside the door and a clerk who asked him to sign a receipt. His copy of that receipt had disappeared years ago. Badu asked him to sketch the office and describe the clerk without guessing at a name. The sketch was rough, and the description broad. Even so, it gave the team a practical task: search transfer logs from the relevant administrative offices rather than searching every archive in the country.

Mensah arrived with a folder he had kept separate from his official retirement papers. He did not hand it over immediately. Instead, he asked Badu to explain whether the interview was voluntary and whether he was being treated as a witness or a suspect. Badu answered plainly: his status could change as evidence developed, and no promise of immunity had been made. The legal officer present confirmed that Mensah could request a break or clarification. The formality irritated the old inspector, but it also seemed to reassure him that the conversation would be recorded properly.

His recollection of the night at Haven House came in fragments. He remembered a power interruption, a staff member carrying a stack of forms and a senior official who insisted that a child’s placement be treated as confidential. He could not confidently identify the official from the surviving photograph. He remembered the voice more clearly than the face, but admitted that the voice might have become familiar through later news coverage. The interviewer marked that uncertainty. Mensah was not permitted to turn a feeling of recognition into a positive identification without explaining its limits.

The folder contained a carbon copy of a visitor slip, but the bottom edge was missing. The time had been written in pencil and overwritten in blue ink. Mensah said he did not know who made the alteration. The slip could help reconstruct the sequence of visits, yet its condition left room for doubt. Badu asked the examiner to compare it with other forms from the same office. Mensah watched the copy being sealed and finally said, ‘I kept it because I was afraid someone would say it never existed.’ He did not say who he had feared.

Mensah’s Conditions

Mensah agreed to a formal follow-up only after his lawyer reviewed the proposed questions. He wanted the record to show that he had not been the officer responsible for the original transfer and had not personally seen the child’s birth certificate. Badu accepted the correction. Mensah’s earlier account had been useful, but his phrasing had sometimes made second-hand information sound like direct observation. The revised statement marked each source: what he saw, what another officer told him, and what he later inferred from the file.

During the interview, Mensah described a meeting in which Ofori had asked him to sign a receipt for a sealed packet. Mensah said he signed after being told that the contents had already been checked. He could not say whether the packet contained the altered register or another document. The receipt, however, carried a time stamp that placed the packet in the records office after the official transfer had supposedly ended. The inconsistency did not prove that Mensah had participated in the alteration, but it gave investigators a specific record to seek.

When the interview ended, Mensah asked Badu whether the case would destroy his pension and reputation. Badu said he could not promise what the inquiry would conclude. He could promise that the statement would include the corrections Mensah had made. At last, the old inspector seemed to understand that

cooperation did not mean receiving protection from consequences. It meant allowing the record to show both the truth he could offer and the limits of his own responsibility.

Badu asked him to state the distinction in his own words. Mensah did so, then added that he had failed to challenge the official explanation at the time. The admission did not make him innocent of every decision, but it made his evidence more useful. An investigator could test what Mensah had actually seen; no one could test a memory that had been silently replaced by a story told afterwards.

Mensah returned to explain that he had seen Ofori leaving the administrative corridor with a folder under one arm. He had not seen the folder opened and could not say it contained the register. Years later, another officer had told him that the missing packet had been in it. Mensah had repeated that account so often that the two memories had fused. He looked shaken when he recognised the difference.

Mensah’s lawyer sent a list of corrections to the draft statement. Some were minor, such as a room number; others changed whether Mensah had seen Ofori carrying the packet or had merely heard that he had done so. Badu refused to merge the versions. The original account would remain preserved, the corrections would be attached, and the interview record would identify which sentences Mensah had personally confirmed. It was an awkward process, but the alternative was a polished statement that concealed how memory had changed under questioning.

The Witness’s Boundaries

His aunt watched the evidence bag being sealed. ‘You are treating your father like a stranger, ’ she said. Badu answered that the procedure was not a judgment on his father. It was a way of finding out what the surviving

objects could honestly tell them. The explanation did not comfort her, but she signed the inventory and agreed to provide a statement about how the boxes had been stored after the funeral.

At the bottom of a box, they found an envelope containing a bus ticket and a small appointment card. Neither mentioned Haven House, but the card carried the initials K. B. M. and a date within the disputed period. Badu did not take it as proof that his father had attended the meeting. He asked the officer to bag it and requested a comparison with the old service calendar. The ticket could have belonged to any journey; the card could have been kept for a reason unrelated to the case.

Badu asked his aunt to help inventory the boxes left from his father's house, but he arranged for an independent officer to attend. They opened one container at a time, photographed the contents in place and wrote a short description before moving anything. Old receipts, a service medal and family letters appeared first. His aunt grew impatient with the process until the officer explained that the inventory protected her as well as the investigation: no one could later claim that an item had appeared or disappeared without a record.

A family search with witnesses

The Unfinished Inventory

The independent officer supervising Badu's family connection asked him to prepare an inventory of every item his father had left that might relate to Haven House. Badu began with the letter, diary and photograph, then added the appointment card found in the family boxes. He listed where each item had been stored, who had handled it and whether anyone could remember seeing it before the investigation began.

The exercise felt painfully formal. These were objects he had known since childhood: the diary his father carried to meetings,

the envelope that smelled faintly of dust, the photograph that had sat behind a drawer. Now each required a description that did not assume its meaning. He wrote ‘handwritten note referring to a meeting’ rather than ‘confession’, and ‘photograph showing five children’ rather than ‘proof of the fifth child’s identity.’

The officer reviewed the inventory and asked him to identify gaps. Badu admitted that he could not explain how the letter had come to be in the drawer or whether his father had shown it to anyone. His aunt remembered seeing an envelope of similar size but could not be certain it was the same one. The diary’s missing pages might have been removed years earlier, but no witness could date their removal.

They contacted the retired sergeant whose number appeared in the old directory. The sergeant did not answer at first. When he finally returned the call, he said he remembered Badu’s father as a careful man who disliked signing documents he had not read. He also remembered a period when the father had become unusually anxious about office visitors. He could not recall the names of those visitors.

Badu asked if the sergeant would give a formal statement. The man agreed, provided the questions were written down first. He wanted to consult his own notes and avoid making a claim based on the pressure of a telephone conversation. Badu respected the condition and passed the contact to the independent officer.

That evening, Badu removed his father’s name from the suspect column on the board and placed it under ‘persons connected to the records’. The distinction did not protect his father from scrutiny; it protected the investigation from an assumption. If his father had been involved, the evidence would have to show how. If someone had used his name, that too would need to be established.

Before he left, Ama gave him a folded letter found among the notebook’s loose pages. The letter was addressed to his father

and bore no signature. It asked him to attend a meeting about “the outstanding register and the child’s file.” The paper had no official letterhead. The date was partly torn away. Badu did not open it further at the table; he placed it in a clean envelope and arranged to have it examined and documented through the investigation team. His father’s name had entered the case again, but the paper did not yet say whether he had been a participant, a witness, or simply someone who had been asked for help.

The recollection was important enough to record and too uncertain to treat as fact. Badu wrote down her words, read them back, and asked her to correct anything that sounded stronger than she meant. She corrected “refused to carry” to “said he did not want to carry it.” That small change mattered. It transformed a firm act into a remembered conversation, which was all she could honestly offer.

Badu felt the old instinct to turn a family detail into an answer. He resisted it. He asked instead whether she remembered his father returning from a meeting troubled or unusually quiet. She recalled one evening when he had come home later than expected and washed his hands before greeting anyone. She had asked whether something had happened. He said only that a man had asked him to carry a sealed envelope and that he had refused because he did not know what it contained. Years later, she could not remember the exact month, and she was not sure the envelope had any connection to the judicial review.

Ama studied it for a long time. “He sometimes used initials for places where he had business. H. H. could mean Haven House. It could also mean something else. He never told me everything about his work.”

Badu began with the notebook. Several pages had been removed cleanly, leaving a narrow strip of paper beside the binding. The remaining entries were practical: a list of telephone

numbers, a reminder about a meeting, a note to collect a repaired radio. Near the back, one entry read, “H. H. — confirm receipt; do not sign for contents.” There was no date beside it. Badu photographed the page and asked his aunt whether she remembered the initials.

“Your father was careful with papers,” she said. “But careful people also keep things they do not understand. Do not assume every page he kept means he agreed with it.”

Badu waited until the evening to visit his aunt. He did not want his first question about his father’s old papers to become a conversation overheard by neighbours or repeated by relatives who had only fragments of the history. His aunt, Ama, lived in a modest house where family photographs covered one wall. She had kept his father’s school certificate, a few letters, and the small notebook Badu had asked about before. She set them on the table without making a speech about loyalty.

A Family Record

PART TWO — THE MISSING YEARS

CHAPTER SIX

The Man Who Remembered

Retired Inspector Mensah did not hand Badu his notebook immediately. He first asked him to read a photocopy of the page listing the first interviews after Daniel disappeared. The entries were brief: time, name, relationship to the child, exact words where possible, and what had not been checked. Beside one line, Mensah had written, ‘Do not convert absence into abduction without evidence.’

‘You were already thinking someone had taken him,’ Badu said.

‘I was thinking a child was missing and adults were giving me explanations that changed depending on who asked. Those are different things.’ Mensah tapped the note. ‘A frightened family can hide a child. A careless office can lose a file. A dishonest official can alter a record. A person can leave voluntarily. At the beginning, all those possibilities must remain open.’

The notebook showed how quickly the original inquiry had narrowed. A clerk had described Daniel as a temporary placement. A second record called him a visitor. In a later summary, the word ‘visitor’ had become ‘unidentified male child.’ No single change proved deliberate wrongdoing, but the sequence made the record less useful with every retelling.

Mensah explained that he had requested copies from two offices because he did not trust a summary prepared by the same unit responsible for the original file. One copy had arrived without its attachment list. The other carried a reference number that did not match the dispatch book. He had reported the discrepancy, then been told to focus on locating the child rather than questioning clerical procedure.

‘And you accepted that?’ Badu asked.

‘For a time. I had other missing children, other families waiting. I told myself the attachment list was administrative. That was my mistake. It may not have been the only mistake, but it was mine.’ Mensah’s voice held neither self-pity nor an attempt to make himself the centre of the case.

He finally passed over the notebook. The pages were worn at the corners, but the handwriting remained legible. He had underlined the same three names in different colours, then drawn a line from each to a question rather than a conclusion. The fifth name was absent from the official summary, yet it appeared in a rough list copied from a social worker’s pocket diary.

Badu photographed the pages in place and recorded who had supplied them. He would not treat an old notebook as self-authenticating proof. Mensah could explain how he made the entries; other records would have to establish whether the details were accurate. Still, the notebook gave the team a path that did not depend on anyone remembering the past perfectly.

Before Badu left, Mensah pointed to the final note. ‘Ask the fifth child.’ The phrase had been written twice, once in the margin and once beneath the list. ‘I do not remember writing it the second time, ’ he admitted. ‘I may have copied it from the diary. I may have been reminding myself not to stop at four names. Do not build a theory on my uncertainty.’

Badu left with the notebook secured in an evidence sleeve. The most valuable thing it offered was not a revelation. It was a record of where the earlier investigation had stopped asking questions.

Mensah’s Correction

Mensah called Badu the following morning to correct a phrase in his statement. He had said that he “delivered

the envelope to the office," but what he meant was that he left it with a clerk at the reception desk. He had not seen the envelope enter the restricted room and could not say who opened it. The difference seemed small until Nyarko explained that the original wording might be used to suggest Mensah knew the packet reached its intended recipient.

They brought him back for a supplemental statement. Mensah insisted on reading the whole page before signing. When he reached the corrected sentence, he stopped and asked whether the first version would remain on file. Nyarko said yes; the record would show both the original wording and the amendment, with the reason for the change. Mensah accepted that. He said he had spent years watching records become cleaner each time they were copied, until the uncertainty disappeared and only the official version remained.

Badu asked whether the clerk's identity could be recovered from duty rosters. Mensah remembered a woman named Efua, but he was not certain of her surname. A retired staff list contained three possible matches. The team would need to locate each person or establish that they had died before narrowing the search. Mensah's correction did not make him more or less trustworthy by itself. It gave investigators a more precise account and a new task they could verify.

The Diary's Missing Pages

Badu took his father's diary to a conservator rather than attempting to lift the binding himself. The conservator found fibres near the missing section that suggested the pages had been removed with a blade, not torn out in anger. A narrow indentation remained on the following page, as if someone had written on the sheet above it. With angled light, a few pressure marks became visible, but they formed only fragments: a date, the letters 'H. H.' and a word that might have been 'return'. The

conservator photographed the marks and made no attempt to fill in the missing sentence.

Badu's aunt remembered his father returning from an official meeting with dust on his shoes and a sealed envelope under his coat. She had not asked about it at the time. Years later, she had found the envelope empty in a drawer and assumed it had held ordinary paperwork. Her memory was uncertain about the month and she said so. Badu did not press her to choose a date. He asked whether she had told anyone else. She named one relative, then paused and admitted she might also have mentioned it to a neighbour while his father was alive.

The conversation left Badu with less certainty than he had hoped for, but a clearer map of what remained to be checked. His father might have preserved evidence, removed evidence, or tried to protect someone from it. A son's affection could not decide which. Badu placed the diary in the case inventory and asked another officer to review the conservation report, ensuring that his family connection would not make him the sole interpreter of its contents.

Mensah's Terms

Inspector Mensah refused to begin his second statement until the prosecutor explained how it would be used. He wanted to know whether he was being treated as a witness, a suspect or an old officer whose memory had become convenient to younger investigators. The prosecutor told him that his status could change if evidence justified it, and that no promise of immunity had been made. Mensah nodded, disappointed but not surprised. He had spent years watching officials make informal promises and later deny that the conversations had happened.

He described the night at Haven House in fragments: a vehicle waiting outside, a supervisor carrying a folder, a child being told to repeat a name, and a telephone call that interrupted the meeting. Each fragment came with a qualification. He could

remember the smell of disinfectant in the corridor, but not the colour of the vehicle. He remembered a senior official's voice, but could not swear that he had seen the official's face clearly.

Badu asked him to draw the building as he remembered it. Mensah sketched a corridor, a stairwell and three doors, then stopped. He said Room Four had been labelled as a storage room on one plan and an interview room on another. The difference might have been administrative, he admitted, but the room's use had mattered because children were brought there without the ordinary care records being completed.

The prosecutor asked whether he had ever challenged the practice. Mensah looked down at the table. He had raised a concern to a supervisor, he said, but withdrew it after being told the arrangement had been approved at a higher level. He could not produce a written complaint. His silence had protected his job, and perhaps protected him from being asked to do more. It had also left the children without a reliable record of what had happened.

When the interview ended, Mensah asked whether Daniel would be forced to meet him. Badu said no decision about contact would be made for the witness's convenience. Daniel was not evidence to be displayed; he was a person who had already been made to carry the consequences of other people's decisions. Mensah accepted the answer. For the first time, he seemed to understand that telling the truth did not entitle him to forgiveness.

CHAPTER SEVEN

Adwoa's House

Adwoa Sarpong initially denied knowing anything useful about Haven House. When Badu mentioned Mensah, she admitted that she had worked at the home and had been present on 14 August 2004. Something had happened that should never have been allowed, she said, and a child had been placed in her care under circumstances she did not fully understand.

Her house was tidy, with family photographs arranged above the television. Daniel appeared in several: a school uniform, a graduation robe and a stiff studio portrait. Adwoa spoke about his childhood illnesses, the school he attended and the small routines of family life. The memories were ordinary and specific. Whatever the documents said, her care for him was not a fiction.

When Badu asked about the brass key, she clasped the edge of the table. "Room Four was not a place for children to sleep," she said. "It was where adults took them when they wanted answers without the others listening." The children had been asked to repeat names, dates and details about who had brought them there. The adults called it paperwork; the children knew they were frightened.

Adwoa said she had taken Daniel because he had been left without a safe adult to claim him. Someone told her the record would be corrected later. She had believed that a home, a school and a family name could give him a future. She had not understood that a temporary arrangement would become a permanent falsehood. She knew what she had been told and what

she had been asked to write down, but she could not identify the person who first ordered the change.

She showed Badu a photograph of herself holding a baby. She had not given birth to him; she had raised him and called him Daniel. A message from Agyeman, sent three weeks before his death, instructed her to tell Daniel not to visit the judge and to find the woman who remembered the fifth child. Adwoa did not know who that woman was. When Badu showed her the photograph of the five children, she recognised the setting but could not identify every face with certainty.

Before Badu left, she directed him to the original Haven House building. At the end of a corridor was a room the staff had been forbidden to enter: Room Four. The judge, she believed, had known someone was coming for the truth. She asked Badu not to make Daniel think his life had been a lie. He could not promise that the facts would not hurt him, but he promised that the investigation would not confuse what had been done to Daniel with what Daniel was worth.

After Badu left, Adwoa searched a folder of old school reports and clinic cards. The documents consistently named the boy Daniel Sarpong. At the bottom lay a folded note from the woman who had brought him to her: If anyone asks, say he came to you before the transfer was completed. The note gave a date and an address, but no full explanation. Adwoa had kept it because she never believed the matter was finished.

She called Badu and said she would hand over the note in person. She had not shown it to Daniel because she feared he would think she had accepted him for some reason other than love. She understood now that withholding it had protected her from a painful conversation while leaving him alone with the consequences.

Adwoa’s promise to hand over the folded note brought Badu back to her house the next afternoon. This time he came with a female officer who could witness the transfer and record the circumstances in which the document had been kept. Adwoa watched the officer photograph the envelope before it was opened. She looked embarrassed by the formality, but Badu explained that the process protected her as much as it protected the investigation. No one should later be able to claim that a crucial paper had appeared from nowhere.

The note was written in blue ink on a narrow strip of paper. The handwriting was hurried but legible. It instructed Adwoa to say that the child had arrived before the transfer was completed and gave an address near an old bus station. There was no signature. The date on the note was two days earlier than the date entered in the surviving register. If genuine, it could mean that the arrangement had begun before the official account said it had; it did not tell them who had written it or why.

Adwoa identified the address as a place where a Haven House administrator sometimes met relatives away from the children’s dormitories. She had never gone inside. She remembered being told that the meeting concerned a temporary placement and that the papers would be regularised once the review ended. She had not been given a copy of any order. At the time, she had been worried about the boy’s immediate safety and had accepted assurances from people whose positions made them seem trustworthy.

The witnessing officer asked whether Adwoa had received money or been promised a benefit. Adwoa shook her head sharply, then stopped herself from answering too quickly. She had been reimbursed for transport and the cost of basic supplies, she said, but she had not been paid to take Daniel. The officer recorded the distinction and asked for any receipts or letters that might support it. Adwoa agreed to search for them. Her distress

was plain, but distress could not answer the factual questions for them.

Badu asked why she had kept the note for so many years without telling Daniel. Adwoa looked toward the family photographs. “I was afraid that if he learned he had been placed with me through a lie, he would believe every ordinary thing in his life was a lie too.” She spoke of school fees paid in small instalments and nights spent beside him when fever kept him awake. She remembered the first time he returned from school proud of a mark he had earned. “None of that was false,” she said. “But I can see now that love did not give me the right to hide the truth forever.”

Badu did not reassure her that the note would settle the matter. The paper might be authentic and still be incomplete; the address might lead to a witness who remembered the arrangement differently. He told her that Daniel would need time and independent advice before deciding how to respond. Adwoa asked whether the investigation would expose him to public ridicule. Badu said he would not discuss private details with the press, but he could not promise that court proceedings, if they followed, would remain private.

After the officer sealed the note, Adwoa showed them a small tin in which she had kept old clinic cards. One card recorded a vaccination appointment for a child listed as Daniel Sarpong. The date matched the week after the transfer, but the card contained no information about his birth parents. On its reverse, a clinic worker had written a telephone number that no longer appeared in service. Badu asked permission to have the card copied and to trace the clinic’s surviving records. Adwoa

consented, then requested that the original be returned after examination.

Adwoa asked Badu whether the investigation could be conducted without turning her home into a public spectacle. He explained that the team would not release her address and that any request for records would be handled through official channels. He could not promise that her name would never appear in court documents. She appreciated the honesty more than reassurance. For years, she had believed the arrangement was temporary and that a correction would arrive from an office somewhere. She now understood that the promise had depended on people who had no incentive to keep it.

When Mabel visited, she did not begin with the photograph. She asked Adwoa what she remembered about the first week Daniel lived with her. Adwoa described the food he refused, the fever that worried her and the way he cried when a stranger raised his voice. Those memories were not evidence of his birth identity, but they made the official records feel painfully incomplete. Mabel asked permission to take notes and offered to stop whenever Adwoa wished. The older woman continued, not because the memories solved the case, but because she wanted Daniel’s life to be more than a disputed entry in a ledger.

Before the visit ended, Adwoa corrected one date in her earlier statement. She had first said the clinic appointment took place three days after Daniel arrived; the card showed it was five. Badu thanked her for the correction and asked the clerk to amend the statement with a clear note rather than silently replace the earlier version. Adwoa looked relieved. She had feared that admitting uncertainty would make every part of her account suspect. Badu told her that an openly corrected detail was better than a false certainty left untouched.

As Badu prepared to leave, Adwoa added one memory she had previously considered too uncertain to mention. On the

morning she received the child, a woman had waited outside the house in a dark blue dress. The woman did not enter. She watched from across the road until Adwoa carried the baby indoors, then left in a taxi. Adwoa could not identify her and could not be sure whether she had been connected to Haven House. Badu recorded the description without assigning the stranger a name. It was a lead, not an identification.

That evening, Badu placed the visitor slip, the note and the clinic card in separate evidence sleeves. They touched the same period of time, but none independently explained what had happened to the five children. He wrote three questions on the board: Who authorised the placement? Who changed the register? Who was the woman outside Adwoa’s house? Beneath them he wrote a fourth: What did Daniel himself remember? The next interview, he decided, would begin with Daniel’s own account rather than with the names other people had given him.

Badu returned to Adwoa's house with a female officer and a written list of topics for the second interview. He explained that she could ask for a break and that her answers would be recorded accurately, including any uncertainty. Adwoa seemed surprised by the formality. For years, she had answered questions in rooms where officials had already decided what the answers ought to be. This time, she described the morning she received the child in sequence. First came a knock, then a short conversation at the gate. She was given a document to sign and warned not to take the child to the home for a routine review until she received further instructions.

She could not identify the person who gave the warning. She remembered a vehicle but not its registration, and she had no reason at the time to record it. The officer asked why she had not challenged the placement. Adwoa said she had believed the officials were acting lawfully and that refusing would leave the child without care. That explanation did not erase the harm

caused by her later silence. Badu made clear that he was not asking her to justify the past but to distinguish what she knew then from what she learned afterward. When she finished, Adwoa asked whether Daniel would hate her. Badu said he could not answer for Daniel; the truth would give him the chance to decide for himself.

Adwoa asked for the door to remain open during the interview. She did not want Daniel to feel that adults were making decisions about his life behind another closed door. The legal officer explained that she could stop at any point and that her account would be checked against independent records. Adwoa spoke first about ordinary things: school uniforms, clinic visits, the neighbour who had watched Daniel after work. Those details were not dramatic, but they gave the timeline texture. They also made clear that the child at the centre of the file had been cared for by people who did not understand the larger arrangement.

When shown the note, Adwoa recognised the paper but not the handwriting. She remembered receiving an envelope with instructions to keep certain documents safe, though she could not say who had delivered it. At first she had believed the request was intended to protect Daniel from public attention. Later, when questions began to circulate, she had feared that explaining the arrangement would expose him to people who wanted to use his identity. Her silence had been a decision made under pressure, not a guarantee that she knew the whole truth.

Badu asked whether the woman seen outside her house had spoken to her. Adwoa said the woman had asked if Daniel still lived there, then left when Adwoa asked her name. She could not identify her from a photograph. The team recorded the description and checked nearby camera coverage through proper channels. No one told Adwoa that the woman was connected to the murder. Until evidence established that link, she remained an unknown person who had asked a troubling question.

Adwoa’s Account Reconsidered

Adwoa asked for time before giving a second statement. When she returned, she brought a notebook in which she had recorded dates for school admissions, clinic visits and family travel. Some dates contradicted the chronology she had first given Badu. Rather than hide the discrepancy, she pointed it out herself. She had remembered the transfer as occurring before the school term, but a receipt showed that Daniel had already attended two weeks of classes. The mistake made her ashamed, yet it also showed why memory had to be tested against documents.

She explained that she had been told the arrangement would last only until the appointment review was complete. She had believed that restoring Daniel’s name later would spare him public scrutiny. When the review ended without an announcement, she asked for the papers and was told they had been sent to another office. Each delay made it easier to accept the next. By the time she understood that the temporary arrangement had become permanent, Daniel was old enough to feel that every adult had agreed to lie to him.

Badu asked whether she had ever been threatened. Adwoa recalled a visit from a man who warned that reopening the matter could cost Daniel his education and expose the family to disgrace. She could not identify him with certainty, and the visit had happened years earlier. Badu recorded the description without assigning it to Ofori. Mabel later told Adwoa that a responsible account could include fear and complicity together. One did not erase the other.

Afterwards, Daniel did not ask her to justify herself. He asked why she had never told him that the promise to correct the record had existed. Adwoa said she had feared that explaining the lie would make it permanent in his mind. Daniel replied that silence had made it permanent in the official file instead. They did not reconcile in that room. They agreed only that any further

conversation would happen without investigators present, and that neither would use the other’s words as evidence without consent.

The officer recording the statement asked whether she had ever signed a form she knew was inaccurate. Adwoa paused, then said she had signed a receipt confirming the child had been placed with her, but she could not now swear that every attached page had been present. She was not allowed to turn uncertainty into certainty simply because the consequences were painful. The officer read the statement back slowly and marked the points where Adwoa was sure, unsure or relying on what another person had told her.

Adwoa asked for a quiet room before giving her supplementary statement. She wanted to explain the sequence from the day the child arrived, not answer isolated questions that made each decision sound disconnected from the next. She described being told that the placement was temporary, that a senior official had approved it and that the paperwork would be corrected after a review. She remembered believing the promise because several people in authority repeated it. She also remembered the first time she saw the name on a document and chose not to ask why it differed from the name she had been told.

Adwoa tells the whole sequence

Room Four in Daylight

Badu returned to the old Haven House building with a facilities officer and an independent witness. The building had been converted into administrative storage, but the corridor still held the same narrow windows and chipped green paint that Adwoa had described. Badu did not enter the room alone. They photographed the door, the hinges and the surrounding wall before the facilities officer opened it with a current key.

Room Four was smaller than Badu had imagined. A metal cabinet stood against one wall, its doors removed. The floor had been replaced, and there was no guarantee that the room looked as it had in 2004. Still, the shape of the corridor and the position of the high window matched the details in the photograph. The officer marked the points that could be compared and those that could not.

A caretaker remembered that the room had been used for interviews and storage, not sleeping. He recalled adults coming in and out with folders, but he could not identify them or give a reliable date. Badu asked whether any old maintenance plans survived. The caretaker pointed to a records cupboard in the next building, where building plans had been mixed with invoices and equipment lists.

The plans showed that the corridor had once connected to a small records office through a door later sealed during renovations. That did not prove a secret route or explain the brass key. It did establish that the building’s layout had changed and that anyone relying on present-day measurements would need to account for those alterations.

Mabel arrived after the inspection and asked whether the room had revealed anything decisive. Badu said it had revealed the danger of imagination. A place could feel like the answer because it resembled a memory, yet decades of repairs made direct comparison difficult. They would need old plans, dated photographs and testimony from people who had actually worked there.

Before leaving, they placed a preservation request for the remaining plans and maintenance books. Adwoa had spoken of Room Four as the place where adults made children repeat names. In daylight, the room offered no visible explanation. Its importance lay in the records that had passed through it and the people who had chosen not to describe those visits honestly.

After the meeting, Mabel walked with Adwoa to the gate. Adwoa asked whether the newspaper would call her a liar. Mabel said she could not promise how every reader would react, but she could promise to avoid presenting uncertainty as a confession. “You can be responsible for what you chose,” she said, “without being responsible for every decision made by officials who controlled the records.” Adwoa did not look relieved. She looked as though the distinction was the first fair thing anyone had said to her in years.

Badu asked permission to record the account formally. Adwoa agreed, but insisted that the record distinguish her present understanding from what she had known at the time. The investigator conducting the formal statement would need to ask the same questions independently. No one promised her immunity or told her what answer to give. The team could offer support, but it could not rewrite the past into a simpler story.

Mabel asked whether Adwoa had ever been told to deny knowing about the original record. Adwoa looked down at her hands. She remembered a conversation with a visiting official who said that questions about the name could cause the placement to be reviewed. He had not threatened her directly, but he had made it clear that cooperation would be easier than resistance. She had understood the message. Whether that official had been acting alone, following an instruction, or trying to avoid a scandal remained unknown.

“I knew there was another name,” she said. “I did not know who had authority to change it. I thought the people handling the paperwork were correcting something that had been done wrongly before I arrived.”

“Did you know his birth name was Emmanuel Sarpong?” Badu asked.

Adwoa explained that she had been told the placement was temporary. She remembered signing forms, but not all the pages had been explained to her. One official had said the arrangement would protect the child while a family matter was resolved. Another had said that a new record would make school admission easier. She could no longer tell whether those statements had been made on the same day. At the time, she had been exhausted and frightened of losing the child. She had followed instructions from people who appeared to have authority.

Badu began with dates, not accusations. He showed her a copy of the transfer reference and asked whether she recognised the handwriting. Adwoa said the final letter of the surname looked familiar, but the document had passed through too many hands for her to identify its author confidently. She recognised the name of a clerk who had visited the home, though she could not say whether he had been present on the day the register was changed. Mabel wrote down the distinction between recognising a name and identifying a person.

Adwoa agreed to meet Badu and Mabel at a community office rather than at her home. She wanted Daniel to be able to decide for himself when he would hear the next part of the inquiry, and she did not want every conversation to become a family confrontation. A counsellor from a local support service sat nearby, not to direct the interview but to make sure Adwoa could pause whenever she needed to.

The Boundary of Adwoa’s Memory

A Neighbour’s Memory

A neighbour from Adwoa’s former street agreed to speak after Badu explained that he was not asking her to identify a child from a photograph. She remembered a period when Adwoa received visits from two officials who never stayed long. One usually waited near the gate while the other spoke inside. The neighbour had assumed they were social workers because Adwoa had fostered children before. She could not remember their faces clearly and would not pretend otherwise.

The investigators checked the street’s old tenancy records and found that one property had changed owners twice since 2004. There were no surviving camera records, and the neighbour’s description could not distinguish the visitors from many people who had come to the house. Yet her account established a possible pattern of contact that could be compared with official travel claims. Badu asked her to describe the visits separately rather than combine them into a single remembered scene.

After the interview, Mabel asked the neighbour whether she would speak publicly. The woman declined, explaining that she did not want her grandchildren drawn into a story they did not understand. Mabel respected the refusal and wrote a note for the newsroom that the account was background only unless the source later consented to publication. She was beginning to see that the investigation’s human cost would not end when the missing names were restored. Some people wanted truth; others wanted the right to decide how much of their own lives it could expose.

CHAPTER EIGHT

Daniel Sarpong

Daniel Sarpong had lived for years with a suspicion that the name on his documents was not the name he had been born with. He worked as an accounts supervisor, kept his childhood private and avoided questions about his family. When he received a message saying the Haven House register had been found, he called Adwoa. She urged him not to run and admitted that she had told Badu his identity had been changed.

Daniel agreed to meet Badu in a public garden near the university. He chose a bench facing the entrance, then listened with guarded courtesy as the detective explained the evidence. “I’m not asking you to accept a story because a policeman tells it,” Badu said. “I’m asking you to help establish what happened.” Daniel replied that people had been establishing things about him since childhood, usually without asking what he remembered.

He recalled a corridor at Haven House, a green door and a room where adults asked him to repeat a name until he stopped correcting them. He remembered floor polish, a paper cup of water and a man wearing a watch with a cracked leather strap. He could not remember every face and would not pretend otherwise. He had once corrected a man who called him Emmanuel; the man told him that the name was no longer his. Daniel could not say with certainty which day that memory belonged to.

Badu showed him a copy of the photograph of the five children. Daniel stared at the smallest boy but did not

claim certainty. “That might be me,” he said. “Or I might want it to be me because everyone says I’m supposed to be there.” Badu recorded the answer exactly. A memory could guide the investigation, but it could not be made more certain by repeating it.

Daniel agreed to provide a formal statement after speaking with a lawyer. He asked for a copy of the register entry, including the alteration, through the proper process. He also asked Badu to find out who had benefited from the name he had been given. “If my name was changed to protect me,” he said, “I want to know who was being protected from the name I had before.”

That evening, Adwoa called and said she had found a paper she wanted to show him before handing it to the police. Daniel almost refused. He finally agreed to meet her with Badu present, because he did not want another private conversation in which a crucial detail could be softened or forgotten.

Adwoa placed the note on the table without trying to touch his hand. Daniel read it twice. It said that he had come to her before the transfer was completed, but did not name the person who arranged it. Adwoa admitted she should have told him the note existed. Daniel said she should have kept it with his papers. He did not forgive her on the spot, but he passed the note to Badu so it could become part of the record.

Later, Daniel wrote down the fragments he remembered, leaving blank spaces where he was uncertain. He knew that memory was not a document, but it remained evidence of what he had experienced. He returned to the old building in daylight to check what he could. The corridor seemed smaller than he remembered, and the room at the end remained locked. He left

without forcing entry, aware that his memories needed to be tested against the surviving records.

Daniel did not sleep much that night. He spread the documents he had kept since leaving Haven House across his dining table: school reports, an old clinic card, a baptism certificate, and the first identity document he had ever been told to guard carefully. The papers did not tell one story. Dates differed by weeks; one form listed a guardian who had never visited his school, while another left the space blank. None of the discrepancies proved a conspiracy on its own. Together, they suggested that the adults responsible for his early records had not been working from a single reliable account.

He photographed each page beside a ruler and wrote the source and date on a separate sheet. Then he sealed the originals in a clear folder. He had spent years thinking that keeping quiet was the safest way to live, but silence had left other people free to describe him. He would not surrender his papers to anyone without a receipt, including Badu. The detective had respected that boundary, and Daniel decided that respect was worth a measured degree of trust.

At their next meeting, Badu brought a records officer rather than another detective. The officer explained how a certified copy could be made and how the originals would be logged if Daniel chose to submit them. Daniel asked whether an alteration could be dated by ink alone. The officer said sometimes, but not reliably: paper, ink, handwriting, storage conditions and the order of entries all mattered, and no examiner could promise an exact date from a glance. Daniel appreciated the answer because it did not pretend that science could settle every uncertainty.

One school report carried a teacher’s note in the margin: ‘Corrected name confirmed by guardian.’ The handwriting differed from the rest of the page. Daniel remembered being

made to repeat a name in a corridor, but he could not connect that memory to the report. Badu asked whether the teacher was still alive. Daniel did not know. The records officer recommended locating the school’s admission register and any surviving correspondence before drawing a conclusion. They added the teacher’s name to the inquiry list, with no assumption that the teacher had knowingly taken part in wrongdoing.

Daniel requested a copy of every document in which his name appeared, subject to the rules governing restricted records. He wanted to see how many versions existed and when each had been created. The records officer explained that access might be limited where other people’s personal information appeared, but agreed to prepare a schedule of the documents and the legal basis for any redaction. Daniel insisted that the request be recorded in writing. He had spent much of his life receiving answers that depended on somebody’s memory; he wanted a paper trail of his own.

Later, he spoke with a former classmate who remembered that the school had asked for an updated birth certificate before an examination. The classmate could not remember which year or what name had been on the first form. Daniel did not pressure him to be more certain. Instead, he asked whether he would be willing to provide a statement about the request itself. The classmate agreed to search old messages and papers. It was a modest lead, but it offered a route to contemporaneous records rather than another chain of recollections.

That night Daniel wrote two names on a blank page: the name he had used throughout his life and the birth name now appearing in the evidence. He did not cross either one out. Both had shaped him; one had been given to him through a family that loved him, while the other seemed to have been removed by a system he had never understood. He decided that the investigation could establish the facts, but it could not dictate

how he should feel about them. The distinction gave him room to breathe.

After the meeting, Daniel asked Badu a question he had avoided. “If the records show that I was given another name, what happens to the life I have lived under it?” Badu answered carefully. The investigation could establish what the records said and whether anyone had unlawfully altered them; legal advice would be needed before Daniel made decisions about his own documents. His work, friendships and years of ordinary life did not become false because a form might have been changed. The answer did not resolve Daniel’s anger, but it gave the anger a boundary.

That evening he returned to the photograph of the five children. He no longer tried to force the smallest boy’s face to become familiar. Instead, he wrote down what he could observe: the boy’s left hand was closed around a paper tag; a dark mark showed near the cuff; the edge of the tag appeared to carry two lines of writing. He noted that the image was too blurred to identify either line. He sent the observations to Badu and left the photograph untouched. For the first time, the past seemed less like a door he had to force open and more like a record that had to be read carefully.

Daniel brought a folder of school reports, vaccination cards and old photographs to the interview. He had gathered them because they were the only records that belonged to him in an ordinary, personal way. Badu asked permission before examining each item and arranged for copies to be made, leaving the originals with Daniel. The school reports consistently used Daniel Sarpong, while the earliest clinic card had a correction beside the date of birth. A school administrator, contacted with Daniel's consent, confirmed that the school had accepted the documents supplied at admission and had not independently verified the child's original identity.

The discovery unsettled Daniel more than the altered register. The school had not conspired against him; it had relied on documents that appeared valid. His teachers, classmates and achievements remained part of his life, even if the paperwork had a concealed history. He asked whether he should change his name immediately. Badu advised him to seek independent legal advice and warned him not to alter official records while the investigation was active. Daniel agreed, but insisted that he would not let the case turn him into a passive object again. He would provide a statement about his memories, review it carefully and correct any words that did not reflect what he actually remembered.

Daniel agreed to meet the former school administrator in a public room at the district office. He brought copies of the records he had collected and laid them out in chronological order. The administrator remembered the transfer, but not the person who had authorised it. The school had accepted the documents presented at the time because they bore official stamps and appeared complete. That explanation did not resolve the discrepancy, but it showed how a false record could travel through ordinary systems without every clerk being part of a conspiracy.

One report listed Daniel under a shortened name; another used the full name that appeared on his later medical card. The dates did not line up perfectly. The administrator said school records were sometimes copied at the end of term, and mistakes could persist for years. Daniel asked whether the original admission register still existed. The administrator did not know, but offered to check the storage inventory. Daniel left with no definitive answer, yet he had gained something important: a clear account of which documents the school had actually seen and which had been added later.

Outside the office, Daniel told Mabel that he wanted the truth even if it damaged the version of his childhood he had

carried for years. She reminded him that the investigation was not entitled to every private detail merely because the story was newsworthy. They agreed that he would decide what personal material could be published, while investigators would continue to pursue relevant evidence through lawful channels. Daniel felt less like an object passed between institutions and more like a person able to set boundaries.

Daniel’s Own Questions

Daniel began keeping his own list of questions. He wanted to know who had chosen the name on his earliest school form, why the clinic card used another reference, and whether his biological family had ever tried to find him. Badu warned him that some answers might never be recovered. Daniel replied that uncertainty was already part of his life; what he could no longer accept was adults deciding that he did not need to know it. The statement changed the tone of their meetings. Daniel was no longer only a witness being asked to remember. He was a person directing the inquiry toward the questions that mattered to him.

At the school, the headteacher allowed the team to inspect an old admission ledger under supervision. The original page had been transferred to a district archive, but the school retained a carbon copy. The name had been entered in a different hand from the signature of the guardian. A clerk’s initials appeared in the margin, though the clerk had died years earlier. The record could not establish who ordered the change, but it narrowed the period when the substitution had been made.

Daniel read the copied entry and asked whether the investigators would publish his birth name. Mabel explained that the public interest lay in how officials had altered records, not in exposing every detail of his private life. He asked to see the proposed wording before it appeared. She agreed, while making clear that editorial decisions could not be handed over to a

source. The compromise gave him a voice without turning the article into a personal statement he did not control.

A former classmate responded to a discreet inquiry with a photograph from a school event. Daniel appeared in the back row, wearing a badge with a name that matched the school register. The photograph did not establish his birth identity, but it confirmed that the school had used the later name by that date. Daniel studied the image and remembered the day, including a teacher who had insisted that the badge be corrected. He wrote down the memory, then labelled it a recollection to be checked rather than a fact to be announced.

Mabel suggested that he not publish the timeline until an independent archivist had checked the dates. Daniel agreed, but he asked that the record be preserved as his own account rather than absorbed into the police file. The distinction mattered to him: the investigation needed evidence, while he needed a way to understand his life without having every private detail become public property.

Daniel created a timeline of his childhood from items he had kept: school reports, clinic cards, a photograph from a naming ceremony and the dates of two moves between homes. He wrote each date beside its source and marked recollections that came from Adwoa rather than from his own memory. The exercise was unexpectedly difficult. Some events he had always described as happening in the same year were separated by several months; one certificate had been issued later than the event it recorded.

Daniel’s own chronology

Daniel’s Own Questions

Daniel met the case psychologist and the independent officer in a quiet consultation room. He had agreed to discuss his memories, but he wanted the limits explained first. The psychologist told him that memory was not a recording and that

repeated questioning could alter how a person understood an old event. They would ask open questions, record uncertainty and avoid supplying names or details for him to confirm.

Daniel described the green door, the paper cup and the instruction to repeat a name. He could not say whether the room had been Room Four or whether the adults had been wearing uniforms. He remembered one woman kneeling to speak to him at eye level, but he did not know if she was Adwoa. The account was written down in his own words, with pauses and corrections preserved.

When the interview ended, Daniel asked whether the investigation would change his legal identity. The officer explained that the police could establish evidence and refer it to the appropriate authorities, but they could not rewrite civil records by themselves. A separate process might be needed, and Daniel would have to receive advice about the consequences for his education, employment and personal documents.

The answer disappointed him. He had imagined that finding the original register would settle everything. Instead, it opened questions about which records were valid, which institutions had relied on them and whether correcting one document would create conflicts elsewhere. His life had been built through ordinary acts—school enrolment, examinations, work contracts, bank forms—each completed in good faith under the name he had been given.

Mabel asked if he would speak on the record. Daniel declined for now. He did not want the first public account of his childhood to be shaped by the needs of a newspaper or the demands of a police case. He offered to review a factual chronology for accuracy, but only after his lawyer had seen it.

Badu accepted the boundary. Daniel was not merely a clue to be followed; he was a person whose choices had been constrained by the decisions of others. The investigation could

not restore his childhood, but it could avoid repeating the original wrong by taking his consent seriously and separating his private life from evidence that genuinely mattered.

Daniel's Own Questions

Daniel made a list of questions before meeting the document examiner. He wanted to know which records were original, which were copies, and whether the name Emmanuel Sarpong appeared anywhere beyond the disputed statement. He also asked whether an official could alter a birth record without changing every later document. The examiner explained that identity records often accumulated in layers: a hospital entry, a registration form, school records, clinic cards and later applications. One changed record could influence the next without automatically rewriting every earlier source.

That explanation made Daniel angrier than a simple answer would have done. The false name had not needed to replace his whole life in one act. It had only needed to enter the chain at the right point, then be repeated by people who trusted the document in front of them. Each later form could be accurate about what it copied and still preserve an original lie.

He brought the examiner a school report he had kept because of a teacher's handwritten comment in the margin. The paper had been folded for years, and the ink had faded. The examiner photographed it and explained that the comment might help establish a date or a teacher's identity, but it could not by itself prove Daniel's birth name. Daniel agreed to let the report be recorded, provided the original was returned and not released to the press.

Mabel asked whether he would allow her to describe the emotional effect of learning the truth. Daniel said she could describe his decision to investigate, but not invent feelings he had not expressed. He did not want to become a symbol in a story about official corruption. He wanted a complete account of

the people who had changed his records and the reasons they had given themselves.

That evening, he wrote to a relative he had not spoken to in years. He did not ask for an immediate answer. He asked for any old letter, photograph or school document that might help establish the sequence of his childhood. He was no longer waiting for the investigators to tell him who he had been. He was helping to assemble the evidence himself.

Daniel’s Own Record

Daniel requested a copy of every document that named him, subject to the investigation’s disclosure rules. He wanted to see the records for himself rather than hear his childhood explained by people who had handled it. Nyarko arranged a supervised review with a support person present. The documents were laid out in chronological order, and Daniel was invited to mark questions without writing on the originals.

He noticed that his school record used a different spelling of his middle name in two successive years. The difference had previously seemed like an ordinary clerical mistake. Beside it, the admission form carried a reference number that did not appear on the clinic card. The discrepancy did not prove that the records belonged to different children, but it gave the team a concrete question for the school archive and the clinic’s successor institution.

Daniel became angry when he saw how little of his early life could be confirmed. Badu did not ask him to calm down or reassure the officers that he understood. He explained which records could be requested and which were likely to have been lawfully destroyed under retention rules. Daniel wrote a list of questions in his own words. By the end of the meeting he had not found a complete answer, but he had stopped being a passive subject of the file. He was now directing part of the search.

CHAPTER NINE

The Inspector’s File

The file associated with Mensah’s old inquiry had spent years moving between offices. Its inventory listed twelve items, but the box contained only ten; the numbering skipped from six to nine. Badu asked the records officer to document the discrepancy before he examined the contents. He had learned that a missing page could disappear twice: first from the file, then from the official account of what the file had contained.

One surviving statement described a late-night meeting at Haven House involving Agyeman, Asare and an officer identified as Ofori. The witness said the men argued about whether a child could be entered under a different name without a new birth record. A handwritten margin note read: The order came from above. The statement did not identify who had given that order, and Badu refused to treat the phrase as a name.

A second document described a senior visitor arriving after a child’s transfer was supposedly complete, carrying a file bearing a judicial seal. The visitor said the register had to be changed before the appointment review resumed. Mensah said he had seen Ofori carrying papers, but had not seen him give the instruction. That distinction mattered: presence was evidence of opportunity, not proof of authorship.

Badu’s team compared the report with the duty roster. One version placed Ofori elsewhere on the night of the transfer; the roster showed him at the local station and contained no replacement entry. The discrepancy might have been a clerical error, but it justified further inquiry. Badu asked the team to separate confirmed facts, reported statements and unverified claims rather than force them into a single theory.

Mensah’s original statement had been kept apart from the official report. It described the time, the room and the instructions he received, but the most important paragraph had been crossed out in a later copy. Mensah said he had delayed speaking because he feared the witness would be exposed and because he knew his own silence had made him complicit. He could identify a voice more confidently than a face, and he would not swear to an identification he could not support.

Soon after agreeing to give a formal statement, Mensah vanished. A neighbour reported seeing a dark vehicle outside his building twice in three days. Part of its registration led to a company that no longer traded. Mensah had initially refused protective accommodation, saying he did not want to be hidden by the same system he distrusted. He promised to meet Badu the next day but never arrived.

Badu issued preservation notices for the relevant archives and asked that access logs be secured. He also shared the missing-page discrepancy with the prosecutor before making any public statement. The evidence supported three propositions with different levels of confidence: a child’s name had been changed; the change appeared deliberate; and the person who ordered it remained unidentified.

A message warned Badu to stop looking for the fifth child. He added the words to the timeline, not as proof of who sent it but as evidence that someone feared the investigation. The missing pages mattered, but so did the limits of what remained. The case would advance only if each conclusion could survive scrutiny.

Badu asked the records officer to prepare a chain-of-custody sheet for every item removed from Mensah’s file. The officer was irritated by the extra work. The box had been moved through three offices, he explained, and its old inventory might have been copied from an earlier list. Badu did not accuse him of

tampering. He asked for the names of everyone who had signed for the box and the dates on which it had changed hands. Routine administration could explain a gap; it could also reveal when a gap first appeared.

The first transfer form was complete. The second carried a stamp but no signature. On the third, the receiving officer’s initials belonged to a man who had retired before the date written beside them. The records officer checked the register and discovered that the date had been corrected in a different ink. None of this established who removed the missing items, but it meant the inventory could no longer be treated as an unquestioned description of the box’s contents. Badu requested an independent audit and kept the original forms sealed.

The team reconstructed the file’s movement on a wall chart. They marked each confirmed transfer in black, each recollection in blue, and each unresolved entry in pencil. The chart looked untidy, but its untidiness was honest. A junior investigator suggested that Ofori must have removed the pages because his name appeared in the surviving statement. Badu asked what evidence linked Ofori to the missing inventory items rather than merely to the old inquiry. The investigator had none yet. Badu told him to keep the suspicion on the board but not to colour it as fact.

A retired clerk agreed to speak after the prosecutor arranged a formal interview. She remembered preparing copies of a report about Haven House, but she could not recall who collected them. She did remember being told that one copy was ‘for the review panel’ and another was not to leave the building. When shown the inventory, she pointed to the skipped numbers and said the original file had once contained folded sheets attached behind the main statement. She could not say whether those sheets were the missing items. Her account gave the team a practical next step: search the panel’s records and the clerk’s old dispatch book.

The dispatch book was found in a storage cabinet at the former office. Its paper had browned at the edges, and several entries had been blurred by water. One line recorded a sealed envelope sent to the review panel on the day after the disputed transfer. The recipient’s surname was incomplete, but the office stamp was legible. Badu photographed the page in place, arranged for a conservation-quality copy, and asked the panel’s successor office to preserve any matching register. He did not remove the book or mark it. A clue that had survived for years could be damaged in seconds by careless handling.

The archive clerk brought the team a set of accession sheets showing how the old inquiry file had been absorbed into a newer catalogue. The dates did not align perfectly with the surviving inventory. One transfer had been logged on a Friday, while the receiving office’s stamp appeared on the following Monday. That delay might have reflected ordinary weekend procedures, but the absence of a sealed-bag number meant the team could not establish whether the packet had remained intact. Badu requested the original accession book and a statement from the clerk who had prepared the modern index.

Mabel traced the restricted-annex code through an old newspaper clipping. It appeared in a brief note about a committee meeting, but the note did not say what had been discussed. She requested the reporter’s notebook from the newspaper archive and found that the page for that date was missing from the bound volume. The omission could have occurred during binding or later handling; she did not call it deliberate. She photographed the surrounding pages and documented the gap so the archivist could investigate it independently.

The two trails converged on the same administrative period, but they did not yet prove that one missing record had caused the other to disappear. Badu asked the team to draw separate arrows on the case board for confirmed transfers, reported transfers and suspected transfers. The result looked untidy, a tangle of solid

lines and dotted ones. He preferred it that way. A clean diagram could be satisfying while hiding how much of the case rested on inference. The next step was to find a person who had handled the file and could explain the gaps from direct knowledge.

When Mensah finally returned Badu’s call, he sounded tired and wary. He said he had not disappeared because he had changed his mind; he had found an old colleague waiting outside his building and feared that any meeting would put the man at risk. He refused to identify the colleague over the phone. Badu offered a meeting at the prosecutor’s office with a support person present, but Mensah asked for one day to think. The call ended without a promise. Badu recorded the time and content, then informed the prosecutor. He did not send officers to the colleague’s home on the strength of an unverified remark.

That night the team compared the dispatch entry with the surviving statement and the duty roster. The dates were close enough to matter, but not enough to prove that the envelope contained the altered register or that Ofori had handled it. The investigation now had a missing-file trail, a possible destination for a duplicate, and a witness whose fear had become a fact in its own right. Badu wrote three tasks beneath the chart: locate the panel copy, verify the clerk’s account independently, and arrange Mensah’s statement safely. The anonymous warning remained pinned beside them. It explained the pressure surrounding the case; it did not identify the person applying it.

The archive's inventory clerk, Ama Biney, met the team in a records room where the shelves were labelled by year and transfer category. She explained that a file could be recorded as dispatched without a receiving office ever confirming delivery. The system had relied on carbon copies and handwritten initials; a missing receipt might indicate loss, negligence or deliberate removal. She showed Badu how to read the ledger's cancellation marks and warned him that an overwritten reference number

could be an ordinary correction. The relevant entry had two different inks, but no one could yet say whether they had been applied on the same day.

Biney agreed to provide a certified copy of the ledger and a statement explaining the archive's procedures. She refused to speculate about Ofori or Asare. ‘If you want me to help you, let me tell you what this book can prove, ’ she said. Badu respected the boundary. The ledger could establish that a packet had been recorded and that its destination was unclear; it could not establish what the packet contained or who had taken it. The team now had a narrower search: identify every office that used the transfer code and compare its incoming register with the archive's dispatch copy. It was slow work, but it offered a route from suspicion to verifiable fact.

The file audit began with a simple inventory. Every page was numbered, photographed and compared against the index. The gaps did not form a neat sequence, which weakened the idea that a single person had removed a whole section at once. Some missing items had been listed as transferred; others had no movement note at all. The records officer explained that files were sometimes split between departments when a matter involved both a confidential appointment and a child-welfare concern. That practice could account for part of the confusion, though not for the altered entry.

A retired clerk’s name appeared beside one transfer number, but the signature could not yet be authenticated. The team contacted the clerk’s family through the appropriate office and learned that several boxes of work papers had been retained after his death. The family agreed to let an archivist inspect them. Investigators did not seize the papers on the strength of a hunch; they documented the voluntary handover and provided a receipt.

Inside one box was a list of file references, including the missing packet's number, but no packet itself.

Badu used the list to map the file's journey. It had passed through at least three offices, and each transfer created an opportunity for error or interference. The map also exposed an assumption in the team's earlier theory: the person who altered the register might not have been the person who removed the pages. The two acts could be connected, but they required separate evidence. Badu wrote that distinction on the board in the incident room, underlining it once. A theory that could not survive a competing explanation was not ready to become a conclusion.

The Inventory Dispute

The records office challenged the team's request for the complete inventory, arguing that some references belonged to unrelated confidential matters. The prosecutor responded with a narrower request listing the dates, shelf codes and transfer numbers already identified in the investigation. The office then produced a ledger that had not appeared in the first search. Its pages were intact, but one line had been overwritten in a darker ink. The correction was initialled by an officer who had retired before the judge's death.

An independent records specialist compared the ledger with the transfer receipt. The specialist could confirm that the overwritten line had been changed after the surrounding entries, but could not establish the date of alteration or the identity of the writer. A second source, the dispatch book, showed that a sealed packet had left the office that afternoon. The two records corroborated the movement of a packet, not its contents. Badu asked the team to avoid calling it the missing register until a physical match could be established.

The distinction frustrated the officers who wanted a breakthrough, but the prosecutor welcomed it. If the packet was

eventually recovered, its chain of custody would matter as much as its contents. If it was not, the team still had evidence that an unexplained transfer had occurred. The investigation was beginning to reveal a pattern of official decisions that could be documented even when the motives behind them remained disputed.

Mabel prepared a diagram showing the known transfers, the uncertain transfers and the period for which no record survived. She used different line styles instead of colouring every gap as suspicious. When Badu reviewed it, he asked her to include the most ordinary explanation for each missing entry. They needed to know which gaps were unusual, not pretend that every administrative omission was part of a conspiracy.

Badu asked for the names of everyone who had handled the box and for the retention policy that applied at the time. The office could not produce a complete list. Staff had changed, and some routine movements had never required a signature. The gaps were recorded in the report. A broken chain did not automatically make every surviving document false, but it limited the conclusions that could safely be drawn from it.

The records officer reconstructed the packet’s journey from the surviving transfer slips. One receipt showed that a box had been moved from the review office to temporary storage; another recorded its return, but the handwriting on the second slip was not yet attributed to a known clerk. The inventory number matched the missing packet only after an older numbering scheme was taken into account. That made the lead stronger, but it also showed why the team could not announce that the packet had been found when all they had was a trail of references.

The Chain Of Custody

The File’s Journey

The records team created a movement chart for the missing file, listing every office named in the surviving transfer slips. The chart was deliberately plain: date, sender, receiver, reference number and source. Where the evidence was missing, the space remained blank. Badu had asked for a narrative, but the records officer explained that a narrative could conceal the gaps the team needed to see.

Three transfers were documented; two were supported only by initials. One office had been renamed twice and its archive split between two successor departments. The team sent preservation notices to both. A clerk found a box list that mentioned the appointment review but not Haven House, while another found a receipt for a sealed packet whose reference number differed by one digit.

The discrepancy might have been a typing error. It might also mean that two packets had been handled under similar references. The team did not choose between those possibilities. They requested the original receipt and the register used to allocate numbers that year. The old numbering system had been partly handwritten, making the comparison slow but necessary.

Mabel traced the names of two clerks who had signed the movement sheets. One had died; the other had moved to another region and was willing to be interviewed. She gave Badu the contact details and explained which information had come from public records and which had come from a source who asked not to be named.

The living clerk remembered a review panel that met after ordinary office hours. She recalled carrying files into a room and being told to leave them on a side table. She could not say whether the Haven House packet was among them. She had not

seen the contents and did not recognise the names when Badu read them aloud.

Her statement narrowed the search without solving it. Badu added the room and the likely date to the chart, then marked the clerk's memory as approximate. The file had not vanished in a single mysterious act; it had travelled through a bureaucracy where incomplete logs, informal instructions and later reorganisations created opportunities for concealment.

Badu added the receipt to the chronology and marked the link as provisional. The case was no longer only about a missing document. It was about a sequence of transfers in which ordinary safeguards had failed, been bypassed, or never been completed. To find out which, the team would need the people who signed the logs—and evidence independent of their memories.

The most useful result came from a routine receipt book in a neighbouring series. It showed that a sealed packet had been delivered to the review unit on the same afternoon as the register. The receipt named a messenger but not the packet's contents. The messenger had died, and the signature could not be compared with a reliable sample. The entry established movement of an item, not what the item contained. Still, it gave the investigators a date, an office and a list of people who could have been on duty.

Mabel compared the paper index with a microfilm copy. A faint line appeared beneath the crossed-out code, but it was impossible to determine whether it was a letter, a numeral, or damage in the film. She asked a technician to scan the frame at different settings and preserve the unaltered image alongside any enhanced versions. The enhanced copy made the line easier to see but also introduced shapes that were not visible in the original. The technician advised that the enhancement could guide a search, not serve as proof of a character's identity.

The team requested the relevant boxes through the proper records process. The archive staff warned that the labels had changed when the office moved buildings. Two boxes were found quickly; a third was listed in a disposal schedule but had no destruction certificate attached. The absence of a certificate did not prove that the box still existed. It meant the archive could not establish what had happened to it.

A retired clerk, Mr Osei, was interviewed with a union representative present. He remembered the review unit’s practice of keeping sensitive annexes in a separate cabinet, but he would not identify a particular officer based on a code he had not seen for more than twenty years. He did recall that the cabinet key was held by two authorised staff members and signed out in a ledger. That ledger might have been archived under the unit’s administrative records rather than the case file itself.

The supervisor brought out a training manual and an example from an unrelated case. Files sent between units were supposed to be listed by reference number, page count, date, and the name of the receiving officer. If a sealed annex travelled separately, it required its own entry. In the Haven House file, the main folder had a page count, but the annex field was blank. Someone had written a short code in the margin, then crossed it out. The supervisor could not identify the writer from the copy alone.

The records office had not lost every trace of the missing file. Its paper index listed a transfer to a review unit, while the electronic index showed the file as returned. The discrepancy had been treated as a clerical mismatch for years because neither entry was accompanied by a signed receipt. Badu asked the archive supervisor to explain the office’s normal procedure before anyone labelled the difference suspicious.

The Archive’s Duplicate

The Number That Changed Hands

The archive technician, Tetteh, asked Badu to stand on the public side of the counter while she opened the register. She had been instructed not to let the original volume leave the records room, and she followed that instruction even after Asare’s office called twice. A rule that applied only when convenient, she said, was not a rule worth keeping.

The entry for the missing attachment had been made in blue ink. The corresponding receipt number was in black, and the handwriting looked similar but not identical. Tetteh would not call it a forgery. Ink colour alone proved little; different pens could be used on the same day, and a clerk might complete a line later. What mattered was that the number pointed to a transfer receipt that was not in the expected bundle.

She retrieved the daily index and laid it beside the register. A carbon copy recorded the file as received at the annex, while the main ledger marked the same number as retained at headquarters. Both entries carried initials that might belong to the same clerk. The inconsistency could have been a routine copying error, but it meant the team could not say where the attachment had gone without finding the receipt or interviewing the people who handled it.

Badu asked whether the record could be photographed. Tetteh checked the authorization, wrote the time and purpose in the access log, and watched as he took the images. She then made a certified copy through the office procedure. The steps were slow enough to irritate an impatient investigator, but each one protected the record from a later claim that it had been altered during the inquiry.

‘Someone could have planned for a missing paper, ’ Badu said. ‘Or a missing paper could be making us imagine a planner.’

‘Exactly, ’ Tetteh replied. ‘The record tells you that two offices disagreed. It does not tell you why.’

She remembered a courier who had arrived near closing time during the period in question. He had carried a sealed envelope and complained that the receiving clerk was gone. Tetteh could not identify the envelope now, and she would not claim it contained the attachment. Her memory supplied a name for the next interview, not an answer.

The courier’s old duty roster had been archived separately. Badu requested it through the records supervisor and asked that the original remain untouched. He also arranged for a second officer to witness the retrieval. By then the case had taught him that a document could be genuine and still tell only part of the truth.

On the drive back, Badu reviewed the photographs. The number appeared three times, but in one place the final digit could be read as either a three or an eight. He entered both possibilities in his notes. A careless investigator would choose the digit that matched the theory. A careful one would search for both and record what each search produced.

The Missing Number

The records officer found that the missing items in Mensah’s file had not simply been removed from the box. An old inventory listed an annex number that had been crossed out and replaced with a reference to a separate restricted series. The replacement ink was not recent enough to date confidently, and the person who made it was unknown. Still, the entry suggested that someone had changed the filing route rather than destroyed every trace of the papers.

Badu requested the accession register for the restricted series. The first search returned nothing because the catalogue used the department’s former name. A second search, using the old administrative code, produced a card that had been filed under “miscellaneous correspondence.” The card listed a sealed packet, a transfer date and the initials of a receiving clerk. It did not identify the contents, but it offered a way to test the route described by Mensah.

The prosecutor warned the team not to describe the card as the missing register. It might refer to an unrelated packet or a routine transfer. Badu agreed and asked for the original card to be photographed in place before removal. For years, the case had been driven by the belief that a single person had hidden a single document. The new lead suggested a more complicated possibility: the record had been broken into pieces, moved through several offices, and made difficult to find without being completely erased.

CHAPTER TEN

The Appointment Review

Deputy Commissioner Asare watched the news of Agyeman's death and retrieved a confidential file concerning a judicial appointment review. The review had been delayed by a disputed document from 2004. One memorandum warned that the altered identity could affect the reliability of evidence considered by the panel.

Asare had told himself that the arrangements were temporary and intended to protect innocent people. The records had never been corrected, however, and the child had grown up without knowing the truth. Agyeman had written recently that the arrangement had failed and that the original record could not withstand another review.

Badu obtained the portions of the appointment file relevant to Haven House. They confirmed that officials feared the child's original identity might undermine an earlier decision, but they did not establish who had altered the register or who had benefited. A note written three weeks before Agyeman's death referred to a missing witness who had to be located before the matter could be reopened.

With an independent legal officer present, Badu studied the file. The paperwork revealed a pattern rather than one signed order: a restricted annex, a postponed hearing, a witness removed from accessible copies and an identity change described as temporary. Each step could be defended in isolation. Together, they had made the original event almost impossible to reconstruct.

Asare had signed a memorandum recommending that the disputed record be set aside until the witness could be located.

The review proceeded without the missing testimony, and the temporary measure became permanent. Asare had never considered himself a criminal. He had considered himself practical, choosing to contain a scandal rather than expose an institution to it. But the correction he expected never came, and each new official inherited the silence as precedent.

When an aide asked whether the folder should be destroyed, Asare refused. He would not create another offence to conceal the first. Still, he removed one page and placed it in his desk. It recorded Ofori's access to the annex. Asare told himself he was preserving it until he understood what Badu had discovered. His decision left him with evidence that might help the investigation—and another secret that could implicate him in the cover-up.

For nearly an hour after the aide left, Asare sat with the page face down on his desk. It was not an original signature sheet, only a carbon copy of an access memorandum. The entry showed that Ofori had requested the restricted annex on a date when the official visitor register recorded no such visit. A short notation beside the entry read: 'Reviewed under verbal authority.' No name followed it.

Asare knew what Badu would ask first: who had given the verbal authority, and why had the entry been excluded from the copy released to investigators? He could answer the second question. He had ordered the file prepared for limited disclosure and had allowed the page to be left out because he believed it would confuse the review. That explanation had sounded reasonable at the time. Now it sounded like the beginning of a defence prepared too late.

He called the independent legal officer assigned to the inquiry. He did not send the page electronically or ask an aide to carry it. Instead, he sealed it in an evidence envelope, signed across the flap, and recorded the time. The officer arrived with a

clerk who entered the transfer in a separate register. Asare watched the page disappear into a transparent sleeve and felt the first small relief of the day: at least this piece would no longer depend on his memory or his discretion.

‘You should have disclosed it when the first request came,’ the officer said.

‘Yes,’ Asare replied. He had expected to explain the omission. The single word left him with no room to hide inside procedure.

The officer asked whether the notation referred to a particular conversation. Asare said he remembered a meeting in which Ofori argued that the child’s identity should remain restricted until the appointment review was complete. He could not swear that Ofori had ordered the alteration, and he had never seen him write on the register. What Asare could confirm was that Ofori had access to the annex and that Asare had helped keep the access trail out of the ordinary file.

The legal officer asked Asare to describe the review as he had understood it at the time, before showing him the memorandum. Asare said the process had been suspended because a witness’s statement raised questions about the child’s identity. He claimed he believed the suspension would be brief and that the record would be corrected once the witness had been located. The officer asked why no deadline or written follow-up had been issued. Asare had no satisfactory answer. He said he had trusted another office to act, and that trust had gradually become a reason not to check.

The memorandum itself was carefully worded. It recommended postponement, not destruction, and referred to the witness only by an internal code. Its date preceded the public notice stating that the review had been administratively concluded. The two documents did not prove that Asare had

ordered a falsification, but they showed that he knew the review was unresolved when the public notice appeared. The legal officer took both originals into custody and arranged for a document examiner to compare the copies held by the archive.

Asare asked whether his cooperation would protect him from prosecution. The officer said no promise could be made; his statement would be assessed with the rest of the evidence. Asare looked toward the window, where the afternoon traffic moved in slow lines. For years, he had treated the review as a file that could be reopened when circumstances were safer. Now he saw that the delay had itself shaped people’s lives. He agreed to identify the other officials who had received the memorandum, though he warned that some were dead and others might deny remembering it.

The statement was recorded, read back to him, and amended where his wording had been too vague. Asare signed each page. He knew that a signed statement would not repair the damage, and that his cooperation might not protect him from disciplinary or criminal scrutiny. It was the first time he had accepted that those consequences were not an unfortunate price paid by the institution; they were consequences of decisions he had made.

Before leaving, the legal officer asked whether any other document remained outside the file. Asare thought of the memorandum he had kept years earlier, the one recommending that the review be postponed until the missing witness was found. He disclosed its existence and agreed to surrender it. The inquiry now had two documents that could be compared against the official copies. Whether they proved deliberate tampering or a chain of careless decisions remained to be established.

After Asare signed his statement, the prosecutor asked for a separate chronology of the decisions he had taken during the appointment review. Asare described meetings, telephone calls and instructions passed through assistants. Several details

contradicted his earlier account, particularly the date on which he first learned that the register had been altered. He tried to explain the discrepancy as confusion over whether he had seen the original or a photocopy. The prosecutor recorded both versions and asked him to identify any diary, calendar or office log that could settle the question.

Asare named a former secretary who had kept appointment books after retirement. The team contacted her through counsel and asked her to preserve the books without searching or removing pages. She agreed, but warned that she could not promise every year had survived. Asare looked older when he left the room. He had cooperated, yet the statement had made his responsibility more visible, not less. Badu reminded himself that cooperation did not equal innocence, just as a contradiction did not automatically prove guilt. Each person would be assessed against the documents and the sequence of events. The case was becoming clearer, but it was also becoming less simple.

Asare’s formal statement took most of the afternoon. He described the appointment review as a confidential administrative process and insisted that he had never ordered a register to be altered. The legal officer asked why a document had been withheld from the initial disclosure. Asare said he believed it belonged to a separate file and had not understood its relevance. That explanation could be innocent, careless or self-serving; the statement alone did not decide which. He was asked to identify every person who had access to the document and to provide the relevant office circulars.

During a break, Asare asked Badu whether the case had become personal. Badu replied that the evidence would be assessed by people who had no family connection to him and no reason to protect his father’s reputation. He did not argue about motive. Independent oversight would remain in place whether the next discovery supported or undermined Badu’s theory.

Asare seemed to understand that the process had moved beyond private assurances.

The legal officer later found a reference to a sealed annex that was not listed in the copy first supplied to investigators. The annex might contain a routine administrative explanation, but its omission mattered because the file index said it existed. A request was made for the original and a written explanation of its custody. No one was allowed to open the seal without a witness, photographs and a record of the time. The case was advancing by procedure rather than revelation, and every careful step narrowed the space in which a false account could survive.

The Anonymous Message

Badu's team traced the anonymous message through a series of public access points, but each lead ended in a place used by dozens of people. The sender knew enough to frighten Mabel without giving them a reliable path back.

Then Mensah's message arrived: I have remembered something. Meet tomorrow. Come alone. Badu replied that he would meet him, but not without telling his superintendent where he was going. If Mensah was in danger, secrecy would not protect him. Badu prepared a second team to remain nearby and placed the message in the evidence log. By morning, the former inspector had disappeared again.

The team did not treat the word disappeared as proof that Mensah had been abducted. His room at the guesthouse was empty, but his bag and medication were gone too. The receptionist remembered a man collecting him before dawn, although she could not identify the visitor and could not be sure whether Mensah had left willingly. Badu asked her to write down what she remembered before discussing the detail with other staff.

The number Mensah had used to contact Badu went straight to voicemail. A technician confirmed only that the message had passed through an ordinary mobile network; the available data did not reveal who had physically held the phone. Badu resisted the urge to turn the missing man into a dramatic certainty. Mensah might be frightened, ill, avoiding the inquiry, or under pressure. Each possibility required a different response, and none could yet be ruled out.

Badu notified the superintendent and requested that Mensah be entered as a person whose whereabouts needed to be

established, not as a confirmed victim of a crime. A patrol checked the nearby transport stations and hospitals using the proper channels. Another officer preserved the guesthouse's visitor book and asked whether any camera footage remained. The first search produced no reliable sighting, but it created a record against which later claims could be tested.

At the guesthouse, Badu found that the page for the previous night had been folded back at the binding. The receptionist said she had noticed it that morning and had not altered it. The crease passed through two entries, making the times difficult to read. A forensic examiner would need to inspect the original before anyone could claim that a name had been erased. Badu photographed the page in place, then arranged for it to be secured.

One entry remained legible beneath the fold: a visitor had asked for Mensah by his former rank and waited less than ten minutes. The name column contained only an initial, 'K.' It might have been a surname, a first initial, or a mark made by the receptionist. Badu wrote down all three possibilities. The detail was useful precisely because it was incomplete.

When he told Mabel about the visitor, she asked whether the initial could refer to K. B. Mensah himself. Badu said it could, and that it could also be a deliberate attempt to point them toward him. They agreed not to circulate the photograph of the register beyond the investigation team. A public leak could warn the visitor, damage a witness's memory, or turn an ambiguous mark into a fact in the public mind.

Later that afternoon, a sealed envelope arrived at the station addressed to Badu. It contained a photocopy of a transfer form and no covering letter. The signature at the bottom was partly cut off, but the date matched the day the Haven House register was

altered. The form named a receiving officer whose signature did not appear in the surviving appointment file.

Badu logged the envelope, photographed its contents, and asked the document examiner to compare the copy with the known forms. He did not assume the sender was Mensah. The paper might have come from the missing inspector, the anonymous source, or someone trying to steer the inquiry. Its value lay in the details that could be independently checked: the date, the form number, the receiving officer, and the missing original.

By evening, the superintendent approved a discreet search for the receiving officer and a formal request for the original transfer ledger. Badu returned to the case board and moved Mensah's name away from the column marked 'suspects'. He placed it beneath 'missing witness', with a question mark beside it. The investigation had not found Mensah, but it had found another document that could explain why somebody wanted him silent—or why he wanted to remain hidden.

Mabel compared the anonymous photograph with the image she had found in her own box. The angle was different, but a broken section of wall appeared in both. The anonymous sender had access to a private memory and a public location. That could mean the sender was one of the children, someone who had worked at Haven House, or an investigator who had kept copies of the records.

She refused to publish the photograph. Her editor argued that a story about a dead judge and missing children would dominate the news cycle. Mabel replied that a headline could not substitute for verification. If she published a false identification, the person responsible

for the altered records would gain a reason to dismiss every other finding. Instead, she asked the editor to protect her notes and give her time to verify the source. It was the first time she had told a colleague that the story might concern her own childhood. The admission made the newsroom feel smaller, but it also meant she no longer had to pretend she was untouched by the investigation.

The anonymous photograph showed a man standing beside the side entrance of Haven House. His face was blurred by movement, but the watch on his wrist was visible: a dark strap split near the buckle. Daniel had remembered a similar watch in Room Four. That resemblance was not enough to identify the man, but it was enough to keep the image from being dismissed.

Mabel met Badu in a café where the tables were close together and nobody could speak privately for long. They compared what they knew, carefully avoiding the exchange of original evidence. Mabel had the photograph and the date of the anonymous message. Badu had the altered register and the witness statement. Each piece made more sense beside the other, but neither completed the picture.

“Someone is guiding us,” Mabel said.

“Or trying to make us think we’re being guided.”

She accepted the distinction. They agreed to document every new contact and not to meet unknown sources alone. Mabel had spent years believing that persistence meant going wherever a story led. Now she understood that a source could be frightened, compromised or deliberately deceptive.

Her phone vibrated beneath the table. A message appeared: *The fifth child is alive. Ask who signed the transfer.*

Mabel showed Badu without replying. He photographed the screen for the record and asked the technical team to preserve the message metadata. The sender had given them a useful question but no reliable answer.

That evening, Mabel returned to the photograph of the children. She placed tracing paper over it and marked each face, not as a suspect list but as a promise not to let any child vanish into a category. She could not yet say which of the five had become the missing witness. She could say that the story had survived because someone, somewhere, had refused to throw the photograph away.

That evening, Mabel received a photograph of a diary page. The handwriting matched the style on the note recovered by Adwoa, though a specialist would need to verify it. The message accompanying it said only: *She kept what they told her to destroy.*

They arranged to have the property inventory reviewed and asked the driver to make a formal statement. Mabel also contacted the former staff member’s last known neighbour, who remembered a woman leaving in a hurry but could not say whether she had been threatened.

“That is better than a question pretending to be an answer,” Badu replied.

“Every lead creates another question,” Mabel said.

She and Badu met to compare the leads. The driver’s account aligned with the transfer note but did not identify the person who authorised it. The safe might contain the missing pages, but no one knew whether it had been opened after the judge’s death.

The former driver agreed to meet Badu at the station rather than at his home. He arrived carrying a small notebook in which he had recorded fuel purchases and delivery dates for his own

accounts. The notebook did not mention the child by name, but one entry showed a trip to the side gate on the date of the transfer. He remembered being told to wait while a sealed parcel was carried inside. He could not identify the person who carried it. Badu photographed the page, took a formal statement and returned the notebook after the agreed examination.

Mabel's third caller proved less reliable than the first. The caller claimed that the judge's safe contained the missing pages, but could not explain how they knew this. A property inventory confirmed that a safe existed in the study, yet the safe had been opened by police under documented conditions and contained ordinary legal papers, not the missing diary pages. Mabel recorded the discrepancy and informed her editor. The rumour might have been mistaken, outdated or deliberately planted. She would not repeat it as fact simply because it sounded like a breakthrough.

Badu asked the team to review the security around the witnesses without treating every anonymous message as an imminent attack. The driver received a contact number and instructions to report any direct approach. Mensah's location remained confidential while his statement was being checked. Mabel's editor arranged for another reporter to accompany her on late assignments. These were precautions, not proof that the suspects were watching them. Badu wanted the team safe, but he also wanted their decisions to remain proportionate to what they knew.

Mabel logged each call and assigned a confidence level to the information, not to the caller's character. The driver was willing to provide a statement. The second caller offered only a rumour. The third had details that could be checked against the judge's property inventory.

The first caller was a former driver who had delivered supplies to Haven House. He remembered being told to use the

side gate on the day of the transfer, though he could not recall who gave the instruction. The second caller claimed to know the missing staff member but would not provide a name. The third said the judge had kept copies of old records in a private safe.

The driver who had delivered supplies to Haven House provided a statement at the prosecutor's office. He remembered being redirected to the side gate and seeing a government vehicle parked near the administrative wing. He could not identify its occupants, and he admitted that his memory had been refreshed by newspaper coverage. The prosecutor separated details he recalled before reading the reports from details he learned later. That distinction weakened some parts of his account but left others available for comparison with delivery records and the gate book.

Mabel asked to see the statement, but Badu refused while the witness's account was being verified. She protested that she was part of the story. Badu replied that she was also a potential witness, and that publicising details could unintentionally shape another person's memory. He offered to tell her which records she could independently request. Mabel accepted the limit, reluctantly. Later she wrote in her notebook that being close to the case did not grant her ownership of every piece of evidence. The lesson felt personal: she had spent years trying to recover a childhood memory, and now she had to protect it from the very story she wanted to publish.

The guesthouse manager remembered the visitor because he had asked for a room without giving a telephone number. She could not identify him with certainty from the first photograph Badu showed her, so the detective stopped the exercise and asked her to describe the encounter in her own words. Only afterward did the team conduct a properly documented identification procedure. The manager’s first description was modest: middle-aged, neat shirt, carried a folder, spoke quietly. It was not enough to name Mensah, and Badu did not pretend otherwise.

The register entry had been written in a hand that differed from the signature on the payment receipt. That could mean one person had filled the form for another, or that the manager had completed it later. The guesthouse had changed ownership, and the old booking software was no longer available. Staff located a paper receipt book in storage, but the page containing the relevant transaction had a torn corner. An examiner would need to determine whether the damage was accidental or deliberate; the team could not infer intent from the tear alone.

Badu arranged for Mensah's lawyer to be informed that a new lead had emerged. He did not send officers to seize the retired inspector merely to create pressure. The guesthouse record would first be authenticated, then compared with transport, telephone and witness evidence. If Mensah had been there, investigators needed to establish when and why. If he had not, the same record might reveal someone using his name. Either possibility changed the case, but neither justified a conclusion yet.

The Missing Witness Protocol

The team reviewed its procedure for contacting witnesses after the anonymous messages. No officer would visit a witness alone; contact attempts would be logged; and no one would disclose Daniel's current address to a person whose role had not been verified. These safeguards slowed the work, but they also made it harder for someone inside the investigation to manipulate a witness privately. Badu knew that the precautions could not guarantee safety. They could, however, make later claims about intimidation easier to investigate.

A possible witness named in the guesthouse ledger was located through a former employer. She agreed to speak by video after confirming the investigators' identities through the station's public number. She denied having seen Mensah at the guesthouse, but remembered a man asking the receptionist

whether a retired inspector had arrived. The description was too general to identify the man. Her statement was still useful because it separated a verified memory from the rumour that had grown around it.

The witness also recalled that the guesthouse had replaced its handwritten ledger with a digital system years earlier. The original book had been stored in a box after an audit, then moved when the business changed ownership. The owner agreed to preserve the box for the investigators. It was not a dramatic revelation, but it offered a practical route to testing the entry rather than repeating it as fact.

Mensah then supplied a list of former colleagues who might remember the transfer process. He warned that some were elderly and some had died. Badu arranged for contact to be made through official channels, with no promise of immunity and no suggestion that cooperation would erase earlier conduct. Mensah signed the list and asked that his family not be contacted unless necessary. The request was noted, and the team proceeded without turning his private life into leverage.

The account did not resolve who had made the call. The number had been masked, and the wording could have come from someone who knew the case or from someone hoping to make the witness appear more important than he was. Badu ensured that the threat was recorded separately from Mensah’s evidence about Haven House. Fear could explain a person’s conduct; it could not confirm the truth of every statement that followed.

When Mensah finally returned to the station, he did not arrive alone. His lawyer accompanied him, and he carried a written account of the hours he had been away. He said he had gone to stay with a relative after receiving a threatening call and had switched off his phone because he feared it could be tracked. Investigators verified the relative’s address and asked for permission to check the relevant travel records. Mensah agreed

to the limited checks but refused to hand over his personal phone without legal advice.

The Missing Witness Returns

When questioned about why he had not raised the matter after the promised correction failed to occur, Asare said he had assumed another office had taken responsibility. Badu asked whether he had checked. Asare did not answer immediately. His silence was not treated as an admission, but the written record now showed a precise question that he had not answered. The investigation had moved beyond a contest of personalities and toward a sequence of decisions that could be compared with the documentary record.

A former secretary remembered preparing a folder for the meeting but could not recall who collected it. She identified a filing code that had been used for confidential appointment reviews. That code appeared on one of the surviving transfer slips. The connection justified a search of the corresponding storage series; it did not establish that Asare had personally removed anything.

Asare’s office diary was compared with his written response in the presence of his lawyer. The diary confirmed a meeting on the relevant date, but its brief entry did not identify the child or the documents discussed. Asare said the meeting concerned an urgent administrative problem and that he had relied on advice from staff who described the identity change as temporary. He denied directing anyone to falsify a register. The investigators recorded both the corroborated meeting and the limits of what the diary proved.

Asare’s calendar

The Terms of Asare’s Cooperation

Asare’s lawyer proposed that his client provide a further statement in exchange for clarity about the scope of the

interview. The prosecutor refused to promise immunity or a favourable outcome. Instead, the parties agreed that questions would be recorded, that relevant documents would be disclosed according to procedure, and that Asare could consult counsel before answering matters that might expose him to criminal liability.

Asare arrived carrying a slim folder. He looked tired, but he had arranged the papers in date order. The first was a memorandum recommending that the appointment review be postponed. The second was a handwritten note instructing staff to keep the child's identity out of the general file. Neither document contained an explicit order to falsify the register. Both showed that senior officials had created a system in which ordinary staff were expected to understand an instruction that was never fully written down.

Badu asked why Asare had not objected. Asare said he had believed the delay would last only until the review was complete. He had been told that the child's placement would be regularised later and that public disclosure could harm the child. He admitted that he had not insisted on a deadline, a written authorisation or independent oversight.

'You may not have written the false entry, ' Badu said, 'but you helped build the conditions in which it could survive.'

Asare looked at the memorandum for a long time. 'That is fair, ' he said. 'It is not the same as saying I ordered it.'

The prosecutor recorded both statements. The distinction mattered. Responsibility could include more than the person who physically altered a page, but it still had to be proved through conduct, authority and intent rather than moral disapproval alone.

Asare identified a meeting secretary who might remember the review panel's instructions. The secretary had retired and lived outside Accra. The team would need to locate him and establish whether his recollection could be corroborated. Asare's cooperation gave the investigation a direction, not a conclusion.

After the interview, the prosecutor warned Badu not to treat the folder as a confession. Some documents supported Asare's account; others raised new questions. The investigation now had to test whether the postponement had become a cover for deliberate falsification, and who had benefited when the promised correction never came.

Asare's Second Interview

Asare arrived for the second interview with his lawyer and a folder of carefully arranged copies. He had numbered the pages and placed a note beside each document explaining why he believed it supported his account. The preparation impressed the prosecutor, but it also made the gaps easier to see. The folder contained a copy of the appointment-review minutes, yet no original. It included a summary of the transfer decision, but not the annex that should have recorded who authorised the change to the register.

Asare said the original annex had been held by another office and that he had never personally seen the altered page. The prosecutor asked why his signature appeared on a routing slip attached to the packet. Asare studied the copy for a long time before saying that his signature confirmed receipt of the file, not agreement with its contents. That was possible, but it meant the routing slip could not establish what he knew unless other records or testimony placed the information before him.

Badu asked whether Asare had spoken to Ofori after the judge's death. Asare said he had called him to ask whether the old review records had been secured. He insisted the call was administrative. The call log confirmed contact, but not its

subject. The prosecutor warned Badu not to describe the call as evidence of collusion unless the content could be established through a recording, a witness or an admission.

Asare's lawyer requested a copy of every document relied on in the questioning. The prosecutor agreed within the rules governing disclosure and noted the request in the record. Badu understood why the procedure mattered. An investigation that withheld inconvenient material could damage its own case, even if the underlying suspicion was justified.

At the end, Asare offered to identify two retired officials who had attended the review meeting. One was seriously ill; the other lived abroad. The offer might be an attempt to redirect attention, or it might lead to useful testimony. Badu recorded both names and made no promise about what their statements would prove. The next step was to interview them independently, before their memories or accounts could be shaped by one another.

Asare’s Choice

After the second interview, Asare asked Nyarko whether a person could cooperate with an investigation and still be held responsible for what he had done. Nyarko said cooperation did not erase conduct; it could clarify it. Asare looked at the copies in his folder and admitted that he had allowed a temporary arrangement to become permanent because correcting it would have exposed the review panel’s conduct. He had told himself that the child was safe and that no one would be harmed by a delay.

Badu asked why he had not gone back to Agyeman when the promised correction failed. Asare said the judge had become the only person who still insisted that the record be repaired, and their conversations grew more hostile. That explained a conflict, not the murder. Asare denied entering the judge’s residence on the night of the death and agreed to provide phone records and his calendar for independent comparison.

Nyarko made it clear that the team would verify the material rather than accept it because Asare had volunteered it. His lawyer requested a written list of the documents taken into evidence. The process was slow, but it made the next step possible: the prosecution could compare his account with the official timetable, the visitor records and the testimony of people who had attended the review. Asare had finally begun to describe his own decisions, but he had not yet answered every question about them.

PART THREE — THE LIVING LIE

CHAPTER ELEVEN

The Witness Who Disappeared

By the end of the day, the search had produced leads but no verified location. Badu briefed the prosecutor on what was known and what remained speculation. The prosecutor approved further inquiries while warning that the investigation could not use Mensah's absence to fill gaps in the case against Ofori. One uncertainty could not be used as proof of another.

That difference did not make the sighting worthless; it made it uncertain. The team preserved the original guest register and checked whether the date could be independently confirmed through the guesthouse's payment records. Meanwhile, Badu arranged for Mensah's lawyer to receive a direct contact number. If Mensah had chosen to leave, he deserved a chance to say so without being publicly cast as either victim or culprit. If he had been pressured, a careful process gave him a better chance to return safely.

A call from a small guesthouse produced a possible sighting. A staff member remembered a quiet older man who had asked to use the telephone and paid cash, but the guest register entry was incomplete. The description fit Mensah in some respects and did not fit in others. Badu sent two officers to speak to the staff member separately and asked them not to show a photograph until they had recorded the witness's unaided memory. Their notes differed on the man's height and the colour of his shirt.

The anonymous envelope found earlier was examined again. The transfer form inside bore a reference number that matched the archive index, but the paper stock was common and the handwriting had not been authenticated. It could have come from an original record, a photocopy, or a reconstruction made by

someone who had seen the file. The investigators sent it for document examination and asked the archive to verify the number against its own registers.

Badu resisted the temptation to describe Mensah as a kidnapped witness in briefings. Such language could frighten other witnesses and lead investigators to interpret every unknown person as a suspect. The official notice said only that Mensah's whereabouts were unknown and that anyone with reliable information should contact the team. His lawyer was informed and asked to pass along a message that Mensah could make contact without first agreeing to a full interview.

A patrol officer visited Mensah's registered address and spoke with a neighbour who had seen him leave with a small bag. The neighbour could not remember the exact time and had not seen anyone force him into a vehicle. A transport clerk at the station remembered a man resembling Mensah asking about a bus to Cape Coast, but the description was too general to rely on. Investigators requested any available terminal records and checked the hospitals through the proper missing-person procedure.

The report that Mensah had disappeared reached Badu through two separate channels. His phone had been unreachable since the previous afternoon, and he had missed an appointment with the lawyer who had been advising him about his statement. Neither fact, by itself, established that a crime had occurred. Mensah had been frightened, ashamed, ill, or simply unwilling to cooperate. The team began by checking the ordinary explanations.

The Empty Room

When Mensah's disappearance was first reported, Badu returned to the room where they had last met. The landlord

remembered that Mensah had asked for a quiet place and had paid for the hour in advance. The desk had been wiped, the rubbish emptied and the window left open to the courtyard. None of those details established that a crime had occurred. They established only that the room had been used and that ordinary traces were no longer available.

The team obtained the building’s visitor book and interviewed the caretaker separately. The book listed a delivery worker at a time close to Mensah’s departure, but the caretaker could not say whether the person had seen him. A nearby shop had a camera facing the road, though the footage had been overwritten under its normal retention schedule. Badu resisted the temptation to call the missing footage suspicious. It was a limitation, not evidence of interference.

Badu went to the terminal with an officer who had not heard the witness interviews. They spoke to the station supervisor first and asked what records were kept as a matter of routine, before describing Mensah. The supervisor produced a duty ledger and explained that cash passengers were not listed by name unless a ticket had been reserved or a receipt requested. A page for that afternoon showed a handwritten note about a passenger asking for the Cape Coast service, but it contained no name and no reliable description. It was a lead, not a match.

The worker who had reported the sighting was interviewed again, this time without being shown Mensah’s photograph. He remembered a small bag and a man who had asked whether the bus would stop along the way. He was less certain about the man’s age than he had been on the telephone. When Badu asked whether the passenger had seemed frightened, the worker shook his head. He had noticed no argument, no struggle and no one following the man. “I thought he was travelling,” he said. “I did not think I was watching anything else.”

Badu asked the supervisor to preserve the duty ledger and make a certified copy of the relevant page. He did not ask the staff to identify a passenger from a list of names they had never recorded. On the return journey, the accompanying officer said the absence of a confirmed sighting made the search feel as though it were going backwards. Badu answered that the team had learned something useful: the terminal could not prove where Mensah had gone, and the witness could not prove the man was Mensah. That boundary mattered. A false identification might send officers after the wrong person and leave Mensah harder to find.

At the station, Nyarko added the ledger to the search file but kept it separate from the evidence concerning Agyeman's death. She reminded the team that a missing witness and a homicide investigation could intersect without becoming the same case. If Mensah had travelled by choice, the team needed to respect that possibility. If someone had pressured him, they needed evidence of the pressure rather than a story built from his silence. The search would continue, but no one would be permitted to turn an unanswered question into a conclusion.

Nyarko approved a public appeal for information that did not reveal the contents of Mensah's statement. She also directed officers to contact his lawyer and family before circulating his photograph. The investigation had to find him without turning an uncertain disappearance into a dramatic story that might frighten him into silence. By evening, a bus station worker reported seeing an older man with a similar build carrying a small bag. The description was too broad to confirm identity, but it gave the team a location to check.

Asare's Written Response

Asare submitted a written response through his lawyer. He acknowledged attending a review meeting but denied ordering anyone to alter a child's identity. He said the arrangement had

been described to him as a protective measure and that he had relied on legal officers to correct the records when the review ended. He also admitted that he had failed to follow up when no correction appeared. The response was carefully worded, but it gave investigators a date, a room number and the names of two officials who had been present.

The prosecutor asked Badu to test those details independently. One official had died; the other was living outside the country and agreed to a remote interview. The surviving official remembered a disagreement about whether the child should be named in the appointment-review papers, but did not remember Asare giving an order. The account supported the existence of the dispute without confirming who had made the final decision. Badu added it to the evidence matrix rather than treating it as a confession by implication.

Asare later requested a private meeting with Badu. He said he had been afraid that disclosure would damage the institution and expose the people who had signed the original forms. Badu answered that institutions could survive embarrassment more easily than a permanent record of deliberate deception. Asare did not agree, but he gave permission for the relevant portion of his response to be verified against the office diary. It was the first practical cooperation he had offered, and it came too late to undo the years of silence.

The Reception Clerk

The name on Mensah’s list led them to Efua Mensima, a retired reception clerk who now lived with her daughter outside Cape Coast. She agreed to speak by video, but asked that the interview be recorded and that no one describe her as the person who had “lost” the file. Badu explained that the purpose was to establish what she remembered, not to assign blame before the records had been checked.

Efua remembered a sealed envelope arriving at the reception desk during the period of the Haven House review. She had entered it in the incoming-mail book, then placed it in the tray used for restricted correspondence. She could not remember who collected it. The signature column had been left blank on several entries that week, she said, because staff had been told that a senior officer would sign for the bundle later. She had complained once and been told not to delay the dispatch.

“Did you see the contents?” Nyarko asked. Efua said she had not opened the envelope. She remembered a paper clipped to the front, with a reference number and a handwritten note asking that an attachment be returned after the meeting. She could not recall the number or the exact wording. She also could not say whether the envelope was the same one Mensah had described. Badu asked her not to guess. The answer, she said, was that she remembered the process more clearly than the particular packet.

The incoming-mail book was still held in a records store, though the relevant volume had been moved twice during office renovations. Efua gave the team the approximate month and the name of the supervisor who had managed the tray. Investigators requested the book through the proper records procedure and asked an independent archivist to document its condition before anyone turned to the likely pages. Efua’s account was a lead that could be tested; it was not a substitute for the book itself.

Before ending the call, Efua mentioned that staff sometimes used the phrase “the fifth copy” when a document had an attachment not meant for general circulation. She did not know whether the phrase referred to a fifth child, a fifth page, or simply the number of copies made for a meeting. The wording caught Badu’s attention, but he did not ask her to choose among meanings she could not support. He recorded the phrase exactly as she had used it and left its significance unresolved.

After the interview, Nyarko asked Badu to separate the new lead from the case against Ofori. The reception book might

establish that an envelope passed through the office; even if it did, it would not establish who altered the child’s record or who later removed the attachment. Badu added a task to the evidence matrix: locate the volume, photograph the relevant pages in sequence, and compare the entries with dispatch records held by the other office. For once, the next step was concrete. It was also narrow enough to be trusted.

CHAPTER TWELVE

The Price of Silence

At the guesthouse, Mensah's hands shook as he unfolded the statement. He described a woman from Haven House who had objected to the transfer because the child's papers did not match the name the officials gave her. She was told to sign the form anyway. When she refused, the document was taken away and returned with a different signature.

Mensah had been ordered to record the matter as a routine transfer. He had written a fuller account privately, believing it would protect him if the case were reopened. Instead, he had hidden it and let the official report stand. He admitted that this choice had helped the cover-up survive.

Badu asked whether the witness was still alive. Mensah said he did not know. He believed the witness had been moved under another name, but the only person who might confirm it was Ofori.

Before he could say more, a car door slammed outside. Mensah went pale. Badu moved toward the window, and when he turned back, Mensah was gone. The envelope lay open on the table, its central page missing.

Mensah chose a different place for their second meeting: a modest office above a pharmacy, with a fan that clicked each time it completed a turn. He had brought no tea and no papers. He seemed to have spent the night deciding how much of his memory he could trust.

“The staff member who disappeared was not a stranger to the children,” he said. “She was the person they went to when they were afraid. She saw the transfer being prepared and understood that the names on the forms did not match the children in front of her.”

“Why didn’t she make a statement?”

“She tried. The statement was taken, then she was told it would be safer to leave the matter alone. After that, she vanished from the file. I cannot prove what happened to her.”

Badu asked for the staff member’s full name. Mensah gave it, then insisted that the information be recorded as a lead, not a confirmed fact about her fate. He was determined not to repeat the errors that had weakened the original inquiry.

For years, he had told himself that silence had protected his family. He now admitted that it had protected the people who had controlled the records. The distinction was painful, and he did not ask Badu to forgive him.

Mabel joined them for the final part of the meeting. She asked whether the staff member might have kept a personal copy of the statement. Mensah said it was possible; she had been methodical, the kind of person who kept receipts and wrote dates on envelopes.

“Then we look for the people who knew her,” Mabel said. “Not just the offices that erased her.”

Mensah nodded. It was the first time he seemed to believe the search might reach beyond the paper trail. Before they left, he gave Badu a list of former staff members. Some had moved. One was believed to have returned to her hometown. None was guaranteed to speak.

The missing witness had become more than an empty line in a file. She had been a person with habits, colleagues and a life beyond the day she disappeared.

Badu did not excuse him. He also did not waste time condemning him. They had a lead now, and this time it would be followed with proper support.

“I thought I was protecting the search,” he said. “I was protecting myself from being frightened again.”

Mensah read the new information and admitted that he had once visited the same town while trying to find her. He had turned back after a stranger asked why a retired policeman was asking about an old children’s home. He had called the incident a warning and used it as a reason to stop.

The address led to a small town outside Accra. A local officer confirmed that someone by the same name had once lived there, then moved away. The trail was not enough to locate the witness, but it narrowed the search.

The neighbour had kept a Christmas card from the woman, with a later address written on the back. She had not contacted her in years and did not know whether the address remained valid. Mabel photographed the card and asked permission to share it with Badu. The neighbour agreed, but requested that her name not be published unless necessary.

The phrase stayed with Mabel. It described the whole case more clearly than any of the official reports.

“She did not like people saying children were confused,” the neighbour said. “She used to say adults were confused, too, but adults had the power to make their confusion official.”

The former staff member’s neighbour agreed to speak at a community centre, where several people were present and no one had to enter a private house. She remembered the woman as patient with the children and exacting about records. If a form was incomplete, she would return it. If a child gave a different date, she would write both versions and ask someone to verify them.

At the community centre, the former staff member’s neighbour gave Badu the name of a retired nurse who had worked occasional shifts at Haven House. She would not call the nurse a witness. She had only heard that the woman kept a small notebook because the official logbooks were often taken away for review.

Badu asked the local officer to make contact through ordinary channels. He did not want a uniformed team appearing at the nurse’s door and turning a request for information into a warning. The officer returned two days later with a telephone number and permission to call. The nurse agreed to meet them at a district office, provided that her statement was recorded accurately and that she could read it before signing.

She remembered the transfer day as crowded and confused. A child had been brought into the office with one set of papers, while an official carried a second envelope bearing a different name. She could not identify the child now, and she would not pretend otherwise. What she remembered was the argument: a staff member insisting that the discrepancy be written down, and a man replying that the review panel had already settled the matter.

“Did you see the register altered?” Badu asked.

“No. I saw the register after it had been returned. One line was darker than the others, and the page had been handled so

often that the edge was soft. That is not proof of a crime. It is what I noticed.”

The nurse had made a note of the date in her personal diary because she had been asked to remain late. She had kept the diary through two moves, but it was in storage with other papers. She would look for it and contact the officer if she found it. Badu gave her his case reference and explained how to submit it without handing an original to an unknown messenger.

Outside, Mabel asked whether the nurse’s account changed their theory. Badu said it changed the order of their questions, not the answer. The second envelope could have been a correction, a duplicate, or an attempt to replace the original record. Until they found the diary or a matching official entry, all three possibilities remained open.

Mensah listened to the summary without interrupting. When Badu finished, the retired inspector admitted that he had once been asked to sign a page confirming that the register had been checked. He had signed the cover sheet, not the register itself. At the time, he had assumed the distinction was administrative. Now he understood how a signature on the wrong document could be used to make an incomplete process appear complete.

The nurse’s account required careful handling. She remembered a woman objecting to the transfer, but could not identify her from a photograph shown years later. She recalled that the woman had said the child’s name should not be changed without a court order. The nurse had not written down the words at the time; they survived only in her memory. Badu asked her to describe the room, the people present and the sequence of events before asking about names. The details remained broadly consistent, though she was uncertain about the exact hour.

A second interview focused on what could be checked. The clinic’s surviving appointment book showed that the nurse had

been on duty that morning, but it did not record the conversation. A staff roster placed two other employees nearby; one had died, and the other could not be located. The evidence supported the nurse's opportunity to witness the event, not every detail of her recollection. The prosecutor advised that her account could guide the inquiry but should not be presented as a standalone proof of the alteration.

Mensah listened as the limitations were explained. He had wanted the nurse's statement to settle the question of who objected to the transfer. Instead, it added another layer: a witness remembered an objection, and the institution's own records confirmed she had been there, but the person she described remained unidentified. Mensah said he would have treated the statement as sufficient years earlier. Badu asked whether that would have been enough to correct the register. Mensah lowered his eyes. 'No, ' he said. 'It should have made us ask the next question.'

"Put that in your statement," Badu said.

Mensah looked offended for a moment, then nodded. He would not be allowed to turn remorse into a substitute for evidence. The new statement would make his own part in the chain visible, including what he had failed to ask. At last, investigators were examining the silence around the transfer not as one great conspiracy but as a series of small decisions, each made easier by the person before it.

Mensah's fuller statement forced him to describe the moment he chose not to challenge the transfer. He had been told the decision came from senior officials and that the child would be safer if the paperwork remained quiet. He had not seen evidence that the child faced an immediate threat; he had accepted the warning because it came from people with power over his career.

The admission did not make him the architect of the scheme, but it showed how the scheme had survived. He signed each page only after the prosecutor read it back to him and corrected a date he had initially placed a year too late.

The prosecutor asked whether he could identify the woman who had objected to the transfer. Mensah said he might recognise her in a photograph but could not promise it. A photo array would need to be prepared fairly, with comparable images and no suggestion about which person investigators suspected. The prosecutor also warned that a memory from twenty-two years earlier could be sincere and still be mistaken. Mensah accepted the warning. For once, he did not ask the team to trust him because he had carried the secret for so long. He asked them to test what he said.

The retired nurse brought a notebook she had kept from her years at Haven House. It was not an official medical record and she was careful to say so. The entries were brief reminders: a child refusing food, a fever, a visit from a district officer. One date coincided with the transfer shown in the disputed register. Beside it she had written that a child was ‘distressed after questions’. She could not remember the exact questions or who had asked them. The note was valuable because it had been made close to the event, but its meaning remained uncertain.

The nurse said she had once been asked to sign a form confirming that a child had been present at a particular time. She remembered refusing because she had been working in another room and could not verify it. She did not know whether the form had later been signed by someone else. The investigator asked her to avoid discussing the interview with former colleagues until the relevant records had been secured. The instruction was not meant to silence her; it was intended to reduce the risk that memories would be reshaped by shared conversation.

Mensah reviewed the notebook and corrected one date from memory, then immediately qualified the correction: he might be

confusing it with a later visit. The team retained both versions in the record. The disagreement did not make either witness dishonest. It showed why the timeline had to be built from dated documents and independent sources wherever possible. Badu began to see that the old system had not hidden the truth in one dramatic act. It had buried it beneath dozens of small decisions, omissions and assumptions.

The Cost of a Signature

Mensah returned with a copy of the receipt he had signed for the sealed packet. He had kept it because he was uncertain why the packet had been delivered after the transfer was complete. The receipt bore his signature, a time, and a reference number that differed by one digit from the number in the official inventory. Mensah said he had noticed the discrepancy at the time but had been told it was a clerical correction. He had accepted that explanation because he trusted the officer who gave it.

The document examiner found that the final digit on the copy had been written over an earlier number. The examiner could not determine the original digit with certainty, but the paper impression on the sheet beneath it matched the reference in the dispatch book. This suggested that the receipt had been altered after it was signed. The examiner did not conclude who had done so. Badu asked whether the copy had remained in Mensah’s possession continuously. Mensah admitted that he had lent the file to a former colleague for a pension inquiry and could not account for two days when it was out of his hands.

That admission weakened the receipt as a standalone exhibit but did not erase its value as a lead. The team sought the corresponding office copy and documented the limits of both versions. Mensah looked tired when he signed the supplemental statement. ‘I thought a signature was just proof that a packet had passed through my

hands, ’ he said. ‘I did not understand that it would become proof that I had stopped asking questions.’ Badu recorded the words but did not put them in the evidence summary as a confession.

Outside, she told Mabel that she had stayed silent because she feared losing her pension and being blamed for a decision made by people above her. Mabel did not promise that the public would forgive her. She said the article would explain both the pressure and the choices the staff had made. The nurse accepted that answer more readily than reassurance. She wanted the record to show that she had been frightened, but not to pretend that fear had made every decision inevitable.

A surviving duty roster placed her at the home that day, though the roster could not establish which room she had entered. The team requested the original rather than relying on a photocopy supplied by a former employee. The nurse’s statement was amended to include the corroborating roster and the limits of that corroboration. She signed each page and initialled the correction, a small procedure that protected her from claims that the account had been altered after the interview.

The retired nurse reviewed her first statement before answering further questions. She corrected the colour of the folder and the approximate time she had seen the child, but she stood by her recollection that two adults argued over the name written on the transfer form. She could not identify either adult with confidence. The interviewer asked whether she had discussed the event with other former staff since the investigation began. She named two people and described what each had told her, allowing the team to separate shared memory from later conversation.

The nurse’s second statement

A Statement with Margins

The prosecutor returned Mensah’s draft statement with questions written in the margins. Each question asked him to separate what he had seen from what another person had told him. Mensah disliked the process. He said it made his account sound weaker, as though caution were a form of dishonesty. The prosecutor replied that a precise statement was more useful than a confident one that collapsed under cross-examination.

Mensah revised the account. He had personally seen Ofori carrying a folder; he had heard a clerk say the register would be corrected; he had not watched anyone alter the page. He remembered signing a receipt for a sealed packet, but the surviving copy did not show what the packet contained. He had suspected the report was incomplete and had chosen not to challenge it in writing.

The last admission troubled him most. ‘I thought I was protecting the children from another public inquiry, ’ he said. ‘I also wanted to protect myself from the senior officers who told me to leave it alone. Both things can be true.’

The prosecutor did not offer comfort. She explained that motive and responsibility would be assessed separately, and that his willingness to correct the record would be documented without guaranteeing a particular outcome.

Badu asked whether Mensah could identify the handwriting on the receipt. Mensah said he could recognise the clerk’s style but would not claim certainty from a photocopy. The original had to be located. He offered to review it alongside other documents if an examiner supervised the comparison.

Before leaving, Mensah asked whether Daniel would ever learn that adults had discussed his identity as an administrative problem. Badu said Daniel already knew enough to understand that decisions had been made about him without his consent. What remained was to establish who had made those decisions and what could lawfully be corrected.

Mensah signed the revised statement and initialled each page. The process did not erase his earlier silence, but it converted a general confession of guilt into a more useful account of specific acts, omissions and uncertainties.

The Statement That Changed

The first version of Mensah's statement said that he had seen a sealed packet carried out of Haven House. The second said that he had seen a folder, and the third described the object only as papers. The prosecutor laid the versions side by side and asked him to explain the difference. Mensah said he had become more careful as he remembered how little he had actually seen. He could recall the person carrying something against his chest; he could not swear that the item was sealed.

Badu was frustrated by the retreat, but the prosecutor stopped him from treating it as proof of dishonesty. A witness who corrected an overconfident statement might be trying to tell the truth more accurately. The relevant question was whether the underlying observation could be tested. Mensah identified a second staff member who had been in the corridor, though he warned that she might deny remembering anything.

The staff member, now living in another region, agreed to a recorded interview after receiving independent advice. She remembered an argument about a missing page and a request to keep children away from the office. She did not remember seeing the packet leave. Her account supported the existence of a dispute but did not identify who removed the record.

The prosecutor added both statements to the evidence schedule, including the differences between them. Nothing was to be quietly discarded because it complicated the theory. If the case went to court, the defence would be entitled to examine those differences. The investigation had to survive not only the questions that supported it but the questions that weakened it.

Mensah later told Badu that he had once believed a truthful statement was simply one that contained no deliberate lie. Now he understood that a person could mislead by sounding certain about a memory that was incomplete. Badu said the most useful thing Mensah could offer was not a perfect recollection, but a clear account of where his recollection ended.

The Staff Member’s Account

The former staff member’s statement was taken in two sessions because she became distressed when asked to describe the child’s reaction to the changed name. In the first session she gave a broad chronology; in the second she reviewed it with her lawyer and corrected two dates. She explained that she had remembered the dates by linking them to a staff meeting and a power outage, not by reading a diary entry. The investigators recorded that basis so later comparisons would not give the memory more precision than it deserved.

She remembered a senior official saying that the child’s papers would be corrected after the review. She could not identify the speaker from a voice recording and did not claim to have seen the register being altered. What she could confirm was that she had been instructed to copy a new name onto a temporary list, and that the instruction came from someone who had authority over her work. The original list had not been attached to her statement because she no longer possessed it.

Badu asked whether she would identify the official in a formal procedure if presented with a fair set of options. She said she would consider it after receiving legal advice, but she would

not choose a face from a single photograph. Mabel respected the boundary. The statement strengthened the evidence that a deliberate administrative change had occurred, while leaving the identity of the person who ordered it unresolved.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

A Name Kept Hidden

Adwoa found a letter from Agyeman stating that the arrangement was temporary and that the child's identity would be restored after the review. The promised correction had never happened. Adwoa had not changed the register herself, but her silence had helped preserve the lie.

Before he left, Adwoa gave him the small key she had kept since Haven House. She had finally checked the cupboard it belonged to after Badu's first visit. It was empty except for a torn envelope and a receipt for a file transfer, dated two days after the incident. The receipt carried a reference number that matched the restricted annex.

Daniel took it to Mabel. Now the story had produced an object that neither memory nor an official summary could explain away. Mabel photographed it, recorded where it came from and sent a copy to Badu. The receipt would not identify the person who ordered the change, but it established that the file had moved after the transfer was supposedly complete.

When Daniel returned the following afternoon, he brought the envelope with him but did not sit down. He asked Adwoa to tell him the names of everyone who had come to the house on the day he was placed in her care. She gave him two names she remembered clearly and one she was uncertain about. None matched the name he had been using to search online. Daniel wrote them down anyway, then asked why she had never kept a copy of the transfer order.

"I was told the original had to go back," Adwoa said. "I thought keeping a copy would put you in danger."

"Or put you in danger?"

She did not answer. Daniel realised that the silence had never belonged to one person alone. Adwoa had been frightened, but she had also chosen the version of events

that allowed daily life to continue. He could understand the fear without accepting the choice.

Adwoa did not begin with the truth. She began by making tea, asking whether Badu had eaten and telling him that Daniel had always been stubborn about his schoolwork. The ordinary details came out in a rush, as though she could build a wall from them. Badu let her speak until the kettle had cooled and the room had grown quiet.

"I did not give birth to him," she finally said.

The words seemed to leave her smaller. She explained that Daniel had been brought to her after the events at Haven House, a frightened child whose official papers were incomplete. She had been told that a relative could not be found and that taking him home would be temporary. Temporary became a year, then a school admission, then a life.

"Why did you keep the name Sarpong?"

"It was the name on the paper they gave me. I was told changing it again would cause trouble. I thought I was keeping him safe."

"Did you know his birth name was Emmanuel?"

Adwoa looked down at her hands. "I heard that name. I was never given a document I could trust. They told me the matter had been settled."

She admitted that she had suspected the record was false. She also admitted that she had been afraid of losing the child she had come to love. Those two truths had lived together for years. She had made food, paid school fees when she could, attended meetings and cared for him through fevers. None of that made the altered record right, but neither did the record erase the care she had given.

Badu asked whether she would make a formal statement. Adwoa said she would, but only after Daniel had been told everything. She would not allow another official to decide the order in which he learned his own life.

When Badu left, she stood at the doorway and called after him. “Please don’t write as if I stole him. I did not take him to hurt him. I took him because every adult in that place was saying someone else would take responsibility.”

Badu wrote down her words exactly. The case needed truth, not a villain shaped to make the truth easier to swallow.

The new lead made the story more personal and more complicated. Mabel could not assume that the truth would arrive as a single revelation. It might come through several people remembering different pieces, each with their own reasons for having forgotten.

Later, Mabel asked her mother for permission to record another conversation. Her mother agreed, but said she could not promise to remember everything. She recalled that a family friend had helped arrange Mabel’s care during a difficult period. The friend’s name appeared nowhere in the records Mabel had found so far.

The advice was simple, and she wrote it in her notebook. They agreed to seek an independent specialist to compare the photograph with Mabel’s childhood images, while recognising that visual similarity could not prove identity on its own.

“Then keep them separate until they do.”

“I don’t know what I remember,” she said. “I know what the photograph shows. I know what my mother said. I don’t know how the pieces fit.”

Mabel looked at the table between them. It was the first time someone had spoken about her possible connection to Haven House without treating it as a scoop.

"You were one of the children," Daniel said. "You have a right to know. But you also have a right to decide what you do with it."

Daniel asked Mabel to meet him at the university library. He wanted to know how she had found the photograph and whether the newsroom intended to publish the names of the children. Mabel told him that she would not publish a name merely because it appeared in a file, and that any decision involving his identity would require a conversation with him and independent legal advice.

Daniel asked for a copy of Adwoa's letter, but he did not take it from her hands. He asked Badu to arrange a scan and record where the original had been found. It mattered to him that the first document connected to his identity should not disappear into another office without a trace. Badu agreed, and a legal officer witnessed the copying process.

The letter referred to an arrangement being temporary, but it did not name Daniel clearly enough to settle his identity. The paper bore Agyeman's signature, though the signature alone could not establish when the letter had been written or whether every sentence had been added at the same time. A document examiner would compare the ink and paper with other surviving correspondence. Until then, it was a lead with a strong connection to the judge, not a final answer.

Daniel read the letter twice. The first time he searched for a name. The second time he searched for a promise. The wording suggested that someone had expected the record to be corrected

after the review, but offered no explanation for why the correction never happened.

“Did you believe they would come back for me?” he asked Adwoa.

“At first, yes,” she said. “Then I told myself that no news meant the matter was finished. That was easier than admitting I had no control over what they had written.”

Daniel wanted to be angry with her, but anger did not make the past simpler. She had cared for him and withheld something essential from him. Both facts remained true. He told her that he would not decide what their relationship meant in a single afternoon. He needed her to answer questions formally, and he needed her not to soften her answers to protect him.

Adwoa agreed to a recorded interview at the station. Before it began, Badu explained that she could request a break, correct an answer, or say when she did not remember. She was not being treated as guilty merely because her name appeared in the history of the placement. At the same time, no promise of protection could be made in exchange for a particular version of events.

Her statement clarified one point and complicated another. She had received the child from two officials, not one. She could describe the older man, but the younger man had kept his face partly turned away. She remembered a ring with a square dark stone and a folder marked with a blue stripe. Neither detail was unique enough to identify a person, but both could be compared with other accounts.

Mabel entered the details into the evidence log and marked them as recollection, not identification. A photograph of the old officials’ meeting showed one man wearing a ring, but the image was too distant to establish whether it was the same one. She

resisted the temptation to connect the two simply because the match would be satisfying.

Later, Daniel and Mabel reviewed the photograph from Haven House with an independent specialist. The specialist explained that age, lighting, print damage and camera angle limited any comparison. The image could support a line of inquiry, but it could not prove that Mabel was one of the children. Her mother's memories were also inconsistent about dates, and Mabel insisted that those uncertainties remain in the record.

"I don't want a story built around me before I know whether it is true," Mabel said.

Daniel understood. His own life had been shaped by a name copied from one form to another until people stopped asking where it came from. He told her that the investigation should not repeat that process by turning a possibility into a fact. They agreed that any public report would distinguish confirmed records, witness recollections and unanswered questions.

Daniel and Mabel visited the public registry together, but Daniel spoke for himself when the clerk asked why he wanted the records. He explained that he was trying to reconcile conflicting entries and wanted the process documented. The clerk did not speculate about the old transfer. She outlined the steps required to request a certified extract and advised that any formal correction would need supporting evidence and review by the appropriate authority. Daniel thanked her. The ordinary nature of the process was unexpectedly reassuring: he could seek an answer without asking someone to make a private exception for him.

Mabel later reviewed the wording of the old letter attributed to Agyeman. Its paper and typeface were consistent with the period, but the letter had come from a family collection rather

than an official archive. The document examiner could assess physical features, not establish the author's intent. Badu requested handwriting exemplars from authenticated judicial correspondence. Until the comparison was complete, the team described it as a letter attributed to Agyeman. Daniel agreed that the distinction should remain in any public account.

That evening, Mabel drafted a private chronology for the prosecutor. She listed the letter, the transfer receipt, the clinic card and the altered register as separate items, each with a note explaining what it could and could not establish. The timeline showed that several people had promised the identity would be corrected, yet no valid correction order had been found. The absence was significant, but it still left open whether the failure came from a deliberate decision, a chain of negligence or both. Mabel saved the draft without turning it into a headline.

That evening, Badu received a formal reply from the archive. The reference number on the receipt matched a transfer entry, but the entry described a sealed packet, not a register. The destination field had been completed in a different hand. The packet's receiving signature was illegible, and the archive could not confirm whether the packet had ever been opened.

Badu placed the reply beside Adwoa's letter. One document suggested a promise to correct an identity; the other showed that a packet had moved through the system shortly afterward. Together they made a stronger lead. They still did not establish who changed the name, who carried out the transfer, or why the promised correction never took place. Those questions remained the centre of the case.

The archive supervisor arranged a controlled search of the sealed-packet register. Two staff members checked the shelves while a third recorded every box opened. The packet number led to a bundle of administrative correspondence, but the envelope itself was missing. A carbon copy of a dispatch note survived,

showing that the packet had been sent to a review office and signed for by someone whose initials could be read as either Y. O. or Y. Q. The ambiguity was frustrating, but the copy gave the investigators a date and a destination they could check against staff rosters.

Daniel asked to sit in on the explanation. He listened without interrupting, then asked the question none of the officials had yet answered: if the record had been changed to protect him, why had no one restored it once the danger passed? The archive supervisor had no answer. Badu told Daniel that the investigation could establish who moved the packet and who approved the alteration, but it could not promise that every motive would be recoverable. Daniel said he wanted the truth even if it proved that people had acted out of cowardice rather than malice. He was no longer looking for a single villain who could explain every lost year.

The letter attributed to Agyeman was examined for paper, ink and handwriting. The examiner found features consistent with other correspondence from the judge’s office, but consistency did not prove that Agyeman had written every line. The letter’s envelope had no reliable postmark, and the paper could have been removed from a larger file. Mabel resisted the temptation to describe it as a deathbed confession. Its importance lay in the questions it raised about Daniel’s placement and the sealed packet, not in any claim that it settled the identity issue.

Daniel read the letter in the presence of his solicitor. He paused over a sentence that referred to ‘the child whose name was chosen for him’. He had expected a clear answer and found instead a phrase that could mean several things: a name selected for protection, an identity assigned by an institution, or an adult’s attempt to explain a decision made under pressure. He asked for a copy and was told that access would be documented. He accepted the procedure, though the restraint cost him effort.

Adwoa later admitted that she had once been given an opportunity to correct the name on a form and had declined. She believed changing it again would draw attention to Daniel. She could not remember who advised her, and she did not claim that the decision had been right. Daniel was hurt, but he understood that fear had narrowed the choices available to her. Their conversation did not repair the past. It created a more honest basis for deciding what should happen next.

The Letter’s Missing Context

Daniel and Adwoa reviewed the letter attributed to Judge Agyeman with a neutral document examiner present. The paper and ink were consistent with the period, but the examiner could not verify the judge’s authorship from a short sample. A phrase in the letter referred to ‘the review being complete’, yet no date or case number appeared on the page. The letter might have been written to reassure Adwoa, to instruct an official, or to record a decision already made. Without the envelope or a reliable recipient record, its purpose remained uncertain.

Adwoa admitted that she had kept the letter hidden because she believed it would be interpreted as proof that she had knowingly participated in the change. Daniel asked why she had not shown it to him when he first questioned his documents. She answered that she had feared losing him, though she understood that the secrecy had already damaged their trust. Daniel did not forgive her immediately. He said he could accept a frightened decision more easily than another claim that he had been protected from the truth.

Mabel suggested that the letter be treated as a lead to the judge’s correspondence register rather than as the final answer. The registry could show whether a letter had been sent on the date written in the margin. If it could not, that absence would need to be interpreted cautiously: not every personal letter passed through an official office. The search therefore became a

question of corroboration, not a contest over which family member was telling the better story.

Daniel asked to read the letter again after the examination. He was less interested in whether the handwriting belonged to the judge than in the sentence promising that the arrangement would be temporary. Badu explained that even an authentic letter could contain a promise that was never authorised or never intended to be fulfilled. Daniel said he understood, but he wanted the investigation to establish who had made the promise and who had allowed it to expire without action.

The registry's dispatch book showed no entry for the letter on the date written in its margin. An archivist cautioned that personal correspondence was not always logged. A second search found a reference to a meeting that might have concerned the same subject, but the minutes were incomplete. Each source supported a different part of the timeline; none proved that Agyeman had promised to restore Daniel's identity.

The letter attributed to Agyeman was sent for handwriting comparison alongside three uncontested examples from his judicial correspondence. The examiner explained that a close resemblance could support attribution but would not establish when the letter was written, whether every page belonged together or whether its contents were true. The paper stock was commercially available during the period, and the envelope had not survived. Badu recorded the findings as provisional until the report was complete.

The letter's route

Before leaving, Mabel stood by the former interview-room doorway. The building felt smaller than it had in her memory, yet the uncertainty felt larger. She had spent years thinking she had failed to tell the story correctly. Now she understood that memory was not a recording and that the adults around her had possessed information she could never have seen. Her task was

not to force her younger self to know more. It was to preserve the limits of what that child could honestly have witnessed.

Badu asked whether the old room had a separate exit. The maintenance plan showed none. A later renovation document showed a service door added years afterward. That ruled out one rumour about a hidden passage, but it did not establish how the file had left the building in 2004. The investigators would need to reconstruct staff movements, visitor entries and the route between the office and the main gate.

The floor plan helped explain why the witness accounts differed. From the end of the corridor, a child could see the office door but not the desk inside. From the storage-room entrance, someone could see a person carrying a file but might not see which folder it was. The phrase “I saw the file removed” could therefore describe different levels of observation. Mabel recognised that her childhood statement might have captured the movement of a folder without identifying its contents.

An elderly caretaker, Mr Koomson, remembered the old corridor but warned that his memory of dates was poor. He said the children had sometimes waited outside the office when officials came to review their files. He remembered a day when a woman argued that one of the children’s names had been written incorrectly. He could not say whether the woman was Adwoa, whether the argument concerned Daniel, or whether it happened on 14 August. His account was recorded as a possible lead, not as confirmation of the disputed day.

Mabel visited the building with permission from its current managers and an independent witness. She did not walk through the rooms imagining herself as the child she had been. Instead, she measured the corridor, photographed the door frames and noted the changes made during renovation. The current Room Four was used for supplies and had a different door. The former

interview room had been divided by a partition, meaning that a person standing in one position in 2004 might have seen a doorway that no longer existed.

The first reliable floor plan of Haven House came from a maintenance file rather than the child-care records. The drawing had been made when the building’s wiring was replaced. It showed a narrow corridor, a storage room, a staff office and a small interview room marked with a number that had later been painted over. The measurements did not match every recollection, but the plan gave the investigators something fixed against which to test them.

The Room Four Plan

Daniel Sets the Terms

Daniel met Mabel and Badu together to set boundaries for any future reporting. He did not want his childhood photographs used without permission, and he did not want the name Emmanuel Sarpong presented as if it erased the person he had become. Mabel explained the public interest in the altered records but agreed that private medical details and unrelated family matters would stay out of the article. Badu documented Daniel’s preferences so they would not be lost as the team changed shifts.

Daniel then asked the question he had avoided: if the official record had been altered to protect him, could the people who changed it still have harmed him? Badu said protection and harm were not opposites. An action might have prevented immediate danger while depriving a person of identity, history and choice. The legal investigation would examine the decisions, but it could not tell Daniel how he ought to feel about them.

He asked for an independent legal adviser to explain how he could request corrections to civil records if the evidence

supported his birth name. Nyarko agreed to refer him to the appropriate service without promising an outcome. The step gave Daniel something practical to do while the murder investigation continued. He left with copies of his own records, a list of unanswered questions and the assurance that no correction would be made merely because a theory seemed persuasive.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

The Man Behind the File

Asare summoned Badu and warned him not to let personal connections cloud his judgment. Badu replied that the documents —not his father's name—were driving the investigation. Asare acknowledged that decisions had been made to prevent a difficult situation from becoming a public crisis, but he would not say who changed the register.

Meanwhile, Mabel found an old photograph of Agyeman, Asare and Yaw Ofori leaving a meeting about the judicial appointment review. Ofori had accessed a restricted annex three weeks before Agyeman's death. Badu decided to question him.

Before Badu could leave, Daniel reported that someone had visited his apartment and left a warning: the dead judge was not the only person who knew his real name. Daniel feared that the police could not protect him from people inside the system.

Badu reassured him that the investigation would follow the evidence. He then visited Ofori, who admitted being present at Haven House in 2004 and speaking with Agyeman shortly before the judge died. Ofori said the original investigation had never been properly concluded because the witness disappeared. He promised to help locate the annex, but refused to explain his full role.

Mabel’s photograph of the three officials was examined by a picture editor and a forensic analyst. The date could be established from the event banner in the background. Ofori’s presence was no longer a rumour; he had attended the meeting. It still did not prove that he had altered the register, but it contradicted his earlier claim that he had been only a peripheral observer. Daniel’s warning about the visitor at his apartment gave the team a new security concern. Officers checked the building’s access records and requested available camera footage. The visitor had avoided the main entrance, but a neighbour recalled a man waiting near the stairwell. Badu suspected Ofori had more to hide than the missing statement, and he arranged a formal interview with a second officer present.

Asare did not offer Badu a chair. He stood beside the window and spoke in the measured tone of an official accustomed to being obeyed. He admitted that he had helped keep the appointment review from becoming a public scandal. He said the decision had been presented as temporary and that he had believed the child would eventually receive a corrected identity. “Who made the original change?” Badu asked. “I cannot tell you that.” “Or you will not?” Asare looked at him. “There is a difference, Detective, but I understand why you no longer trust the distinction.” He denied ordering the murder and said he had not visited Agyeman’s house. Badu asked for the file he had withheld. Asare agreed to provide it through the proper

channel, but the delay had already cost the investigation time. Badu left with no confession, only a clearer picture of how powerful people could participate in wrongdoing without ever describing themselves as its authors.

Asare's warning came after dark, delivered in person rather than by phone. He arrived at the station without an appointment and asked Badu to walk with him to a quiet corridor outside the records unit. The deputy commissioner looked tired, but his voice was steady.

"You have made requests that touch people above your rank," he said. "There are procedures for this."

"Then the procedures should protect the records."

"They protect the institution."

Badu heard the difference. He asked Asare whether he had attended the meeting at Haven House in August 2004. The deputy commissioner did not answer directly. He said he had been involved in many reviews and could not recall every detail from two decades earlier.

"That is not a denial," Badu said.

"It is the answer I can give you."

After Asare left, an envelope was found beneath Badu's office door. Inside was a copy of the old photograph, this time with three adults circled in red: Agyeman, Asare and Ofori. No note accompanied it. The image could have been a threat, a clue or a deliberate attempt to make them accuse the wrong person.

Badu logged the envelope and arranged for it to be examined. He refused to let the circles become proof. The photograph showed that the men had been present together; it did not establish what each had done.

Mabel, when told about the envelope, pointed out that the sender could have copied an image already in circulation. “We need to know who wants us to look at these three,” she said, “and who benefits if we stop looking anywhere else.”

Badu pinned the photograph beside the timeline but wrote a warning beneath it: *Presence is not guilt.* The words were a reminder to the team—and to himself. If they were going to expose a false record, they could not build the case with assumptions of their own.

The clue now looked less like a revelation and more like an attempt to shape the investigation. Badu added that possibility to the working theory. Someone wanted the team to see the three men together. The next task was to find out why.

Mabel, meanwhile, discovered that the photograph of the three officials had been reproduced in a newsletter distributed at a public event years earlier. The circles had been added recently, but the underlying image was not secret. Whoever sent the envelope had chosen a familiar photograph and altered it to direct attention.

After the meeting, the legal officer quietly advised Badu to preserve all communications with Asare. It was not an accusation; it was a safeguard. Badu sent a written summary of the meeting to the case file and copied the prosecutor.

The deputy commissioner’s expression hardened. He warned that the case could cause lasting damage if the press published incomplete information. Badu replied that the best protection against incomplete reporting was a complete, verifiable record.

“Then we will request it.”

“I don’t have it with me,” Asare said.

Asare requested a formal briefing. He brought legal counsel and insisted that the meeting be minuted. Badu welcomed the procedure and presented the evidence chart. When he reached the altered roster, Asare said the entry could reflect a temporary reassignment. Badu asked for the order authorising that reassignment.

The anonymous envelope was examined for prints and fibres, but the results were inconclusive. The paper was common, the handwriting had been copied or carefully disguised, and the photograph could have come from several archives. Badu recorded the limitations rather than allowing the lack of a match to become evidence of sophistication.

The Review Meeting

The prosecutor asked for a working meeting at the regional office, away from the police station and the press. No one called it a confrontation. The invitation described it as a review of the appointment file, and every person who attended was told that the purpose was to identify what the surviving documents could establish—not to decide guilt by agreement.

Badu arrived with two sealed folders. One contained copies of the original Haven House records and the chain-of-custody forms. The other contained the newer material: the photograph, the archive response, the visitor entries and a list of questions still unanswered. He had separated them deliberately. If the old papers were contaminated by later assumptions, the team needed to know where the contamination began.

The prosecutor, Ama Nyarko, read the timeline without interruption. When she finished, she tapped the entry for the sealed packet. ‘You have a movement record, not proof of what was inside the packet when it arrived, ’ she said. ‘And an illegible signature is not an

identity. We can say a packet travelled. We cannot yet say who opened it or who changed the name.’

‘That is why I want the archive custodian interviewed, ’ Badu said. ‘The first response was prepared from an index. I want the ledger itself, the storage register and any record of later access.’

Nyarko agreed, but she added a condition: every original would be photographed in place before it was handled. The archive’s staff would be present, and the examination would be recorded. If the case eventually went to court, no defence lawyer should be able to argue that the police had altered a record while trying to prove that someone else had altered it years earlier.

Mabel attended only the first part of the meeting, with the prosecutor’s permission, to identify the photograph and explain how it had come into her possession. She described the newsletter in which the image had appeared and the later envelope with red circles. She did not claim the circles had been made by Ofori or Asare. The image’s value, she said, was that it placed the three officials at a particular meeting on a date that could be independently checked.

‘What do you think the sender wanted us to conclude?’ Nyarko asked her.

‘That the three men acted together, ’ Mabel replied. ‘Or that we would waste time arguing about which of them looks most guilty. Either way, the sender gets to choose the question.’

Nyarko wrote that down. It was not evidence of who had sent the envelope, but it was a useful warning about the way evidence could be framed. A photograph could be genuine and still be used to mislead. A record could be accurate about one fact and

silent about another. The investigation had to resist the temptation to treat a document as a complete story.

After Mabel left, Badu asked to speak to Asare again under formal conditions. The deputy commissioner arrived with counsel and a written statement. He acknowledged that he had participated in a meeting about the review and that the issue of the child's identity had been raised. He said he had believed the administrative correction would happen after the appointment decision, when the file could be amended without affecting the review.

'Who told you the correction would be made?' Nyarko asked.

Asare looked down at his statement. 'I cannot now separate what I was told from what I assumed.'

'That distinction is important,' she said. 'Please do not fill the gap with a guess.'

He said he had not personally written the altered entry. He could not, however, produce an order authorising a temporary reassignment or a memo directing the records office to correct the child's name. The absence of those papers did not prove he had ordered the change. It did make his explanation harder to verify.

Badu watched Asare's hands. The deputy commissioner kept them flat on the table, fingers spread, as though stillness could make the statement more certain. When asked about Ofori's access to the restricted annex, he said Ofori had been tasked with retrieving supporting material for the review. He could not say whether the annex had been complete when Ofori returned it.

'Did you report the missing witness?' Badu asked.

'I believed the witness had withdrawn.'

'Did you speak to the witness?'

‘No.’

‘Did anyone show you a withdrawal statement?’

Asare took too long to answer. ‘Not that I remember.’

Nyarko paused the interview and asked the clerk to mark the time. She told Asare that the record would preserve both the answer and the hesitation only insofar as the recording captured it; no one would write a psychological interpretation into the formal statement. The important point was simpler: Asare had accepted a conclusion without seeing the document that supposedly supported it.

Outside the room, Badu felt no satisfaction. The interview had not produced a confession or even a clean accusation. It had shown a pattern of decisions made on assurances that were never tested. The false identity had survived because each person treated the previous person’s claim as if it were an official fact.

That afternoon, the archive custodian called to say the physical ledger had been located in a box filed under a broader administrative category. The relevant page had not been removed, but a narrow strip of paper had been pasted over part of the destination column. The strip was old, discoloured at the edges and attached with an adhesive that would require careful examination.

Badu did not ask the custodian to lift it. He instructed her to secure the box and wait for the document examiner. A covered entry could conceal a name, a correction, or nothing more than an error. Until it was examined, the team would describe it only as an obscured destination field.

When he told Mabel, she said the case had begun to resemble a building with doors that opened into other doors. Every time they found a record, it led them to a person who remembered a

conversation, a person who had relied on a promise, or a person who insisted the matter belonged to someone else.

The legal review widened to include the people who had handled the appointment process after Asare's memorandum. One official remembered receiving a file but said the relevant annex was missing when it arrived. Another remembered a discussion about protecting a witness but could not recall who had proposed it. Their statements were not identical, yet the differences were not automatically evidence of collusion. The prosecutor ordered the accounts compared with duty rosters, meeting calendars and the surviving dispatch book. Where the paper trail ended, the report would say so.

Badu was asked to step out of one interview because of his father's name on the list. He waited in the corridor while another investigator continued questioning the witness. The decision stung; he had spent days trying to make the case more rigorous, and now he was excluded from a conversation that might matter. But when the investigator returned with the notes, Badu understood why the boundary mattered. The witness had referred to Emmanuel Badu without knowing that the detective was his son. The statement needed to be assessed without Badu's presence influencing either the questions or the record.

Later, the independent investigator told Badu that the witness had not identified his father as the person who changed the register. He had named him as someone who attended a meeting and objected to a proposed shortcut. The information could support a different view of the father's role, but it did not settle it. Badu felt relief and shame together: relief that the evidence did not accuse his father directly, shame that he had wanted it to. He wrote the finding in his own notes without adding an interpretation.

'That is how institutions hide things without one person having to control everything,' Badu said. 'Not

always through a master plan. Sometimes through a chain of people who decide that the next office must know more than they do.’

Mabel wrote the sentence in her notebook, then crossed it out. It sounded like a conclusion for an article, and she was not ready to publish it. For now, it remained a question: had the child been erased by a coordinated conspiracy, or by a series of convenient decisions that became impossible to reverse? The evidence might show that both explanations were partly true.

Ofori's first formal interview was conducted with counsel present. He denied changing the register and said his access to the annex had been routine. When shown the access log, he explained that officials often requested files on behalf of colleagues, and that the person listed in a ledger was not necessarily the person who read the contents. The explanation was possible, but it required corroboration. The prosecutor asked him to identify the colleague and the purpose of the request. Ofori said he could not remember. His lawyer advised him not to speculate, and the interview ended without an admission.

Outside, Badu did not call the interview a failure. Ofori had committed himself to a version that could be checked against office diaries, visitor records and the statements of clerks. If those records supported him, the team would have to account for that. If they contradicted him, the contradiction would be meaningful because it had been recorded before he knew what the other witnesses would say. Mabel, waiting across the road, asked whether he believed Ofori was lying. Badu replied that belief was not the standard. ‘We need a fact that survives his lawyer, our doubts and a judge who has never met any of us.’

The obscured archive entry was photographed under angled light, then examined with a non-destructive imaging method. A few letters became more legible, but the result was not a complete name. The entry referred to a sealed annex and

recorded a transfer to an office that had since been reorganised. Badu requested the office's old custody schedules. The search took days because the records had been boxed by year rather than subject, and several labels had faded. The delay frustrated the team, but it also meant that the next discovery would be traceable to a documented search rather than an unexplained coincidence.

Asare's explanation changed in one small but important respect. In his first statement, he had said he did not remember seeing the annex. In a later clarification, he said he might have reviewed a summary but not the original. The difference was not proof of deception; memory often became more precise when a person saw the documents again. Still, the team recorded the change and asked him to identify what had refreshed his recollection. The question was put through the legal officer, not in an unrecorded confrontation.

The records search located a custody sheet signed by a junior official who had since left public service. The signature was clear, but the sheet did not say whether the packet had been opened. Badu added the official to the witness list and asked for an interview. The trail now connected the missing annex to a sequence of identifiable offices and decisions. It was no longer simply a rumour about a powerful person hiding a file; it was a chain of custody that could be tested one link at a time.

The Photograph's Second Frame

A former court photographer supplied a contact sheet from a public event held near the time of the appointment review. Most frames showed officials entering the hall, but one image captured Ofori speaking with a records clerk beside a side entrance. The photograph established that they had met. It did not show what they discussed or whether any document changed hands. The clerk's name matched the initials on the overwritten ledger, making the image a useful connection between two independently sourced records.

The photographer explained that the frames had been numbered during processing, not necessarily in the order the event unfolded. The image could not establish a precise sequence without the original camera log. Badu requested the log and asked the team to locate other photographs from the same roll. One showed Asare leaving the hall with a folder, but the folder’s contents were invisible. The photographs placed several people in the same setting; they did not prove a conspiracy by themselves.

Mabel wrote a timeline on a newsroom board using different marks for confirmed dates, estimated dates and unresolved events. The visual separation exposed a weakness in their working theory: the meeting could have occurred before the packet was transferred, after it was transferred, or on a different day than one witness remembered. She sent Badu the corrected timeline and crossed out the confident headline she had drafted. The story would be stronger if it survived the facts that contradicted its first shape.

Badu asked the assistant whether anyone had instructed her to destroy minutes. She said she had received an order to clear duplicate working papers, but she could not recall whether the instruction covered this folder. Investigators sought the retention policy and the order itself. The distinction was crucial: routine disposal, careless recordkeeping and deliberate destruction could leave similar gaps while carrying very different meanings.

Asare disputed her interpretation of the initials. He said the code could refer to a routine file rather than the Haven House matter. The records officer agreed that the code was not unique, then identified two other documents from the same series. The team compared dates, paper formats and the filing practice in force at the time. The result narrowed the possibilities but did not remove the ambiguity.

A retired administrative assistant described meetings that were often arranged by telephone and recorded only in a senior

officer’s diary. She remembered being told to prepare a folder for a review but could not say which version of the register it contained. Her old notebooks showed a sequence of initials, one of which matched the code on the recovered transfer slip. The notebooks had remained in her possession after retirement, and investigators documented how she had stored them before taking copies.

The office that kept no minutes

The Photograph in the Minutes

Mabel obtained the minutes of a public meeting held shortly before the appointment review was postponed. The minutes listed the attendees but did not describe the discussion. A photograph attached to a later press release showed Agyeman, Asare and Ofori standing outside the building. The image established that they had attended the same event; it did not prove they had discussed Haven House or agreed to alter a record.

A retired photographer helped Mabel locate the original negative in a box of press images. The frame before the published photograph showed the men walking toward a vehicle. In the background, a junior clerk carried a document case. The image was too distant to identify the case or its contents, but it gave investigators a possible witness to search for.

Mabel checked the event programme and found the clerk’s name in the staff list. He had since moved into private accounting. When contacted, he remembered carrying materials for the meeting but did not remember what was inside the case. He was willing to review the photograph and provide a statement about his duties that day.

Badu cautioned Mabel that the photograph could not be used to imply guilt. She agreed and changed her draft headline. The men’s proximity was a reason to ask questions, not an answer to

them. Her editor wanted a stronger angle, but she insisted that the story should explain the gap between what the image showed and what readers might assume.

The clerk’s statement confirmed that some documents had been returned to the registry after the meeting. He could not say whether the Haven House packet was among them. His delivery log, however, listed a return receipt that was absent from the current archive file.

That receipt became the next objective. The photograph had not solved the conspiracy; it had identified a person whose routine work might help reconstruct the paper trail. Mabel saved the image with a caption describing only what could be seen and sent Badu the verified staff details.

The Photograph’s Negative

Mabel tracked down the photographer who had taken the Haven House group picture. He was retired and had stored his old negatives in labelled envelopes inside a metal cabinet. He did not recognise the children by name, but he remembered being asked to take two photographs: one for the home's records and one for a visiting committee. The second photograph had been requested after the first group had begun to disperse.

He showed Mabel the surviving negative sleeves and the order book. The date was clear, but the names had been added later in a different ink. One sleeve had a torn corner and a number written on the reverse. He could not explain the damage. Mabel photographed the order book with his permission and asked a specialist to assess whether the writing could be dated in relation to the original entry.

The photographer warned her that memory was unreliable after so many years. He might have remembered the second photograph because it was unusual, or because he had repeated the story to customers over the years. Mabel noted his caution. The negative could confirm that an image existed; it could not

prove what the adults had said in the room or why one child had been omitted from the official caption.

A comparison of the negative and the published print revealed that the edge of the image had been cropped. A chair and part of an adult's sleeve appeared in the negative but not in the print. The crop was consistent with ordinary photographic framing, yet it also meant that the published image could not establish who stood just outside the frame.

Mabel submitted the material to Badu with a written chain-of-custody note. She kept a duplicate for her editor and did not publish the names of the children. The photograph had become more informative and less conclusive at the same time. It showed what had been preserved, and just as importantly, what no surviving image could tell them.

The Interview Without a Promise

Ofori’s lawyer arrived before the interview began and asked for the questions in writing. Badu refused to provide a script of the entire interview, but he gave the lawyer the stated subjects: the judge’s movements, access to the study, the appointment-review file, and contact with the archive. He confirmed that Ofori would be treated according to the applicable procedure and that no statement would be taken without the required safeguards.

Ofori sat with his hands flat on the table. He had expected anger, Badu thought, or at least a visible effort to intimidate him. Instead the man looked exhausted and precise. He corrected the date of one meeting, disputed the description of a corridor, and asked to see the record on which a question was based.

‘You understand that a discrepancy is not proof of murder,’ Badu said.

‘I understand that you want me to accept your sequence of events.’

‘I want you to explain your own.’

The first hour produced no confession and no dramatic contradiction. Ofori acknowledged signing an administrative instruction concerning the review file, but said he had never handled the attachment now missing. He claimed the instruction authorised a routine transfer. The document showed no clear destination, and the person who should have received the file had not yet been located.

When asked about the night of the judge’s death, Ofori said he had left the building before nine. The entrance log placed a vehicle associated with his office on the premises later, but the log did not identify who was inside it. A guard remembered seeing a driver. He could not reliably identify the passenger. The detail was significant enough to check, not strong enough to turn into a fact by repetition.

Badu showed Ofori a photograph of the study corridor. Ofori studied the clock above the doorway and said it had been unreliable for months. That statement could explain the conflicting times, or it could be an attempt to make them meaningless. Badu asked who had reported the fault and whether maintenance records existed. Ofori said he did not know.

At the end of the interview, the lawyer requested a copy of the record. Badu arranged it through the proper channel and noted the breaks, attendees, and exhibits shown. The interview had not solved the case. It had defined what the team still needed: a reliable account of Ofori’s movements, proof of who could enter the study, and evidence connecting the administrative instruction to the missing attachment.

As Ofori was escorted out, he turned once. ‘You think the missing page explains the judge.’

‘I think it explains why people are afraid of the page,’ Badu said. ‘That is not the same thing.’

The Interview Room

Ofori's next interview began with the simplest questions: where he had been that evening, which route he had taken, and whether he had entered the residence. He answered fluently until Nyarko placed the access log beside his written account. He said the log might have recorded a duplicated credential or a technical fault. The team had not yet authenticated the record, so Nyarko did not argue. She asked him to identify what evidence would support his explanation.

Ofori named a technician who had serviced the gate system. The technician's records showed that a maintenance visit had taken place months earlier, but there was no report of a fault on the night of the murder. That absence did not prove the system worked perfectly; it meant Ofori's explanation still needed support. He then suggested that someone else might have used a copied credential. Investigators requested the access-control audit and the list of people who had held authorised keys.

When the interview ended, Ofori's lawyer asked whether his client was being accused of murder. Nyarko said he was being questioned about discrepancies and that no conclusion would be drawn until the evidence was assessed. Ofori left without a dramatic confession or a visible collapse. Badu found the ordinary ending frustrating, but he understood its value. The interview had produced testable claims rather than a scene designed for an audience.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

The Last Recorded Call

Forensic investigators recovered part of the judge's last recorded telephone call. Agyeman argued that the truth could not remain hidden. The caller warned that the original record becoming public would have serious consequences. Then came the chilling statement: the child was never supposed to become a witness.

The recording did not establish the caller's identity. The forensic team also found a call to a number once associated with a person connected to the Haven House inquiry. Badu and Mabel agreed that they had been asking only which child's name had changed. They also needed to ask what the children had witnessed.

An appointment review memorandum confirmed that a witness had been expected to provide evidence about the authenticity of a disputed document. The identity was missing from the surviving copy. Records showed that Ofori had accessed a separate annex shortly before Agyeman's death.

When Badu questioned Ofori, the former officer admitted that the original investigation had been left unresolved after the witness disappeared. He denied killing the judge and promised to provide evidence of his whereabouts. Badu left without knowing whether Ofori was a witness, a suspect or both.

He wrote in his casebook: The witness is the key. The child's identity is the motive. The murderer is still unknown.

Ofori arrived for the interview in a dark suit and answered questions with the confidence of a man who knew the procedures. He acknowledged visiting the annex but said he had gone there at Agyeman’s request. He denied removing any original record and said his presence at Haven House had been misrepresented. Badu asked him to account for the hours around the judge’s death. Ofori gave a timeline that appeared complete, but one interval had no independent confirmation. He promised to provide his travel records. Badu let him leave, then asked the team to verify every detail. The case had reached the point where the suspect’s calmness was no more meaningful than his nervousness. Only corroboration would matter.

The forensic specialist played the recovered audio three times. The recording began in the middle of a sentence and ended with a scrape, as if the phone had been moved. Agyeman’s voice was clear enough to identify, but the caller’s voice had been distorted by poor reception. The words about a child becoming a witness were unmistakable.

Badu asked whether the caller could be matched to Ofori. The specialist said the sample was too short for a reliable voice comparison. The call could support a timeline, not identify a murderer. Badu wrote that limitation into the report rather than allowing the team to treat a suggestive phrase as proof.

The call log placed the conversation three days before the death. Agyeman had been preparing to reopen the matter, and someone had known it. The murder could

have been an attempt to stop the review, retrieve a document, or frighten the remaining witnesses. They needed evidence of what had happened in the study, not only motive.

The Voice On The Line

The service provider's technical team delivered the recovered call file with a certificate describing the recovery method, the source device and the limitations of the audio. Nyarko insisted that the original storage medium remain sealed and that the working copy be hashed and logged. The recording was important, but its importance made the chain of custody more—not less—necessary.

They listened in a small evidence room. Agyeman's voice came through first, tired and close to the microphone. He said something about the register being a record of a child, not a tool for protecting an appointment. The second speaker interrupted. The voice was low, clipped by the poor connection and too short to identify reliably.

'If that file leaves this room, everyone will ask why you waited,' the caller said.

Agyeman answered, 'I waited because I was told the correction would be made.'

Then came the sentence that had unsettled the team from the first recovery: 'The child was never supposed to become a witness.' A scrape followed, then a burst of static. The recording ended before either speaker explained what the sentence meant.

Badu asked the technician to play the passage again. He wanted to know whether the words might have been assembled from separate fragments. The technician said the waveform showed a continuous stretch of speech, but the quality did not

allow them to determine the speaker's identity. The sentence was clear; its context was not.

'Could the caller be Ofori?' Badu asked.

'Could be,' the technician said. 'Could be someone else. The sample is too short for a responsible voice comparison. If anyone tells you otherwise, ask them to show you the method and the error rate.'

Badu wrote that answer into the evidence summary. He had learned that certainty could enter a case through the smallest opening: a familiar tone, a face in a photograph, a name repeated by several witnesses. Repetition did not make a claim independent if everyone had learned it from the same source.

Mabel asked whether the call might have been made from a number associated with Haven House. The provider's records showed a number that had once been assigned to an office line, but the account had changed hands more than once. The number was a lead, not a person. A billing record could establish that a line was active; it could not prove who had held the phone.

The team traced the number through archived service records. One account had been opened under the name of a charitable trust that later merged with another organisation. The trustee named on the form had died years earlier. A current administrator confirmed that the trust had supported Haven House's administrative expenses, but said she had never seen the appointment-review file.

Badu asked for the trust's minutes and payment records. The administrator agreed to preserve them but requested a written legal basis for disclosure. Nyarko prepared the request. They would not pressure a witness into handing over records informally only to discover later that the documents could not be properly authenticated.

Meanwhile, Mabel found a short notice in an old newspaper archive. It reported that a confidential review had been postponed after a supporting witness failed to attend. The notice did not name the witness or explain the absence. It did establish that the missing person’s testimony had mattered enough to delay the proceedings.

She brought the notice to Badu. He compared the date with the access record for the restricted annex. Ofori had entered the annex two days before the postponement. The timing connected him to the file’s handling, but not necessarily to the witness’s disappearance. He might have been retrieving material, delivering an instruction or simply using a room he was authorised to enter.

‘We need the annex inventory from before and after his visit, ’ Badu said. ‘Not a recollection of what was in it. The inventory.’

The first inventory was found in a routine administrative folder. It listed four items, including a witness statement and a carbon copy of a transfer order. The later inventory listed three. Beside the missing statement, someone had typed ‘withdrawn by witness’. No signed withdrawal was attached.

Nyarko read the line twice. ‘This is the first record that says the witness withdrew. It is not the withdrawal itself.’

They requested the typist’s roster and the office’s document-control book. The roster showed that several clerks had worked that week. The control book had an entry for a correction to the inventory, but the initials did not match the clerk who had signed the original list. The mismatch could indicate a correction by a supervisor, a clerical shortcut or an unauthorised change. It required explanation, not an immediate accusation.

Ofori’s lawyer responded to the interview request with a statement denying that his client had removed the witness statement. He said Ofori had believed the witness no longer wished to participate and had passed that information to a supervisor. The statement did not identify who had spoken to the witness or where the supposed withdrawal had been recorded.

Badu read the response to Nyarko. ‘It fits the administrative explanation, but it does not answer the central question. Who saw the witness say it?’

‘Then that is the next question,’ she said. ‘And we should ask it without telling the person what answer we expect.’

That evening, Badu returned to the call. Agyeman’s words suggested that he had once accepted the promise of a correction. The caller’s sentence suggested fear of what the child might say. Neither statement proved that the call concerned the murder, and neither established the caller’s identity. But together with the missing statement and the altered inventory, they showed that the old review had depended on a witness whose account had been removed from the surviving file.

Badu added a new line to the chronology: *The witness was expected; the record later said withdrawn; no withdrawal statement located.* He underlined the final phrase. It was not dramatic, but it was precise. The investigation was finally learning to state what it knew without pretending to know what came next.

Before leaving, he asked the evidence officer to make a clean transcript with time markers and uncertainty notes. The transcript would include inaudible sections rather than smoothing them into plausible words. A gap had to remain a gap. If the missing words

were ever recovered, the team needed to be able to compare them with the original, not with a polished guess.

The Call in Context

The forensic officer provided a second report on the damaged call recording. The recovered fragment had no continuous beginning and ended abruptly, and the device clock could not be trusted because its settings had not been preserved. The voice attributed to Agyeman was consistent with known samples, but the caller's voice was too brief for a reliable identification. The officer also noted that compression and background noise could make ordinary words sound like names. The report recommended that no transcript be treated as definitive where the audio was unclear.

Badu listened again with the transcript hidden. He heard Agyeman say that a record had to be corrected before the matter went further. The words were clear enough to establish concern, not the identity of the person being addressed. When the transcript was revealed, Badu noticed how the suggested name influenced what he thought he heard. He asked the analyst to preserve both the raw fragment and the working transcript, with uncertainty marks where appropriate.

The call record showed a connection to a number registered to an office used by several officials. The subscriber record identified the institution, not the individual who had placed or received the call. Investigators sought duty rosters and switchboard logs for that evening. Until those arrived, the call could support the chronology but not carry the accusation. Badu knew the most tempting clue was often the one that needed the most restraint.

The Prosecutor's Test

The prosecutor convened a case conference and asked each investigator to present the strongest explanation that did not

depend on another unverified explanation. The access log was useful only if its system records could be authenticated. The call data showed connections between numbers, not the words spoken. The witness statements described movements and conversations but differed on times. The physical condition of the lock explained how the door could be secured from the corridor, yet it did not identify who had used the key.

Badu presented the prosecution theory and then listed the weaknesses himself. Nyarko asked whether another person could have entered the house, left before the fatal encounter and still had a reason to lie. He admitted that the possibility had not been eliminated. The team reviewed the housekeeper’s amended account, the gate record and the duplicate key register, separating evidence that pointed toward Ofori from evidence that merely placed him within the wider history of the case.

The prosecutor concluded that the case had reached a stage where arrest could be considered if the remaining authentication steps held, but the team should not confuse a strong working theory with a proven account of every minute. They assigned officers to verify the key record, obtain a formal locksmith report and secure the original call data. The decision delayed the dramatic confrontation Badu wanted, but it strengthened the case that would eventually have to survive questions from the defence.

The audio file was recovered from a damaged storage device submitted with the judge's personal papers. Only a portion could be restored. The voice at the beginning was indistinct. A second speaker, however, became clear enough for the examiner to make out a few words: "the child was never supposed to become a witness." Then came a scrape, a burst of static, and a sharp sound that might have been a chair moving across the floor.

The technical officer warned that the recording could not establish the full conversation or the date with certainty. Badu made sure that limitation appeared in the report. He had seen too many investigations ruined by treating a fragment as if it were a complete confession.

Ofori agreed to an interview at the station. He arrived in a pressed shirt and answered questions with controlled patience. He admitted that he had been present during part of the old inquiry but denied ordering the name change. He said the judge had been obsessed with reopening the matter and that Asare had wanted it contained.

"Were you at the judge's house on the night he died?" Badu asked.

Ofori looked directly at him. "No."

"Can anyone confirm where you were?"

"My movements are not your concern unless you have evidence connecting me to the death."

"It is my concern if you are lying."

The interview ended without an admission. Ofori's calmness could mean confidence, discipline or preparation. Badu refused to decide which.

Afterward, the team reconstructed the evening minute by minute using phone records, security footage

and witness accounts. The desk clock's 9:41 reading did not match the later time stamp on the recovered call. Because the clock could have been moved after the fatal encounter, the team stopped treating it as a reliable marker of the time of death.

Badu wrote the question on the board: *What did the clock make us believe?* The room had seemed locked, the time fixed and the suspect absent. One of those certainties was almost certainly false.

Badu crossed out the phrase *locked-room murder* on the whiteboard and replaced it with *staged locked room*. The change was small, but it returned the investigation to the realm of actions a person could actually perform.

The team then tested whether the study could have been staged without leaving obvious damage. The door's lock could be engaged from inside, but the latch could also be manipulated under certain conditions. The physical examination did not establish exactly how it had been done. It established only that the room was not the impossible puzzle it had first appeared to be.

Ofori's lawyer sent a letter demanding that the police stop making insinuations to the press. Badu replied through the proper channel that no public allegation had been made and that the investigation would proceed on evidence. He did not mention the recovered access log, which was still being authenticated.

A technician found a faint reflection in a security image from the corridor. It did not show a face, but it showed movement near the study door during the camera interruption. The reflection might be consistent with someone leaving the room, though the angle made certainty impossible.

The telephone company supplied a certified log showing the time and duration of the judge's final call, but not the caller's identity. The number had passed through a routing service, and the retained records did not identify the person who had used it. The recording's voice analysis was similarly limited: the audio was too incomplete for a reliable identification. The prosecutor warned the team not to let the emotional force of the words substitute for proof of who had spoken them.

Badu revisited the housekeeper's first statement with her permission. She remembered hearing the judge say, 'It cannot remain buried, ' but could no longer say whether the phrase came before or after the call. The initial interview had been taken under stress, and her later recollection was influenced by what she had learned from the news. Badu kept both statements in the file and asked the forensic team to treat the difference transparently. The discrepancy did not make her dishonest; it limited what the phrase could prove.

The locksmith's report arrived in a sealed envelope. It stated that the study lock could be operated by key from either side and that the damage was consistent with the police forcing the door after the discovery. The report did not identify who had locked it before the police arrived. A duplicate key had once been issued for an official visit, but the return record and storage envelope required further examination. Badu asked that the key register, seal and all related correspondence be photographed together. The locked-room question was becoming a matter of access and timing, not an impossible mechanism.

Badu asked the team to build two timelines: one based on witness recollection and one based on electronic records. They were not to merge them until the differences had been explained. The stopped clock was

the only item suggesting a precise time of 9:41; every independent source gave a range or a later time stamp. The clock could have been stopped or moved to create a false sequence, but the evidence did not yet show who had done it.

The forensic team obtained a clearer copy of the judge’s final call from a backup held by the service provider. The recording still contained gaps, but its time stamp placed the conversation later than the housekeeper’s first estimate. The judge had been alive at a point when the clock-based timeline suggested he might already have been dead, strengthening the possibility that the clock had been used to mislead investigators.

The audio examiner played the recovered call at normal speed, then provided a filtered copy for clarity. The filtered version made some words easier to hear but also introduced artefacts, so the examiner cautioned against relying on it alone. Neither version yielded a reliable voice identification. Agyeman's words about a child's record and an appointment review were clear enough to guide the investigation, but the caller's identity remained open. The examiner documented the equipment, software and processing steps so that another specialist could repeat the analysis.

Badu asked whether the caller might have been using a borrowed telephone. The examiner said the call data could identify the number and connection route, not the person holding the device. Investigators would need billing records, subscriber information and corroborating evidence of possession. The number had once been registered to a company that no longer existed, and the surviving customer form carried an address that had changed street names. A team was assigned to reconstruct the address through municipal records. It was another lead, not a breakthrough, but it offered a way to move from an indistinct voice toward a person who could be interviewed.

The telephone analyst presented the call data as a timeline, not a transcript. The records showed connections and durations, but not the content of the conversations. A short call from an unregistered number might have been important, or it might have been routine. The team compared it with the housekeeper's account, the guard's log and the judge's known appointments. One gap remained: the device's clock and the security system's clock had not been synchronised. The analyst calculated the likely difference and marked the uncertainty rather than forcing every event into a perfect sequence.

Agyeman's assistant remembered that the judge had asked for a file to be brought to the study earlier that evening. She could not say whether it was the sealed annex. Her recollection was checked against a delivery note and a calendar entry. The delivery note confirmed that a file had been brought upstairs, but the description was generic. The calendar entry had been edited after the judge's death, according to the office system's audit history. The edit might have been a routine correction, so the person who made it was asked to explain the change.

The resulting timeline weakened one part of Ofori's account but did not establish the precise moment of death. Investigators could say that his version conflicted with the guard's record and the documented call sequence. They could not honestly claim that the telephone data revealed what had been said. Badu insisted that the report use careful language. A prosecutor would need to explain the limitations to a court, and the defence would be entitled to test them.

Before Sunrise

Badu barely slept. By dawn, he had arranged for Daniel to be brought to a secure interview room and asked Mabel to join the investigation as a witness rather than an unofficial partner. The night had left them with three immediate tasks: locate Mensah,

secure the missing annex, and establish who had visited Agyeman before his death.

Daniel arrived carrying a small envelope he had found among Adwoa’s papers. Inside was a photograph of a handwritten register entry and a short note in a hand he did not recognise: If you are ever asked to testify, tell them what you remember, not what you were told to remember.

He recalled a night in 2004 when he had been led away from Room Four while adults argued. He remembered a woman crying and a man insisting that the official record must show a transfer. He could not identify every speaker, but he remembered Yaw Ofori standing near the doorway.

Before sunrise, Badu received word that Mensah had been found. He was alive, shaken and unwilling to speak until he had legal protection. He agreed to meet Badu later that morning and said he could identify the person who carried the judicial file into Haven House.

The case was moving, but every new answer opened another question. Badu understood that the final hours before the judge’s death might be the only chance to connect the old incident to the murder.

Mensah told Badu that he could identify the person who had carried the judicial file into Haven House, but he wanted the original statement secured first. Badu agreed and arranged for the document to be copied, sealed and witnessed. The former inspector's willingness to speak gave the case momentum, but Badu reminded the team that fear could affect recollection and every claim still required corroboration.

At the station, Badu logged Daniel's envelope and arranged for an independent officer to sit in on the interview. Daniel described the corridor, the locked room and the argument he remembered. When shown Ofori's photograph, he said he remembered the man near the doorway, but could not swear that the memory was exact. "Then we record it exactly as you said it," Badu replied. "No more and no less."

The hours before sunrise were the quietest and most dangerous part of the investigation. A warrant request was being prepared, the evidence team was reviewing the house's access logs, and Mabel was checking a final lead about the former Haven House staff member. None of them knew whether the next discovery would clarify the case or warn the person responsible that the net was tightening.

Badu returned to the crime-scene photographs. He compared the position of the tea cup, the lamp, the clock and the judge's chair. The arrangement had been described as natural by the first officers, but each object had been left in a way that drew the eye toward the desk. The room had been staged not to hide the death, but to control the first interpretation of it.

A security log showed a short interruption in the camera feed at the residence. The gap was too brief to prove an entry by itself, yet it matched the interval in which the housekeeper said she had

heard movement from the study. Badu asked for the original recording and the system's maintenance report. He would not accept a summary when the original might settle the question.

At 4:18 a.m., Mabel called. She had located a former employee who remembered the transfer papers and had kept a diary from that period. The woman was frightened and would not meet alone. Mabel had arranged for a lawyer and a second journalist to be present.

"Do not go until we have a safety plan," Badu told her.

"I know," she replied. "This time I'm not going to mistake courage for being careless."

Outside the station, the sky was beginning to pale. The case had been built from fragments left behind by people who had waited too long to speak. Now the investigators had to make sure that the next witness would be allowed to finish.

By then, the investigation had three distinct strands: the historical records, the witness accounts and the electronic timeline from the judge's final evening. The team kept them separate until each source could be checked against the others.

Mabel arrived with the former employee's diary and a statement from the neighbour. She had not published the witness's current location. The woman had agreed to speak only after safety arrangements were confirmed, and Mabel intended to honour that condition.

Badu assigned an independent team to verify the access system and requested the original server logs. He also asked that Ofori be informed of the basis for any further interview and that his lawyer be present. There would be no shortcuts simply because the case was urgent.

The prosecutor nodded. “That is the language you should keep using.”

“Ofori’s denial about being at the residence conflicts with the access record, if the record is authenticated,” Badu said. “The clock may have been used to create a misleading time, and the historical records were deliberately altered. Those facts justify further action, but we still need the final forensic report and a clear account of how the room was staged.”

“What can you prove today?” the prosecutor asked.

At dawn, the team assembled in the briefing room. The prosecutor listened as Badu explained the evidence in sequence and challenged him whenever a conclusion moved faster than the facts. The access log was potentially decisive, but its source had to be authenticated. The recovered call was relevant, but the voice identification remained uncertain. The diary supported the historical case, but it did not by itself identify the murderer or establish the precise method of the killing.

The witness speaks

The former Haven House employee arrived shortly after seven, accompanied by a lawyer and a support person of her choosing. Badu met her in a room with a clear exit and no uniformed officers standing behind her chair. She had asked not to be photographed. Mabel waited outside until the formal interview was complete, because the witness had agreed to speak to police first and to the press only if she later chose to do so.

The woman gave her name as Efua Kwarteng and explained that she had worked in the home’s records office for less than a year. She remembered Room Four because it was used for meetings that were not entered in the ordinary visitor book. Staff

were told that the meetings concerned confidential placements. They were not told why some children's files were taken away from the main cabinet.

'Did you see a child removed from the register?' Badu asked.

'I saw an entry covered, ' she said. 'I did not see the first hand that wrote it. I saw the correction after it had been made.'

Her distinction was exact. She had noticed the alteration because the line had been scraped and rewritten, leaving the paper thinner than the surrounding page. She had asked a supervisor whether the register should be replaced. The supervisor told her to copy the final version into the monthly summary and not to retain drafts.

'Did you do that?' Nyarko asked.

The woman nodded. 'I did. I was young, and I needed the job. I told myself that if a senior person had signed it, it must have been authorised.'

She had kept a personal diary, she said, because the instruction troubled her. The diary did not contain a full account of the meeting or the child's identity. It recorded the date, the supervisor's words and the arrival of a sealed folder carried by a man she later recognised as Ofori. She could not say whether he had brought the folder into the room or collected it after the meeting.

Badu asked her to mark the passages she had written at the time and those she had added later. She used two different pens, and the examiner would compare the ink and paper before the diary was treated as a contemporaneous record. Her testimony was important, but the diary needed its own examination.

She then described the day a young girl had been brought to the records office. The girl was upset and kept asking whether she had to say what the adults had told her to say. Efua had not known the child's name. She remembered only that one adult called her 'the witness' and another told her not to repeat what she had seen in Room Four.

'Could that child have been Mabel Owusu?' Badu asked.

Efua looked at the photograph, then shook her head. 'I cannot tell you that. I remember a child, but I do not want to borrow a memory from a picture.'

Badu thanked her for the answer. It was the sort of caution that made a statement useful. Efua was not trying to solve the case; she was trying to describe the limits of what she had seen.

After the interview, Mabel met Efua with the lawyer present. She asked whether the woman remembered a child who had carried a small paper bag with a blue string tied around it. Efua closed her eyes and thought for a long moment. She remembered a blue string, she said, but could not be sure it had been tied to a bag. The detail might have belonged to another day. Mabel did not press her.

The photograph in Mabel's possession showed a child standing near a corridor. Its back had been marked with a date, but the writing could have been added later. The image analyst had already warned that the photograph could not establish the child's identity. Efua's uncertain recollection did not change that. It gave the team a question to test against other records, not permission to label the child.

Daniel listened to the interview summary later, with his consent and a support person present. When Badu explained that Efua remembered a child being coached, Daniel asked whether the child could have been him. Badu told him it was possible but

not established. Daniel accepted the answer, though disappointment crossed his face. He had hoped for a memory that belonged unmistakably to him.

‘I want to know what happened, ’ Daniel said. ‘But I don’t want every person who remembers a frightened child to decide it was me.’

‘That is right, ’ Badu replied. ‘Your life is not a blank space for us to fill with the nearest explanation.’

The statement from Efua gave the investigation a new route. The monthly summaries were sent to a regional office, and their incoming register might show when the altered entry first appeared. The team requested the surviving summaries from the relevant months and asked the archive to preserve any draft copies. If the false name had been copied into later documents, the sequence could help identify where the change entered the system.

At the same time, the technical team reviewed the residence camera interruption. The maintenance record described a brief loss of signal caused by a power fluctuation, but the backup log showed a manual reset shortly afterward. The reset might have been routine. The officer who entered it had not yet been interviewed, and the system’s clock drift had to be measured before the time could be compared with the judge’s final call.

Badu ordered the team not to place the camera interruption and Efua’s diary on a single timeline until the time sources were calibrated. One concerned events twenty-two years earlier; the other concerned the night of the murder. Their possible connection was thematic and investigative, not yet chronological proof.

By midmorning, Mensah arrived with his lawyer. He looked older than he had in the archived photographs, but his memory

for the records office was sharper than Badu expected. He identified the person who had carried a judicial file into Haven House as a clerk attached to the review secretariat. He did not identify Ofori as the carrier.

That answer unsettled the working theory. Ofori's access to the annex still mattered, but the file may have moved through several hands before it reached Room Four. Mensah said he had seen Ofori speaking to the clerk later that day. He could not hear the conversation and could not say whether they had planned anything together.

'Why did you not say this earlier?' Nyarko asked.

'Because I was afraid that if I named the clerk, people would say I had invented it to protect Ofori, ' Mensah replied. 'And because I signed a report that said I had not seen the file move. I thought I could keep that contradiction hidden.'

He had not killed the judge, he said, and he had not changed the register. But he had allowed a report to stand that left out what he remembered. He had convinced himself that silence was not the same as lying. Now he understood how easily the difference had served the people who wanted the record to disappear.

Badu recorded the admission without promising Mensah immunity. Nyarko explained that any cooperation would be assessed through the proper legal process. Mensah accepted the terms. For the first time, he provided the name of the clerk and the location of an old dispatch book that might show who signed the file out.

The team divided the search into three tasks: locating the dispatch book, authenticating the transfer documents and identifying the missing staff member. Each task had a lead

officer and a written deadline for reporting progress. Badu had learned that a case with many threads could become a case in which every person assumed someone else was following the important one. At the morning briefing, each investigator had to say not only what had been found, but what remained unverified and what would happen next.

Daniel attended the briefing only for the portion that concerned his records. He asked whether his personal information would be circulated beyond the investigation. The prosecutor explained that relevant evidence might have to be disclosed to the defence if charges were brought, but that unrelated personal details would be handled according to law. Daniel accepted the answer, though he was visibly uncomfortable. He had not chosen to become a witness in a murder case. Badu told him that he could ask for clarification at every stage and that no one expected him to fill gaps with guesses.

After Daniel left, Mabel challenged Badu about the phrase ‘the child who never existed’. It made a compelling headline, but it risked implying that Daniel’s life had been erased in every sense. Badu agreed. The records might have concealed his birth identity; they could not erase his relationships, memories or achievements. Mabel wrote the phrase in quotation marks as a clue left by an unknown person, not as the investigation’s description of Daniel. The distinction shaped the language they would use if the story reached publication.

The dispatch book was not at Haven House. It had been transferred to a district office during a later reorganisation, then moved again when the office closed. Badu requested a preservation order. The search would take time, and there was no guarantee the book survived. Still, the lead was concrete: a named office, a defined period and a specific record to find.

As the morning advanced, the case stopped looking like a single hidden act and began to resemble a chain of custody that had been broken in several places. The false entry, the missing statement, the absent withdrawal form and the disputed file movement were related, but not interchangeable. Each required its own proof.

The search for the dispatch book began at the district office's temporary records store. Staff worked from an inventory created during the closure, but several boxes had been relabelled when the building was cleared. Badu's team photographed each label and recorded the shelf location before opening anything. After hours of searching, they found a thin ledger with a water-damaged cover. The relevant month was present, though several lines had faded. A delivery entry matched the date supplied by Mensah, and a destination code matched the archive's dispatch system.

The ledger did not name the person who received the packet. It did, however, show that the transfer had been logged before the official report described the matter as a routine placement. That sequence suggested the record had been handled outside the normal process. Badu requested conservation treatment and a high-resolution scan before anyone attempted to read the faint ink. He also asked the prosecutor to preserve the original and notify the defence if it became evidence. The case was approaching a point where the same document might support more than one interpretation, and the investigators had to protect its integrity for both.

The former Haven House employee agreed to speak only after confirming that the interview would not be filmed. She described the home as under-resourced and often overwhelmed by paperwork. Forms were carried from one office to another, sometimes returned for missing signatures, and sometimes copied because the original had gone to a district department. She remembered a child being asked to repeat a name in front of

adults who appeared impatient. She did not know whether the child was being coached or simply confused, and she refused to identify the child from memory alone.

The employee’s account offered context, not a direct identification. Investigators asked whether she had kept any personal notes or letters from that period. She said she had retained a staff roster and a notice about a review meeting. The documents were collected with her consent, photographed in her presence and listed on a receipt. The roster showed who had been on duty, but it did not prove who had entered the records room. A meeting notice confirmed that senior officials had visited, though the purpose was described in general terms.

When Mabel later asked whether the employee would speak publicly, the woman declined. She feared being blamed for decisions made by people above her. Mabel respected the refusal and recorded the account for verification rather than publication. A witness could contribute to the investigation without becoming a public character in the story. The choice reminded Mabel that the truth did not belong to the press merely because the press had found it.

The Dawn Search

The team returned to the storage facility at dawn because the manager had found a second box while clearing a blocked aisle. Two officers photographed the box before it was opened, recorded the seal condition and listed every item in the presence of the manager. Inside were routine transfer slips, a carbon copy of a delivery note and an envelope marked with the old review reference. The envelope was empty. Its flap had been opened cleanly, and there was no reliable way to determine when it had last contained anything.

A delivery note carried the signature of a messenger whose employment record had ended years earlier. The name was common, and the signature differed from the sample on a

pension form. Investigators located a former supervisor who remembered the messenger but could not authenticate the handwriting. The note therefore created a lead to the messenger’s route book rather than proving that the packet had been delivered by the person named.

Daniel watched the inventory being made and asked whether the empty envelope could have held his original identity papers. Badu said it was possible but unproven. Daniel nodded, disappointed by the answer but no longer surprised by it. The case had taught him that a blank space in a file could be important without telling anyone what had once filled it. He asked for a copy of the inventory so he could keep track of what the investigation had actually found.

The discovery delayed the team’s departure because the storage company required a new authorisation before releasing the corresponding box. Badu resisted the urge to announce a breakthrough. The card was a lead, not the packet itself. He requested the next authorisation and arranged for a neutral records officer to attend the opening so that no one could later claim the search had been directed toward a predetermined conclusion.

In a cabinet at the back, they found an index card referring to a sealed bundle transferred during a system migration. The card did not name the children or identify the person who authorised the transfer. It did, however, point to a storage code that had not appeared in the first search. The officer photographed both sides of the card and recorded its position before placing it in a sleeve.

The storage annex was searched under a written warrant and an itemised plan. Officers photographed the exterior, recorded who entered, and assigned an evidence number to each box before opening it. The first containers held ordinary administrative papers: supply requests, outdated forms and duplicate correspondence. The team did not discard them simply

because they looked irrelevant. A filing label or staple pattern could later help establish where a missing packet had belonged.

The search at the annex

Mabel listened once with the examiner present. She wanted to know whether the voice could be Ofori's. The examiner said that question required a proper comparison and a suitable sample, not a resemblance judged by someone who already suspected him. Mabel wrote that answer in her notes. The recording remained a clue to the conversation's subject, not proof of the caller's identity.

The examiner could identify two voices but would not identify either speaker from the short exchange. The line quality, background noise and lack of a reference sample made confident comparison impossible. One phrase appeared to concern an original record becoming public; another was too unclear to transcribe reliably. The team agreed to use only the intelligible words in the working chronology and to describe the rest as uncertain.

The audio examiner played the recovered call in sections, first at normal speed and then through a noise-reduction process. He warned that processing could make speech easier to hear while also changing the sound enough to mislead a listener. The report preserved the original file and documented each enhancement. No one was permitted to use a cleaned fragment as though it were the untouched recording.

The Audio Examiner's Limits

The Call Timeline

The technical team laid out the available time sources on a single board: the telephone company's call log, the residence camera, the housekeeper's recollection, a security guard's shift sheet and the desk clock. Each source had a different margin of error. The camera time had drifted before the power interruption;

the guard’s sheet was completed at the end of the shift; the housekeeper remembered events by reference to a television programme; and the clock had stopped at a time that could not be independently verified.

The examiner explained that a timeline should show ranges rather than pretend to offer minute-by-minute certainty. The last confirmed outgoing call ended at 9:28 p.m. A camera event placed a visitor near the side entrance between 9:30 and 9:50, but the image did not show the visitor’s face. The housekeeper heard a raised voice sometime before ten, though she could not be sure how long before she went to the study door.

Badu asked whether the call could have continued after the fatal encounter. The examiner said the recovered audio was incomplete and its metadata had been copied from a damaged device; the time stamp could not be treated as conclusive without corroboration. The team therefore listed the recording as evidence of a conversation, not a precise time of death.

A second analyst compared the residence’s power log with the camera interruption. The power fluctuation explained part of the signal loss, but a manual restart had also occurred. The technician who performed it could not be located. Investigators issued a request for the contractor’s archived job sheets.

The board made the case less tidy. No single source fixed the time, and the stopped clock was no longer the centre of the reconstruction. Badu felt the relief of a theory becoming more honest, even as it became harder to explain.

He instructed the team to preserve every version of the timeline, with the assumptions written beside each estimate. If the case reached court, the prosecution would need to show not only the sequence it considered most likely but also why alternative sequences were less consistent with the evidence.

When the analyst finished, Badu asked him to identify the most defensible conclusion. The analyst said that the call records contradicted one version of the evening, but they did not identify the killer. Badu wrote that sentence on the case board. It was less dramatic than a revelation, and more useful. The phone had become a reliable witness to connections and timing—not a voice that could tell them what had been said.

Mabel was given the verified portions of the chronology for a right-of-reply request to the people named in her proposed article. She did not share private phone numbers or the entire evidence file. Her questions were specific: whether the official had spoken to the judge that evening, whether the visit had been recorded, and whether the official disputed the documented time. One office replied that it would not comment while the inquiry continued. Another said its records were being reviewed. Neither response established guilt or innocence.

Badu asked the team to compare the call timing with the gate log, the housekeeper’s recollection, and the medical estimate of the time of death. Each source had a different margin of uncertainty. The housekeeper remembered a sound but could not place it to the minute. The gate log contained a late entry. The medical estimate was a range, not a timestamp. The clock on the desk had stopped, but no one could establish when or why. The timeline therefore had to be drawn as overlapping windows rather than a single confident line.

The number’s last network activity occurred in the same broad period as the judge’s death, but the analyst cautioned that the phone could have been switched off earlier or used by someone other than the registered purchaser. A location estimate placed it within a wide area that included several streets and commercial buildings. It was consistent with the judge’s

residence, but also with other places nearby. The record could support a question; it could not answer it alone.

The judge’s final calls formed a pattern. One was to a number associated with the newspaper, another to a former official, and a short call was placed to a prepaid number that had not been used again. The prepaid number was registered under incomplete details. Investigators traced its sale to a retail outlet, but the clerk had no independent memory of the buyer. The transaction log narrowed the possible purchase date without identifying the person who had used the phone.

The telecommunications analyst explained that a call detail record could establish that two numbers connected at a certain time and for a certain duration. It could not reveal the words spoken, and a cell-site record did not pinpoint a person inside a particular room. The distinction disappointed the officers who wanted a precise final conversation, but Badu asked the analyst to explain the limits in writing so that no later summary would overstate the evidence.

The Call That Cannot Speak

PART FOUR — THE LAST WITNESS

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

The Clock and the Door

The reconstruction took place in the empty study with the door left open. Badu had asked the scene examiner, the building caretaker, and an independent locksmith to attend. No one was permitted to move furniture until the room had been photographed from the doorway, the desk, and the window. They recorded the position of the chair, the distance between the desk and the door, and the marks on the latch plate.

The locksmith demonstrated that the door could close and latch from the corridor if it was pulled firmly. The brass key recovered at the scene did not fit the study lock; its tag, ROOM FOUR, pointed to a separate records trail. The study could be secured from the corridor only with a working study key. The estate register showed that a duplicate had been issued to Ofori and later marked as returned, but the storage seal had been broken and the key could not be located. The paperwork therefore recorded a return without securely establishing that the key had reached safe storage. The locksmith confirmed that the duplicate type fitted the cylinder, but neither that fit nor the defective register established when the key had last been used or who had held it. The examiner warned the team against confusing a plausible mechanism with proof that the mechanism had been used on the night of the murder.

The caretaker remembered the door sticking when the weather was damp. His account explained why one witness might have heard a second pull on the handle. It did not establish that the door had been forced or that anyone had remained inside. The team marked the account as a lead and requested maintenance records, including any work done after the judge’s death.

They then examined the stopped clock. Its hands showed a time that had already become famous in the press, but the clock

itself could not establish the time of death. The battery was depleted, and no one could say when it had stopped. A cleaner remembered the clock running during an earlier visit; another employee remembered it being slow. Neither memory was precise enough to set a minute on the timeline.

Badu placed the clock evidence beside the telephone records, the building entry log, and the medical estimate. Each source had a different margin of uncertainty. The entry log recorded a vehicle, not necessarily its passenger. The call record showed a connection through a prepaid number, not the caller's exact location. The medical estimate gave a range, not a single moment. Their task was to find where the ranges overlapped, not to force every fact to match the clock.

The independent locksmith asked whether the killer might have left the room before the door latched. It was possible, but possibility was not enough. The team had no verified account of a person seen leaving at the critical moment. They listed the ordinary routes out of the room and tested which could be supported by the physical evidence. The window was too narrow to serve as an easy escape, and the service passage had a door that would have left a separate trace in the access records.

By late afternoon the reconstruction had eliminated one sensational version of the locked-room story: there was no evidence of a secret passage or an impossible lock. It had not yet established who closed the door or when. Badu recorded the conclusion plainly. The room was not a puzzle that could name its own murderer; it was a physical space whose details had to be weighed alongside testimony and records.

On the drive back, Badu dictated a note for the case supervisor. The locksmith's demonstration had clarified the mechanics, but the duplicate key connected the inquiry to a register he had not maintained and a man whose statements he had already challenged. He asked that another investigator independently review the key register, the seal photographs and

the record of Ofori's earlier visits. The request would slow the inquiry by a day, perhaps two. It would also make it harder for anyone to argue later that Badu had selected only the evidence that suited his theory. He signed the note before handing it over, then kept his own copy in the case diary.

Before leaving, he asked the examiner to seal the photographs and retain the original measurements. If a later witness challenged the layout, another investigator should be able to repeat the work. The case had too many people relying on private recollection already. Its strongest conclusions would have to be those another person could independently test.

The Missing Duplicate

The key register was brought to the study the following morning in a clear evidence sleeve. The estate manager, Mr Tetteh, had signed the original page years earlier, when Ofori borrowed a duplicate for an official visit. The return column carried a tick and a date, but the tick had been made in different ink from the entry beside it. Tetteh would not say who had added it. He remembered the key being returned to the cabinet, not the person who placed it there.

"Can you say the key was missing on the night of the murder?" Nyarko asked.

"No," Tetteh replied. "I can say the cabinet seal was broken when I checked it after the police asked about the register. I cannot tell you when it was broken or who opened it."

Badu recorded the answer without trying to improve it. The register established that Ofori had once been given access to a duplicate. The damaged seal established that the cabinet had later been disturbed. Neither fact, alone, proved that Ofori possessed the key on the night Agyeman died. They needed the locksmith's

findings, the entry log, the guard's account and the other evidence to be tested together.

The locksmith repeated the demonstration with a working duplicate supplied by the estate manager. From the corridor, the key turned the lock after the door had been pulled firmly into its frame. The demonstration explained a practical way the study could have been locked from outside; it did not reproduce the murder or identify who had left the room. Nyarko had the test recorded from two angles and required the locksmith to sign a note describing the exact key and lock used.

Mabel, waiting outside the cordon, asked whether the police had solved the locked room. Badu told her only that the room was no longer impossible. The difference mattered. A mechanism could be demonstrated; the sequence of events still had to be established from evidence. She wrote the distinction in her notebook and did not turn it into a headline.

That afternoon the team sealed the register, photographed the broken cabinet seal, and requested the manager's earlier maintenance records. Badu added one sentence to the timeline: "Duplicate key access is plausible; actual possession at the critical time remains to be proved." It was not the dramatic answer the public wanted, but it was the most accurate statement they had.

The Dawn Briefing

At dawn, the team returned to the evidence board and removed every line that had been drawn from a disputed recollection to a firm conclusion. The revised board used solid lines for authenticated records, dotted lines for testimony awaiting corroboration and separate notes for hypotheses. It looked less impressive than the earlier diagram, but it was easier to explain. Badu asked every officer to identify one assumption they had been tempted to treat as fact. The exercise produced

several corrections and one new request for the telephone company.

The medical estimate of the time of death was reviewed alongside the housekeeper’s account and the call data. None of the sources could provide an exact minute. The clock in the study had stopped, but there was no reliable proof that it stopped at the moment of the fatal encounter. The team therefore treated the clock as a scene detail rather than the foundation of the timeline. The reconstruction now described a range and identified what could narrow it.

Mabel received a summary of the confirmed facts for her right-of-reply questions. She asked whether the prosecutor had approved publication, and Badu explained that the newspaper was independent but should avoid exposing confidential evidence or identifying protected witnesses. She agreed to submit the most sensitive claims to the editor and legal adviser. The dawn briefing ended with fewer certainties than it began, yet Badu felt the case had become stronger because the remaining questions were visible.

Before Sunrise

A Route Through the Records

The team mapped the movement of the Haven House papers on a wall in the records office. Each transfer was marked with the date, the sending office, the receiving office and the document that proved the handover. Several steps were supported only by a later summary. Others were recorded in a register whose pages had been renumbered. The gaps were not proof that the papers had been stolen, but they showed where the chain of custody could no longer be assumed.

A junior archivist noticed that the same reference number appeared on two packets stored in different departments. One was a routine administrative copy; the other was marked restricted. The duplicate number might have resulted from a

clerical error, but it had allowed later staff to refer to the wrong packet without noticing. The archivist prepared a note explaining the discovery and preserved the original labels before anyone attempted to correct them.

Badu asked the team to avoid merging the two histories. They created separate timelines and listed every point at which a document had been copied, renamed or moved. The exercise exposed an uncomfortable fact: some officials might have acted dishonestly, but the system itself had also made mistakes easy to conceal. A weak filing procedure could protect a deliberate alteration by making it look like an ordinary administrative failure.

Mabel used the timelines to check her own notes. One date in her draft article had been taken from a digital catalogue rather than the original register. She corrected it before publication and told Kofi why. The correction embarrassed her, but she knew a small mistake could give a powerful subject an excuse to dismiss the larger story.

By the end of the day, the team had not found a complete original file. They had something more limited but still useful: a defensible account of what was missing, when the gaps first appeared, and which people had access to the relevant offices. The next task was to connect those opportunities to specific acts, not merely to names on a list.

The Limits of the Reconstruction

The next morning, Badu asked the team to reconstruct the hours before Agyeman’s death without using the suspect’s name as the starting point. They began with the house itself: the gate register, the housekeeper’s account, the security camera that had failed to preserve a complete sequence, and the condition of the study door. Every fact was written on a separate card. A card could be moved when a new fact emerged; a conclusion could not be allowed to disguise itself as a fact.

Nyarko placed the medical estimate of the time of death beside the records of the calls and visits. The ranges overlapped, but none fixed the moment precisely. The stopped clock in the study had been moved after the fatal encounter, according to the dust pattern photographed by the first officers. That made it a poor guide to the time, though it remained a clue to someone's later activity. Badu had once treated the clock as the centre of the puzzle. Now he understood that it was a deliberate distraction or a misleading object, not a reliable timestamp.

The locksmith repeated the test with a duplicate key and a replica of the lock. The door could be secured from the corridor after someone left the room. The demonstration explained the physical possibility; it did not establish that this was what happened on the night. The key register had a gap, and the surviving entry did not identify the person who carried the duplicate. A key could support the theory only when connected to a person through independent evidence.

The housekeeper reviewed her statement with counsel present. She remembered hearing the study door close and later seeing a figure near the hall, but she could not swear that the figure was Ofori. The first interview had been hurried, and a question had introduced the suspect's name before she gave her description. She corrected the record rather than allowing the earlier certainty to stand. Badu thanked her and made sure the correction was preserved alongside, not instead of, the original statement.

Mabel asked whether the public would understand a case built from qualified findings. Badu said the public deserved an honest account, not a tidy one. The investigation could show why Ofori had become the principal suspect, why the access records mattered, and why the missing key deserved scrutiny. It could not honestly claim that a single clue answered every question. The murder and the older identity scheme were connected by records and people, but each connection still needed proof.

At the end of the review, Nyarko separated the timeline into three columns: established events, events supported by contested evidence, and open questions. The last column was the longest. It included the exact time of death, the person who last handled the duplicate key, the source of the anonymous envelope, and the identity of the person who had altered the Haven House register. The list did not weaken the case. It showed the team where careful work remained necessary.

Badu looked at the board and saw that the mystery had changed shape. The locked study was no longer an impossible room; it was a room whose sequence of access had to be proved. The altered name was no longer a single forged line; it was a chain of decisions, omissions and convenient records. Neither puzzle would be solved by declaring a theory complete. He authorised the team to preserve every competing explanation until the evidence could distinguish among them.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

The Child Who Never Existed

The annex was located in a storage facility under an old administrative reference. Inside were duplicate forms, a transfer order and a list of five children. One entry had been marked as cancelled, while another had been inserted without a lawful explanation. The records suggested that an identity had been removed from the official system rather than merely changed.

Mabel compared the annex with her childhood photograph. The register listed five children, and one entry had been erased so thoroughly that the official record treated the child as if he had never existed. Daniel's memories helped identify that altered entry as the child later known as Daniel Sarpong. The annex also contained a statement from a child witness whose name was missing.

Badu now believed the altered identity had served two purposes: concealing the child's history and preventing the child from being recognised as a witness. The people who approved the arrangement might have believed they were protecting him. Others had used the arrangement to protect themselves.

The annex included a sealed envelope addressed to Justice Agyeman. It had never been opened. Badu arranged for it to be photographed and documented before examining its contents.

Daniel read the register with Badu beside him. The name Emmanuel Sarpong appeared beneath the overwritten entry, while the name Emmanuel Badu had been added in a different hand. Daniel had been raised as Daniel Sarpong, but the record suggested that his birth identity had been manipulated to make the original child difficult to trace. The false entry had also drawn Kwame's father into the paper trail. Badu explained that the documents did not yet establish who had ordered the change. Daniel asked whether he could ever know which parts of his life had been deliberately arranged. Badu told him that they could establish what the records proved, but they could not manufacture answers where the evidence was silent. It was not a comforting answer. It was, however, an honest one.

The annex inventory was completed in the presence of an independent records officer. Badu insisted that every folder be photographed before it was moved. The paperwork showed that one child's entry had been cancelled in the register while a substitute identity was added elsewhere. There was no lawful order explaining the change, only a chain of initials and approvals. Mabel studied the page in silence. She remembered the children in the photograph, but the register seemed to describe a different group: names that appeared and vanished depending on which copy one read. She had spent years reporting on public accountability. Now she could see how a person could be made invisible without anyone physically removing them—one altered line, one

missing attachment, one official who decided not to ask a question.

The witness statement was kept in a separate envelope. Its wording suggested that a child had overheard an argument about the appointment review and could connect the disputed document to the people who had handled it. The witness was not simply a bystander. Their testimony threatened to show that the official story had been built on a false record.

The former employee’s diary was a small exercise book with a cracked blue cover. Most entries concerned meals, supply deliveries and the daily arguments of a crowded institution. Between them were brief notes about Room Four: a child brought in after supper; a form rewritten; an instruction to use a different surname. The writer did not explain everything. She had recorded what she could without knowing which details would matter later.

One entry named Emmanuel. Another said, *He corrected them again today. They told him he must answer to the new name.* The handwriting grew smaller in the final pages, as if the writer had been trying to fit more words into less space.

Daniel read the entry in silence. He had spent his life being told that his memories were incomplete, that children misunderstood adults, that names on documents were more reliable than recollection. The diary did not answer every question, but it confirmed that his resistance to the new name had existed before he was old enough to understand why it mattered.

Mabel asked whether he wanted to stop reading. He shook his head.

“If I stop now, someone else will decide what this means.”

Badu arranged for the diary to be examined and authenticated. The former employee gave a statement about how she had kept it, where it had been stored and why she had never handed it to the authorities. Her fear was not theatrical. She had watched complaints disappear into offices and had concluded that a record kept privately might outlast a report made officially.

The diary also mentioned a transfer signature. The name was partly smudged, but enough remained to direct the team toward the person who had authorised the paperwork.

The erased child now existed in more than a corrupted database. He existed in the memory of another person, in ink written before anyone knew how the story would end.

“You are speaking now,” Badu replied. “We will make sure the record says that.”

“I waited too long,” she said.

After the interview, the witness asked what would happen to her statement. Badu explained that it would be preserved, reviewed by the prosecutor and disclosed according to the legal process. He did not promise that speaking would be easy or that every person responsible would be punished.

Mabel asked whether the witness recognised the adults in the photograph. She identified Agyeman and Ofori, but said she had only seen Asare once and could not be certain. Her caution mattered. The team recorded the identification as qualified, not definitive.

He closed his eyes, then opened them. The confirmation did not give him a complete past, but it returned a piece of his own voice to him.

“Yes,” she said. “You said Emmanuel. You said it more than once.”

Daniel listened to the recording with permission. He asked one question: “Did I ever tell you my name?”

She explained that she had kept the diary because the official report later claimed she had never worked at Haven House. The diary contained routine entries that placed her there on the relevant dates. It was not proof of every allegation, but it challenged the official claim that she had been a stranger to the institution.

The former employee agreed to provide a recorded statement after speaking with an independent lawyer. Her hands shook as she described the transfer, but her account was precise about what she had seen and careful about what she had inferred. She had witnessed a form being signed; she had not seen who first ordered the change. She had heard an argument in the corridor; she could not quote every word.

The Dispatch Book

The dispatch book arrived under seal two days later. Its cover had warped from damp, and several pages had stuck together near the spine. An archivist separated the pages under controlled conditions while the document examiner photographed each opening. Badu waited through the process, aware that a single impatient attempt to pull a page free could destroy the very trace they needed.

The relevant entry was brief. A file marked ‘confidential review’ had been signed out by a clerk named Samuel Tetteh and returned later that afternoon. The receiving initials were different from the initials on the outgoing line. A note in the margin read, ‘Annex copy retained’. There was no inventory of what the annex copy contained.

Mensah identified Tetteh from an old staff photograph but warned that the man’s appearance had changed and that he had

not seen him for many years. The personnel file showed that Tetteh had left the service in 2007 and died in 2019. His employment record contained no disciplinary finding related to Haven House.

‘We cannot interview him, ’ Mabel said when she heard. ‘But we can find out who inherited his papers, whether he kept work notebooks, and whether the annex copy was ever registered.’

Badu agreed. The death of a possible witness did not turn suspicion into guilt. It changed the questions the team could ask. They requested the retirement file, the records of the office where he had worked, and any surviving correspondence about the confidential review.

The first response came from Tetteh’s daughter, Abena. She said her father had kept boxes of old papers but that most were thrown away when the family moved. She had retained one envelope marked ‘Haven House’, because she had never understood why he kept it separate from his other employment documents. She was willing to hand it over through a lawyer, but wanted to know whether the family would be named publicly.

Nyarko explained that the police could not promise absolute secrecy if the material became relevant to proceedings. They could, however, record the family’s concerns and avoid disclosing personal details unnecessarily. Abena agreed to meet the evidence officer. She did not want the family’s cooperation portrayed as proof that her father had done something wrong.

Inside the envelope were two carbon copies of routine letters and a small sheet listing document numbers. One number matched the confidential review file; another matched a receipt for a sealed packet. The sheet was unsigned. The paper could have been Tetteh’s working note, a copy prepared for another

officer, or a list he had been asked to keep. Its provenance had to be established before anyone could say more.

The examiner found that the sheet was consistent in age with the other papers, but could not determine who had written it. The handwriting was not a match for the surviving examples of Tetteh’s signature. It might have been another employee’s writing, or Tetteh’s own informal hand. The result narrowed nothing to a single person, yet it gave the archive team a second number to trace.

That number led to a receipt book held by a former regional administrator. The receipt described a packet sent to the judicial review secretariat. The sender field contained only an office code, and the destination signature was a line rather than a name. The packet’s contents were not listed. Once again, the paperwork proved movement but not substance.

Badu stared at the copied receipt. ‘The system records where the packet went, but not what happened after it arrived.’

‘Or the detail was recorded somewhere else,’ Nyarko said. ‘We have not found every record yet.’

The distinction mattered. It was possible that documents had been deliberately removed. It was also possible that poor recordkeeping, changes in office structure and the loss of old files had made the trail appear more coordinated than it was. The investigation could not choose between those explanations until it had exhausted the surviving evidence.

Mabel interviewed Abena with her consent and did not ask her to speculate about her father. Abena remembered him bringing home a file once and refusing to let the children touch it. He had said it belonged to work and would be returned the next morning. She could not say whether it was the Haven House

file. She had been a teenager, and the memory had become sharper only after the police called.

Mabel kept the recollection out of her draft article. It was too uncertain and too easy to turn into a scene of secret guilt. Instead, she asked Abena whether she had any calendar, diary or letter that fixed the date. There was none. The memory remained a personal recollection, useful as a lead but not as proof.

The next break came from a payroll register. Tetteh had been assigned to a temporary review team for six weeks in 2004. Ofori's name appeared on the same team list, though the two men had different duties. The assignment explained why their names crossed in the records; it did not establish that they had conspired. Badu asked for the team's meeting minutes and the schedule of document access.

The minutes were incomplete. One page recorded a discussion about 'protecting the child from unnecessary publicity'. Another noted that the panel had agreed to postpone the witness session until the file was verified. The page did not say who proposed the delay. The following meeting's minutes described the witness as unavailable, then moved to the next item.

Nyarko read the pages and frowned. 'This is how a decision disappears. The minutes show the outcome, but not who made it or what information they used.'

Badu asked whether the missing detail could be recovered from the secretary's personal notes. The secretary had died, but her son remembered boxes of papers in a storage room. He would search if the police provided a formal request and did not arrive unannounced. Nyarko prepared the letter that afternoon.

At home, Daniel sat with the certified copy of his birth entry. He had started writing the name Emmanuel Sarpong at the top of a notebook, then stopped. He was not ready to replace the name

he had carried for most of his life, and he resented the idea that anyone expected him to do so quickly. The document gave him a fact about his beginning. It did not decide how he should live with it.

Adwoa sent a short message asking whether he wanted her to bring his old school certificates. Daniel replied that he did, but asked her not to explain the documents before he had read them. For years she had tried to protect him by deciding which truths he could bear. Now, even when she wanted to help, she was learning to wait for his consent.

When the certificates arrived, the earliest one used the name Daniel Sarpong, while a later form listed Emmanuel Badu as an alternative identity. The change was not explained. Daniel noticed that the school’s admission date fell several months after the transfer recorded in the Haven House papers. The gap did not prove where he had been during those months, but it gave the team a period to investigate.

Badu asked the school archive for the original admission register and any supporting letter. The school had retained a scanned copy, but the paper original had been transferred to a central store. The scan showed a faint entry beneath the current name. The archivist warned that the mark could be bleed-through from the reverse side. A forensic examiner would need to inspect the original before they treated it as an earlier name.

The new lead altered the plan for the next week. One team would trace the missing annex copy and the receipt chain. Another would locate the original school register and compare the name entries. A third would continue examining the murder timeline independently. Badu wanted the strands to meet only where the evidence justified it; the old identity case could explain motive, but it could not substitute for proof of the killing.

Before the briefing ended, Nyarko asked Badu what he believed had happened at Haven House. He answered carefully: a child's identity had been changed; a witness statement had been removed from the surviving file; officials had accepted an undocumented claim that the witness withdrew; and later records had repeated the altered identity. The precise sequence and the responsibility of each person remained unresolved.

'And the murder?' she asked.

'The evidence increasingly places Ofori at the residence during a period he denied visiting. But we still need to complete the technical examination, establish the key's chain of custody, and test the alternative explanations. The old file may explain why Agyeman wanted to speak. It does not by itself prove who caused his death.'

Nyarko nodded. 'That is the case you can defend. Keep it there.'

That evening, an envelope arrived at the station addressed to Badu. It contained no letter, only a photocopy of the missing inventory page. In the margin, beside the words 'annex copy retained', someone had written a name that was absent from every official version: 'E. Sarpong'. The handwriting could not be identified from the copy, and the page had no reliable source information. It might be authentic, fabricated, or copied from a record the team had not yet seen.

The storage facility's manager produced a ledger of boxes received during the district office reorganisation. Several entries had been copied from handwritten lists, and one page had been repaired with archival tape. The box containing the annex was listed under a broad category rather than a case number. The manager allowed the team to inspect the receiving ledger under supervision and provided a certified copy of the relevant page. No one was permitted to remove the original from the room.

Inside the annex, the investigators found forms that had survived because they were filed under a different administrative heading. Some were duplicates; others contained marginal notes absent from the official record. The phrase ‘E. Sarpong’ appeared on one inventory page, but the document did not explain whether the initials referred to a child, a relative or an employee. The handwriting comparison was inconclusive. Badu resisted the temptation to call it the missing child’s true name until a second source could confirm the connection.

A clerk who had worked at the facility remembered a request to keep one packet separate from the main file. He could not identify who made the request and admitted that he had not seen the contents. His statement explained how a document might have been stored apart, but not why. The team recorded his account and checked his employment dates. The new evidence gave them a more reliable route through the archive, yet it also exposed how easily a routine filing choice could become a mystery years later.

Badu sealed the envelope and logged it. He did not call Daniel or tell Mabel that the mystery was solved. The name was another lead, and a potentially important one, but the sender’s purpose was unknown. It could be a warning, a test, or an attempt to pull the investigation away from the murder.

He placed the new page beside the old receipt. The initials on the paper seemed to point directly toward Daniel’s erased identity. Yet the source remained unverified. The team could not simply accept it. They had to find the original, identify who had copied it, and establish whether it predated the sender’s knowledge of the investigation.

The document examiner compared the new scan with the surviving register and found similarities in the paper stock and ruling, but not enough to declare that both pages came from the same book. The examiner also noted that the handwriting varied

across the entries. Some differences could reflect multiple clerks; others might be deliberate. The report stated its limits plainly. Badu sent it to the prosecutor and resisted the temptation to describe it to the team as confirmation of the entire theory.

Mabel, meanwhile, found a former Haven House volunteer who remembered five children being assembled for a photograph after a meeting with officials. The volunteer could not remember the date without seeing the picture and did not know the children's legal names. She recalled that one child was taken indoors before the photograph was finished. Her account supported the possibility that the photograph recorded a real gathering, but it could not establish the identity of every child. Mabel wrote down the exact limits of the memory and asked whether the volunteer would provide a statement. The woman agreed, on condition that her current address remain confidential unless disclosure became legally necessary.

The dispatch book was stored in a box marked with the wrong year. An archivist noticed the error because the binding style did not match the other volumes in the series. Inside, the entries recorded packages sent between offices, including one marked only with a reference number. The number matched the missing packet. No recipient’s name appeared in the main column, but a faint pencil notation in the margin pointed to a second ledger. The discovery was not a dramatic recovery of the packet itself; it was a map to another record that might confirm where it had gone.

The second ledger showed that the packet had been received, then transferred again two days later. The receiving initials could belong to more than one employee. Investigators compared staff rosters and specimen signatures, but the evidence did not yet identify the person conclusively. One retired official was still alive and agreed to provide a sample signature for comparison. The team documented the process and avoided showing him the

disputed entry before he supplied the sample, reducing the risk of unconscious imitation.

Daniel studied the reference number and recognised it from a photocopy Adwoa had kept in a household folder. The match was significant, but it did not prove that the documents were the same packet; numbering systems sometimes reused prefixes across departments. Badu asked the archivist to confirm the series and year before drawing a conclusion. For Daniel, the possibility that the file had survived somewhere was both hope and dread. A surviving record might answer his questions, or reveal that people he loved had known more than they admitted.

The Clerk’s Ledger

The former clerk’s family allowed investigators to inspect a ledger kept among his work papers. It contained shorthand references, dates and initials, but no explanation of the abbreviations. A retired colleague helped decode several entries and warned that the clerk sometimes used personal reminders rather than formal case labels. One line referred to a packet ‘held until confirmation’. Another showed a tick beside the appointment-review number. Neither entry named the person who had given the instruction.

The prosecutor asked a handwriting specialist to compare the ledger with authenticated work samples. The specialist found similarities in letter formation but could not give a conclusive attribution because the entries were brief. The family’s account of where the ledger had been stored was recorded, and the pages were photographed before any further handling. The document might help reconstruct office practice, but it could not be treated as an official register without additional corroboration.

Badu began to see the old inquiry as a chain of small decisions rather than a single dramatic order. A clerk accepted an instruction; an inspector signed a receipt; an administrator delayed a correction; a senior officer chose not to ask again.

Each person could describe their act as minor. Together, those acts had made the false identity durable. The participants might not have shared a motive, but each decision deserved scrutiny.

Daniel was told about the discovery in a private meeting. He asked whether it meant the original name had been recovered. Badu said it made the link stronger but did not settle every part of the identity question. Daniel was disappointed, yet he thanked the team for refusing to tell him more than they knew. The case had begun with adults insisting that a convenient story was enough. He did not want the investigation to repeat that mistake in the opposite direction.

One entry contained a child’s reference number matching the number on Daniel’s clinic card. The match was important because the number was uncommon, but the team still needed to establish that the clinic card had not been copied from the same source. Investigators contacted the clinic’s successor organisation and asked whether a separate ledger survived. Until that search was complete, the two documents were treated as potentially related, not independent confirmation.

The newly located box contained a carbon duplicate of a transfer list, but the carbon was faint and the final line had been clipped by the copier. A document specialist compared the spacing and typewriter defects with known office copies from the same period. The results suggested that the sheet had been produced in the relevant office, although the specialist could not identify the typist or prove that the list had not been altered afterwards.

The Fifth Entry

The examiner photographed the erased line under several kinds of light, then compared it with the duplicate index and a carbon copy found in the annex. No single image restored the original entry. Together, however, the documents showed that the fifth line had once contained a longer name and a reference

number. The name could be read from the carbon copy, but the examiner warned that its link to the register depended on proving the copies came from the same record set.

The archive's old numbering guide supplied a partial answer. The reference number belonged to a batch of transfer forms issued during the week of the Haven House review. The batch list recorded five forms, although only four were present in the surviving bundle. The missing form might have been the one associated with Daniel, but the guide did not identify the children individually.

Daniel listened as Badu explained the result. He asked whether the evidence proved that someone had deliberately erased his name. Badu said it strongly supported alteration, but the precise author and reason remained open. The page might have been changed to conceal an identity, to comply with an unlawful instruction, or to cover a different administrative failure. They needed testimony and linked records before deciding.

Mabel reviewed the proposed wording for her article. She removed the phrase 'erased from existence' and replaced it with a description of the altered register and missing transfer form. The more dramatic phrase would attract attention, but it suggested a total disappearance that the evidence did not support. Daniel had lived, studied and worked under a name; the injustice was that the record of his earlier identity had been concealed.

The team searched the annex inventory for the absent form. A handwritten note referred to a bundle returned to the central registry, but the receipt number was incomplete. It was the same kind of gap they had seen elsewhere: a small missing piece that might be ordinary clerical error or a deliberate opening through which accountability had escaped.

Badu added the missing form to the evidence schedule and requested a search of the central registry. The fifth entry was no

longer only a symbol in an old photograph. It was a specific document whose absence could be traced, tested and perhaps explained.

The dispatch book gave the investigation a new list of offices and a narrower period for further searches. It also revealed how much depended on the habits of clerks whose work had never been expected to carry the weight of a murder inquiry. A missing initial, an incomplete receipt and a copied number might once have seemed trivial. Now each omission had to be tested carefully, because the difference between ordinary disorder and deliberate interference was precisely what the case was trying to establish.

Daniel was shown a plain-language summary of the finding, not the original evidence. He asked whether it proved that his records had been moved deliberately. Badu told him that it proved a packet had been recorded as dispatched, while leaving the contents and final destination uncertain. Daniel was frustrated by the answer. He had lived for years with documents that contradicted one another and wanted one page to settle the matter. Badu understood the feeling but refused to give him a certainty the evidence did not contain.

The number matched the faint code on the microfilm, but only after one character was interpreted as a seven rather than a one. Two analysts independently examined the image and disagreed. They documented both readings. The original page was too damaged to settle the question, so the team searched adjacent registers for a matching packet number. A second book contained a similar number, but its date was three days later and the receiving office was different. It might have been a correction or a separate item. No one was permitted to silently choose the version that best supported the theory.

A retired dispatch supervisor reviewed the entry without being told which person the police suspected. He recognised the format as one used when a file annex was sent separately from its main folder. He could not identify the initials. The team then showed him the relevant procedure manual and asked whether the entry followed the standard format. He said the reference number was incomplete; a proper entry should also identify the sender. The omission might have been an error, an abbreviated practice, or deliberate concealment. The record did not distinguish among those possibilities.

The entry they sought appeared in a column headed “outgoing material.” It listed a sealed packet, a reference number and the initials of a receiving office. The line did not name the packet’s contents. A later hand had added a question mark beside the reference number. The ink looked darker, but the conservator warned that ink colour could change because of storage, paper treatment or different pens. A visual difference alone could not establish when the mark was made.

The Five Children

The team prepared a confidential schedule for the five child-record positions appearing across the surviving versions of the register. It recorded the names appearing in each version, the source of each entry, the date of the document and the degree of confidence attached to any identification. The schedule was not shared with the press. Four histories could be traced across at least some records, although contradictions remained; the altered entry associated with Daniel was one of those histories, not an additional child. The note about “the fifth child” was kept separate because the phrase might refer to a witness or to someone omitted from the official sequence. Two people whose identities could be established had grown into adults with no apparent connection to the murder, and investigators had a duty

not to expose them simply because their names appeared on an old page.

A social worker helped the team plan how to contact those whose identities could be established. The first letter explained the purpose of the inquiry, offered a confidential meeting and made clear that the recipient was not accused of wrongdoing. One person replied through a lawyer and declined to participate. Another asked for time. Badu accepted both responses. A witness’s refusal to speak did not prove that the person had something to hide.

The schedule also revealed a gap: one child’s later records stopped abruptly after the review period. That absence could reflect relocation, record-retention rules or the name change itself. The team sought a lawful search of the relevant registers rather than assume disappearance. Daniel read the schedule only after private details about the other children had been removed. He said he wanted his own story restored, not at the cost of turning the others into public suspects.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

The Mother's Secret

The letter from the former administrator did not absolve anyone. It confirmed pressure from officials, but it also showed that staff members had complied rather than risk their jobs. Badu understood that the case would be more difficult than a simple conspiracy: some people had acted out of fear, others from ambition, and some might have done both.

The initials Y. O. appeared on a movement slip for the annex file. An examiner confirmed that the ink and paper were consistent with the period, though the initials alone could not prove who had written them. Badu requested a handwriting comparison and a full access audit. The evidence was finally converging on Ofori, but he would not make the arrest until the timeline and physical details of the murder held together.

Adwoa’s second interview was recorded in full. She confirmed that she had been told the transfer was temporary and that the official record would be corrected after the appointment review. She also remembered seeing Ofori carrying a file from Room Four. She could not say what was inside it, and she would not identify him as the person who changed the register. Her testimony was narrow, but it could be checked against the access log and the photograph.

Mabel listened to the account without interrupting. She was beginning to understand that her childhood had been treated as a problem to manage rather than a life to respect. The adults had decided what the children were allowed to remember, then preserved the decision in official documents. She could not yet recover the full

event, but she could refuse to repeat the old silence. Adwoa apologised to Daniel again. This time she did not ask him to forgive her. She said she would answer the questions the police asked, even if the answers damaged her reputation. Daniel told her that he could not decide the future of their relationship in one conversation. For the first time, they spoke without pretending that the past could be repaired by a promise.

Adwoa's second statement was taken in the presence of her lawyer and Daniel. She did not try to defend the false entry. Instead, she described the decisions that had led her to accept it, one after another, each made under pressure and each easier to justify than the last.

She had been told that the child's family could not be traced. She had been told that the paperwork would be corrected. She had been told that asking too many questions could send him back to an institution where no one seemed willing to claim him. The assurances had come from people with official titles, and she had mistaken authority for reliability.

Daniel listened without looking at her. When she finished, he asked whether she had ever called him Emmanuel in private.

"Once," she said. "When you were asleep. I wanted to hear how it sounded."

"Why didn't you tell me?"

"Because I was afraid the truth would take you away from me. Then I was afraid that telling you late would hurt you more. Every year gave me another reason to wait."

Daniel stood and went to the window. He did not accuse her of failing to love him. That would have been simpler than what

he felt. He could recognise the care she had given him and still resent the lie that had shaped his life.

"I need time," he said.

Adwoa nodded. "You should have had the truth before you needed to ask for it."

Badu recorded the exchange only after both had agreed to continue the formal statement. The emotional truth of the moment mattered, but so did the legal record. He wanted the case to survive scrutiny and the family to retain the dignity that had been denied to them by the original deception.

When they left, Daniel carried a copy of the diary entry. He did not yet call himself Emmanuel. A name recovered from a document could not instantly replace the life he had lived. But it could begin to restore the choice that had been taken from him.

The historical inquiry was no longer only about who had falsified a record. It was also about what repair might look like when the truth arrived too late to return the years it had taken.

That evening, Badu asked the records team to prepare a source map for every document in the file. He wanted more than a list of papers. Each item needed a chain of custody, the person who had first located it, the place where it had been kept, and the reason it was believed to belong to the original review. A photocopy could point them toward a source; it could not silently take the place of the source itself.

The instruction irritated one of the younger officers, who had spent the day sorting boxes and believed the case was already clear. Badu did not rebuke him. He placed two versions of the transfer form side by side. The names were nearly identical, but the dates had been entered in different hands and the stamp on the second copy sat a fraction higher. Those differences might prove deliberate alteration, or they might reflect a later copying

process. The examiner would have to say what the paper could support.

"We are not trying to make the evidence dramatic," Badu said. "We are trying to make it survive the first serious question asked of it."

He divided the team's work into three separate questions: who altered the child's identity, who suppressed the witness statement, and who caused the judge's death. The questions might lead to the same person, but the team was not permitted to assume that they did. A person could participate in one wrong and know nothing about another. A conspiracy could be broad without every participant sharing every secret.

The distinction also protected Daniel. News of the recovered birth record had already begun to travel through official corridors. Badu instructed the team not to circulate Daniel's name beyond those who needed it for the inquiry. The record was evidence, not public property, and Daniel had spent enough of his life having other people decide what his identity meant.

Mabel met Daniel outside the station after the formal interviews. She showed him the proposed wording of her next article, including the parts she intended to withhold until the registry confirmed the certified entry. He read it slowly and pointed to one sentence that described him as a child who had been "given a false identity."

"That makes it sound as if I was only a mistake," he said.

Mabel crossed out the phrase. Together they settled on a more exact description: official records had been altered, and Daniel had grown up under an identity he had not chosen. The wording did not soften what had happened, but it did not reduce his life to the wrongdoing either.

Before they parted, Daniel asked whether she believed the murder and the altered register were part of the same plan. Mabel answered honestly that the connections were strong enough to investigate but not yet strong enough to publish as fact. She had learned, through her own suppressed statement, how easily a confident adult could turn a child's partial memory into a convenient story. She would not repeat that mistake with a headline.

At home, Adwoa placed the old school photographs on the table and asked Daniel whether he wanted them. He chose two and left the rest in their envelopes. The choice seemed small, but it was the first decision about his past that nobody challenged. Adwoa did not ask him to forgive her. She promised instead to answer future questions without deciding in advance which truths he could bear.

After the meeting, Badu reviewed Adwoa's statement against the transfer note. The dates aligned closely enough to support her account of when Daniel came into her care. The identity of the person who arranged it remained uncertain.

Daniel accepted that the love was real. He could not yet decide what forgiveness would mean. The two facts were allowed to exist together.

Adwoa began to cry, but she did not ask him to comfort her. She apologised for the false explanations, for the missing photographs and for the years in which she answered questions with half-truths. She also told him that her love for him had never depended on the name in the register.

"I need the truth to be public," Daniel said. "I don't need strangers to own it."

After the family meeting, Daniel asked Adwoa to sit with him without Badu or Mabel present. He did not accuse her of

lying; he asked why she had accepted a placement without insisting on a complete record. Adwoa said she had believed the officials who told her the papers would follow, and that she had been afraid the child would be sent somewhere else if she challenged them. Daniel listened, then asked why she had not told him once he was old enough to understand. She admitted that the temporary silence had become harder to break with every passing year.

They did not reach a simple reconciliation. Daniel was grateful for the home Adwoa had given him and angry that important facts had been kept from him. Adwoa wanted her care to count for something without being used to excuse the silence. Both understood that love and harm could exist in the same history. When Daniel left the room, he asked that his questions be included in the record, not as evidence against her but as part of what the investigation had cost their family.

Mabel drafted an ethical note for the editor: the story should explain the identity fraud and institutional failures without publishing private medical details that did not bear on the case. She also recommended that Daniel review any direct quotations attributed to him for accuracy, while making clear that he would not control the newspaper’s conclusions. The editor approved the safeguards. The reporting would be firm about public responsibility and careful about the person whose childhood had become evidence.

Daniel did not want his life reduced to a case number. He asked Mabel whether the newsroom would use his birth name in a headline. She said she would not make that decision without him and would discuss the legal and ethical implications with her editor.

The family meeting was difficult in ways no formal interview could capture. Daniel asked Adwoa to explain the years between the transfer and his first school admission. She remembered dates

by the rent they had paid, the job she had held and the illness that kept him home for a week. Her account aligned with some records and conflicted with others. Badu noted each difference for later checking.

Adwoa and Daniel met with an independent lawyer to discuss what the investigation might mean for his civil records. The lawyer explained that an altered historical register did not automatically invalidate every later document, and that any correction would require a lawful process supported by evidence. Daniel asked whether he could keep the name he had used all his life. The lawyer said that question was separate from establishing his birth identity and should be considered without pressure from the police, the press or the family. Adwoa sat quietly through the explanation, then apologised for making decisions on his behalf when he was too young to understand them.

Daniel did not forgive her immediately. He asked why she had not told him when he became an adult, and she could not give an answer that made the silence acceptable. She had feared that the officials who arranged the placement still had influence; she had also feared losing the family they had built. Both fears were real, but neither had given him a choice. When the meeting ended, Daniel asked for time alone. Mabel respected his request and did not follow him with a notebook. The case had exposed a conspiracy in public records, but the consequences were unfolding in private, where no official statement could make them neat.

Adwoa’s fuller statement began with what she had been told when Daniel came into her care. She remembered a promise that the arrangement would be temporary and a warning not to discuss it outside a small circle. She could not recall every word, and she would not pretend that the warning had named a particular danger. At the time, she had understood confidentiality as protection. Later, as the story changed around her, she began

to suspect that it had also protected the adults who made the decisions.

Daniel asked why she had not told him sooner. Adwoa did not answer with a single excuse. She described the fear of losing him, the shame of not knowing his full history, and the repeated belief that she would explain everything once she had a safer answer. Each delay made the next conversation harder. She acknowledged that keeping the truth from him had protected her from immediate conflict as much as it had protected him from public attention. Daniel listened without offering instant forgiveness.

Mabel kept her notebook closed while they spoke. The conversation belonged to them, not to a headline. Later, Daniel agreed to let investigators examine the relevant documents, but he asked that private medical details and unrelated family matters remain outside the public account. The legal officer explained that evidential disclosure and publication were different questions. Daniel could cooperate with a lawful investigation while still asserting reasonable boundaries over the telling of his life.

The Family Meeting

Daniel asked for a meeting with Adwoa and Mabel without the investigators present. He wanted to hear the family account without watching each sentence become an exhibit. Mabel agreed not to record the conversation, and Adwoa accepted that Daniel could leave whenever he wished. At first they discussed ordinary details: the first school uniform, the fever that kept him home for a week, the day he had asked why his birth certificate looked newer than the other papers. The memories were painful precisely because they were ordinary.

Adwoa admitted that she had repeated the official explanation so often that she had begun to use it as if it were her own memory. She had told herself the child would be safer if he did

not know the adults had failed him. Daniel asked whether anyone had ever tried to contact his birth family. She could not answer. She remembered a sealed letter arriving and being taken away by an official, but she had never seen its contents. The memory gave the investigators a new lead and gave Daniel another reason not to accept certainty from anyone too quickly.

At the end, Daniel did not offer forgiveness as a way to make the room comfortable. He said he wanted a relationship that could survive difficult answers. Adwoa accepted this without asking him to reassure her. When Mabel later described the meeting to Badu, she shared only the information Daniel had agreed could be used. His privacy was not a reward for cooperation; it was a boundary the investigation had to respect.

Mabel kept the family meeting out of her article. The fact that it had occurred did not make its private words public property. She included only the parts of Adwoa’s account that had been formally confirmed and gave the family a clear explanation of what would be published. The choice made the story less dramatic, but it protected the boundary between public scrutiny of institutional misconduct and a family’s private effort to rebuild trust.

Daniel read the revised wording and said it was more accurate, though no less painful. He did not promise that he could forgive her. Adwoa did not ask him to. They agreed to continue their conversations with a counsellor who had no role in the police inquiry, so that their relationship would not be reduced to a series of evidential interviews.

Adwoa read the proposed statement in full before signing. She asked for one sentence to be changed because it made her sound as though she had knowingly chosen a false identity from the beginning. The investigator explained that the statement had to include both what she had been told and what she later suspected. They revised the passage to show the sequence: initial trust in the temporary arrangement, growing doubts when the

correction did not occur, and her decision to remain silent when she feared the child would be removed.

Adwoa faces the record

The Cost of Telling It

Adwoa asked Daniel to meet her without the investigators present. He agreed, but they chose a public courtyard and told Badu where they would be. Neither wanted another secret meeting to become a new source of suspicion. Adwoa brought a small envelope of school reports and a photograph of Daniel at a prize-giving ceremony. She said she had kept them because they recorded the life they had actually lived, even if the original papers were incomplete.

She explained that she had first believed the officials who promised to correct the record. When months passed, she had asked again and been told that reopening the matter would expose the child to a public dispute. She had accepted the explanation partly because she feared losing Daniel and partly because she did not know how to challenge officials whose authority seemed absolute.

Daniel asked why she had never told him. Adwoa did not defend herself with the word protection. She said she had been afraid, and that fear had become a habit. Each year made the truth harder to explain because it meant admitting that she had known more than she had said. She had loved him, but love had not prevented her from making a decision that denied him a choice.

Daniel did not forgive her immediately. He said he needed time to separate the woman who raised him from the adults who changed his documents, and to understand where her silence belonged in that history. Adwoa accepted the answer without asking him to comfort her.

They agreed that any public account should distinguish her role from the officials who had ordered or authorised the arrangement. That did not mean hiding what she had done. It meant describing it accurately, including the pressure she faced and the choices she still made.

After the meeting, Daniel gave the school reports to the independent officer for copying, keeping the originals. They proved that he had been known as Daniel Sarpong for much of his life; they did not settle the legal question of his birth identity. The family had finally agreed to let the evidence speak without asking it to absolve anyone.

The Conversation Without Cameras

Daniel asked Mabel to meet him without a recorder. She agreed, telling him that she would not quote the conversation unless he later gave permission, and that she would not promise to conceal evidence relevant to a serious offence. He appreciated the honesty. For years, people had presented choices to him as if he had no right to understand their consequences. He wanted to speak once without being turned into a witness before he had finished being a son.

He told her that the name on his school certificate had shaped every application he had made. It had not prevented him from building a life, but it had made that life rest on a record he now had reason to doubt. He was not asking for sympathy. He wanted the official record corrected, and he wanted to know who had decided that the truth could be postponed until a review was complete.

Mabel said the article could expose the institutional choices without publishing every intimate detail of his childhood. Daniel asked her to include the names of officials only where the documentary record supported doing so. He did not want a careless accusation to make it easier for the responsible people to portray the entire investigation as revenge.

They discussed Adwoa's role. Daniel loved her, but he could no longer accept that love as a reason to avoid difficult questions. Mabel reminded him that someone could have protected him and still participated in a harmful decision. Those truths did not cancel one another. Daniel said he was beginning to understand that the past could contain gratitude and anger without requiring him to choose only one.

When they parted, no dramatic revelation had occurred. There was no confession and no sudden reconciliation. There was a clearer agreement about how the story would be told, and a promise that Daniel's own voice would not be replaced by the assumptions of investigators or journalists.

Adwoa’s Full Statement

Adwoa returned to the station to review her earlier statement. She asked that the record distinguish between the facts she had witnessed and the explanations she had accepted from officials. She had signed a document confirming the child’s placement, but she had not seen the original register altered. She had been told that the arrangement was temporary and that the child’s records would be corrected once the review ended. She now understood that she had treated an assurance as if it were a guarantee.

Nyarko asked why Adwoa had not challenged the delay sooner. Adwoa said she had feared that questioning the officials would lead to the child being removed from her care. She did not offer that fear as an excuse; she said it was the truth of the choice she had made. The prosecutor noted that fear could explain conduct without settling whether it was lawful. Adwoa agreed to provide the letters she had kept and to identify the officials she remembered, with the warning that her memory of faces was limited.

Daniel listened to the revised statement with a support person beside him. He did not forgive her immediately, and she did not ask him to. Instead, he asked for copies of the letters and

for a chance to decide what relationship he wanted with her after the investigation. Adwoa said she would answer his questions when she could and admit when she could not. Their conversation offered no easy reconciliation, but it replaced the old silence with terms both could understand.

CHAPTER NINETEEN

The Name He Was Born With

The recovered statement identified Daniel’s birth name, confirming that Emmanuel Sarpong had been the identity erased from the register. Daniel read the name slowly. It did not make his life with Adwoa false, but it explained why the official records had always seemed incomplete.

The statement also named the missing witness: Mabel Owusu. As a child, she had seen a file removed from Room Four and heard adults argue over the document used in the appointment review. Her statement had been separated from the main report because the officials feared that her evidence would expose the identity alteration.

Mabel’s memory returned in fragments. She recalled being asked to repeat a story that was not hers, then being told that the incident had never happened. Her childhood photograph had survived because someone had kept a private copy after the official records were altered.

Badu confronted Ofori with the recovered statement. Ofori admitted that he had separated the witness’s account, claiming he believed it would protect Mabel from pressure. He denied killing Agyeman, but acknowledged meeting him shortly before the murder. He said the judge had intended to reveal the truth and had asked him to retrieve the annex.

Badu still needed independent evidence. Ofori’s admissions could explain the missing documents, but they did not yet establish who had entered the locked study or why the judge had died.

The team compared Ofori's account with the access log, the movement slip and the statements from Adwoa and Daniel. He maintained that he had separated Mabel's statement to protect her from political pressure, and said Agyeman later asked him to retrieve the file. Badu recorded each claim as an allegation to be tested, not as an established fact.

The recovered birth record gave Daniel a name he had never used: Emmanuel Sarpong. The document did not change the person he had become, but it made the scale of the deception undeniable. The false entry had not simply offered him a new name. It had placed another family's name into the official history and made it appear that the original child had been transferred under lawful authority.

Daniel asked Badu whether his father had known. Badu said the surviving documents showed that Emmanuel Badu had known something about the altered record, but not exactly what he had done. He refused to turn the detective's father into either a hero or a villain before the evidence was complete.

The witness statement confirmed Mabel's role. As a child, she had heard the argument and seen a file carried from Room Four. Her statement had been removed from the main record because it contradicted the account later accepted by the appointment review. The memory returned slowly, accompanied by the knowledge that adults had trained her to doubt it.

Mabel agreed to give a formal statement, with a support person present. She made clear which details she remembered directly and which she knew only from the

documents. Her care with those distinctions gave Badu something the cover-up had tried to erase: a witness willing to speak without pretending to know more than she did.

The birth record was recovered from a sealed registry packet, its paper brittle at the folds. The original entry named Emmanuel Sarpong. A later form substituted Emmanuel Badu—the same name as Detective Kwame Badu's late father—and a subsequent record carried Daniel Sarpong into school and medical files. The match made the detective's family connection impossible to ignore, but the document alone did not establish whether his father had authorised the substitution, had been impersonated, or had been drawn into the scheme another way. The changes had not happened by accident; who had ordered them still required proof.

Badu asked an independent records specialist to examine the ink, the stamps and the order of the entries. The specialist could not identify every hand, but confirmed that the amendments had been made at different times. That finding mattered: the false identity had not been a single desperate correction. It had been maintained.

Daniel sat with the documents spread before him. He traced the name at the top of the original record, then withdrew his hand.

"I thought finding it would make me feel complete," he said. "It feels like finding the first page of a book someone else has been writing."

Mabel understood. She had built her own career around asking questions, yet the photograph had shown her that she, too, had been placed inside a story without consent. The truth would

not restore the years that had been taken. It could, however, prevent others from deciding what the years meant.

The evidence now connected the altered record, the missing statement, the appointment review and the dead judge. It still did not prove who had killed Agyeman. Badu insisted that the murder investigation remain separate from the historical wrongdoing until the evidence connected them directly.

That evening, the technical team sent a preliminary alert: a routine backup appeared to contain an entry missing from the printed residence log. The original system record still had to be authenticated before investigators could rely on it.

Badu read the timestamp and felt the case shift. The locked study had never been the whole mystery. The important question was who had been allowed to move through the house unseen.

The murder case had finally acquired a verifiable route through the house. The remaining question was whether that route could be tied to the man who had denied walking it.

Badu requested a second review of the residence credential before he allowed it to become the centrepiece of the case. The first report linked the credential to Ofori’s assigned unit; the second had to establish what that meant in practice. The systems officer explained that a credential could identify an account or device without proving who had physically used it. The inquiry therefore needed to connect the system record to a person through independent circumstances.

The officer reconstructed the relevant access sequence from the original backup, not from the printed summary. The backup had been created automatically, and its timestamp was consistent with the server’s maintenance record. A separate maintenance log showed no scheduled reset during the interval. None of this

made the entry infallible, but it reduced the chance that the crucial line had been added by hand after the murder.

The security guard was interviewed again, this time without being shown Ofori’s statement. He described the visitor’s coat, the folder carried under one arm, and the brief exchange at the gate. He could not swear to the precise minute. His watch had been slow, and he had relied on the clock in the guardroom for his written report. The team recorded that limitation instead of adjusting his memory to fit the electronic log.

When the guard was shown the photograph of the folder, he did not identify it as the one he had seen. He said only that the shape and colour were similar. Badu thanked him for refusing to guess. A weak identification would have made the file look stronger on paper and weaker under questioning.

The missing duplicate key was another problem. The estate manager produced the original issue book and the note describing the broken seal, but could not explain who had last checked the envelope. Investigators photographed the storage cabinet, took statements from those with authorised access, and sent the seal fragments for examination. The fragments could show when the envelope had been disturbed only within limits; they could not name the person who opened it.

A junior investigator asked whether the case was becoming too cautious to move forward. Badu replied that caution was not hesitation. The evidence already established that Ofori’s first account of his visit was unreliable. It did not yet establish every movement he made inside the house, nor did it prove the exact act that caused Agyeman’s death. The prosecutor needed to understand both the strength of the case and its gaps.

That night Badu reread his father’s letter. He had been tempted to interpret its warning as an admission, but the sentence could bear several meanings. His father might have kept a secret

created by someone else; he might have protected a person he believed innocent; or he might have been defending his own part in the affair. The letter did not choose between those possibilities.

Badu placed it in a fresh evidence sleeve and wrote a note for the file explaining why he had not treated it as a confession. Then he informed his superintendent that his family connection made independent review especially important. He would continue to lead the factual reconstruction, but another officer would countersign decisions concerning the letter and any evidence directly implicating his father.

The decision cost him a measure of control over the case. It also made the inquiry more credible. He had spent years believing that a detective’s duty was to follow evidence wherever it led. Now he understood the other half of that duty: he must not pretend that personal history left him untouched by the destination.

At the registry, Daniel received the certified copy he had requested. The registrar explained that certification confirmed the copy’s agreement with the record currently held; it did not, by itself, resolve the legal process for correcting a record believed to have been altered. Daniel signed the receipt and asked for the procedure in writing. He would not allow a second informal substitution to masquerade as repair.

Mabel kept her notebook closed while he spoke to the registrar. The story mattered, but the moment belonged to Daniel. Later, with his consent, she recorded his explanation of why he wanted the original entry preserved alongside any correction: erasing the false record without preserving its history would make the manipulation harder to understand and easier to repeat.

That afternoon, the technical team confirmed that the access log had come from a routine backup rather than a manually prepared printout. The log showed a credential associated with Ofori's assigned unit at the residence. The credential could theoretically have been used by another person, so the team began checking who had access to it.

Mabel sat with him while he read the examiner's report. She told him she was still trying to establish her own connection to the five children. She would not claim a relationship until the evidence supported it.

Daniel requested a certified copy of the original birth entry. He wanted it for his own records, not just the investigation. The registry agreed to process the request under the applicable procedure. Now the official system was being asked to correct itself through a documented process rather than another quiet substitution.

The prosecutor held a case conference with the investigators and asked each person to identify the strongest evidence against Ofori and the strongest evidence that complicated the theory. The access records and changing account mattered, but the key register contained a gap and the audio did not identify the caller. The guard's timeline conflicted with Ofori's first statement, though the guard's recollection of the precise minute was uncertain. The team agreed to describe the case as a set of converging circumstances requiring further legal testing, not as a complete reconstruction witnessed by anyone.

The duplicate-key issue received special attention. The issue record showed that a key had been signed out for an earlier official visit and marked returned. The storage envelope's seal was damaged, but the date of that damage could not be established. No fingerprint result could reliably identify who had

handled the key. The evidence supported the possibility that someone could have locked the study from the corridor; it did not prove which person had done so. The prosecutor asked for the original lock, the locksmith’s report and the key log to be kept together for any later court examination.

Daniel received the registry’s acknowledgement of his request and placed it in a folder of his own. It was not the final correction he wanted, but it was the first official response that described the uncertainty rather than hiding it behind a completed form. He told Mabel that a truthful answer might take longer than a convenient one. She wrote down his words with his permission, then asked whether he wanted them used in the article. He said he would decide after seeing the full draft.

The prosecutor asked for a chronology that would make sense to someone who had never seen the file. Badu prepared one from the earliest known transfer through the appointment review and the judge’s death. Each event was linked to its supporting source, and every uncertainty was marked. The chronology was less dramatic than a theory, but it was harder to dismiss.

The independent examiner completed a preliminary report on the registry documents. The report found that several entries had been amended at different times and that the visible overwriting was consistent with deliberate alteration. It could not identify every person who had handled the page. Badu treated the report as an important step, not a final answer.

The prosecutor held a case conference with Badu, the forensic examiner and the officer responsible for the access logs. They reviewed the murder timeline separately from the identity investigation. The first established who could have entered the judge's house and when; the second established who had handled the Haven House records. The overlap was important, but it could not be treated as proof that the same person had committed both acts. Ofori's access to the annex gave him a reason to fear

disclosure, while the visitor evidence and missing key gave investigators a possible opportunity. The prosecutor asked for a single chronology showing what each source could and could not establish.

Badu revised the chronology until every line had a source: a call record, a signed statement, a ledger, a forensic report or a clearly labelled recollection. Where two sources conflicted, he left the conflict visible. The prosecutor approved the approach and reminded him that the defence would test every gap. A strong case would not be one in which every uncertainty disappeared; it would be one in which the important uncertainties had been identified and honestly addressed. Badu left the meeting with no triumphant feeling. The evidence was stronger, but he understood that the next stage would be harder: explaining it in a way that did not ask anyone to accept more than it proved.

The name comparison required more than matching letters. Investigators assembled certified copies of birth, school and clinic records, then logged the source of each copy. The earliest document was incomplete, and a later certificate appeared to have been issued on the basis of a declaration rather than a contemporaneous hospital record. That did not make it false, but it limited what could be inferred from it. The registrar explained the procedure used at the time and identified which registers had survived. The team requested a formal search report so that the absence of a record would not be mistaken for proof that no record had ever existed.

Badu’s father remained part of the question, but the evidence did not support a simple story of a lone rescuer or a lone conspirator. His father’s contact list placed him near people connected to the review, yet proximity did not establish purpose. A note in the diary used an abbreviation that might refer to Daniel, but it might also refer to another child. Badu asked for an independent handwriting assessment and kept his own

interpretation out of the referral. He knew how badly he wanted the note to mean something clear.

Daniel chose to use his current name in public while the legal questions were examined. He did not accept that a disputed childhood record should decide his identity for him. His solicitor explained that correcting official records would require a separate process and could not be settled by a newspaper article or police interview. The distinction gave the story a quieter but important resolution: the investigation could uncover how his name had been changed, while Daniel retained the right to decide how he described himself.

A Name Before the Forms

The civil registry search produced an index card referring to a birth entry that had been transferred to a district office during a building renovation. The card contained Daniel’s suspected birth name, but the date was partly smudged and the parent fields were blank. A registry officer explained that the index was a finding aid, not the certificate itself. The original book would need to be located and checked for adjacent entries, corrections and signatures before the team could make a reliable identification.

A search of the district archive found a volume with the correct series number but a missing leaf near the relevant date. The binding showed that the leaf had been cut out before the volume was moved to the archive. No one could say when or by whom. The next page carried a marginal reference to a medical facility that had since changed names. The registry officer recommended contacting the facility’s successor records unit, where admission books might preserve a second source.

Daniel listened as the officers explained the limits of the discovery. He had hoped that a birth entry would settle every question about his identity. Instead, it opened a new line of inquiry. Badu told him that this did not make the search a failure. A reliable conclusion required two independent records where

possible, and the absence of one record had to be explained rather than ignored. Daniel asked to be told when the medical archive replied, whether the answer was good or bad.

Daniel received a summary rather than a stack of raw documents. Badu explained which facts were now independently supported and which questions remained open. The evidence strongly supported the name he had been given at birth, but it did not establish who had first ordered the later substitution or whether every person involved understood its full consequences. Daniel said he could live with an answer that remained incomplete, provided no one called it complete merely to close the file.

The team sought a second source for the birth name. A separate registration index contained a similar entry, but a spelling variation required examination. The registrar explained that clerical differences were common and that a spelling mismatch did not automatically indicate a second person. Investigators compared dates, family details and reference numbers before recording the degree of confidence in the identification.

The clinic’s successor organisation located a ledger stored off-site after a renovation. The relevant page was fragile, and the archivist allowed the examiner to photograph it under controlled light. The reference number matched Daniel’s card, and the entry included a name that differed from the one on his later school records. The handwriting could not be attributed immediately, but the ledger’s sequence and surrounding entries supported the claim that it had been used during the relevant period.

The Name on the Form

Daniel sat across from the civil-records officer with a folder that held certified copies, school entries, and the letter his mother had kept for years. He had expected the process to feel like a verdict on his life. Instead the officer explained that correcting a

civil record required a documented basis, an application, and a review of conflicting entries. The criminal investigation could provide relevant evidence, but it could not automatically rewrite a register.

‘Which name do you want the record to recognise?’ the officer asked.

Daniel looked at the forms. Emmanuel Sarpong was the name recorded at birth. Daniel Sarpong had followed him through school and most of his adult life. Emmanuel Badu appeared on a later document without a clear explanation. None of those names could be erased simply because one caused pain or because another appeared in a file linked to wrongdoing.

‘I want the record to tell the truth about how the names came to be used, ’ he said. ‘I do not want the record to pretend the years under another name did not happen.’

The officer nodded and listed the documents still required. One copy needed verification from the issuing office. Another entry contained a spelling difference that might be a clerical error. The letter from his mother could support his application, but it would need to be considered with the other records. Daniel signed the request for certified extracts and asked for a receipt showing what had been submitted.

Outside the office, Adwoa waited beside the window. She had offered to accompany him but had not answered the officer’s questions for him. Daniel appreciated that more than he could say. For years, other people had explained his identity in forms, interviews, and whispered stories. This time he had been able to state what he wanted without being told which part of his history was convenient.

‘Will they change it?’ Adwoa asked.

‘They will review it. That is all they promised.’

She accepted the distinction. It was not the certainty either of them wanted, but it was honest. They walked to the registry desk to confirm the next appointment and the method for notifying him of a decision. Daniel kept the receipt separate from the evidence copies. The civil process would continue on its own track, while the murder investigation would have to establish responsibility through its own evidence.

That evening he wrote down the dates he could personally remember and marked those supplied by others. He did not try to make the two lists identical. His memory had gaps, and the documents had contradictions. If the review was to mean anything, it had to preserve both the truth he could support and the questions that remained unanswered.

CHAPTER TWENTY

The Last Witness

Badu reconstructed the judge's final evening from call records, the housekeeper's account and the recovered documents. Agyeman had invited Ofori to discuss the original Haven House report. The visitor's movements—not the locked door alone—became central to the inquiry. The post-mortem placed the fatal encounter within a window consistent with the corrected phone and security records, but it could not identify the killer. That question had to be answered by the other evidence.

The stopped desk clock could not establish the time of death. The locksmith's report offered a practical explanation for the locked room: the study lock could be operated with a key from either side. The door had been locked, but that did not mean someone had secured it from inside. The brass key tagged ROOM FOUR belonged to the old records; it did not fit the study lock or suggest a secret passage.

The front-door log placed Ofori's arrival later than the time he had first given. The guard remembered admitting him and later seeing him leave, but had assumed the visit was routine because Ofori had attended the residence before. Investigators compared that account with the access record and call timeline. Together, the sources narrowed the interval in which the fatal encounter could have occurred.

The final interview took place with Ofori's lawyer present. Badu laid out the access log, corrected timeline and locksmith's findings, explaining the limits of each before asking Ofori to account for the discrepancies. The case did not depend on a dramatic confession. It depended on whether his account could withstand independent checks.

Ofori first suggested another officer might have used his credential. The duty records narrowed that possibility. He then said he had visited earlier in the evening, not during the interval shown in the log. The security record and call timing made that explanation difficult to sustain. Asked about the study key, he denied ever possessing one.

The estate manager’s register contradicted him. It recorded a duplicate study key issued to Ofori during an earlier official visit and later marked as returned. Yet the storage envelope’s seal had been broken before the murder, and the key was missing. This did not prove who had used it. Investigators checked the register against the manager’s original notes and Ofori’s visit dates; those records were consistent with the duplicate having remained outside secure storage.

Asked about the old inquiry, Ofori accused Agyeman of threatening to expose everyone involved. He admitted meeting the judge that night but insisted he had left while Agyeman was still alive. He also acknowledged separating Mabel’s witness statement from the main file, claiming he had meant to shield her from political pressure. The admissions suggested motive and opportunity, but neither was proof of murder by itself.

Prosecutor Nyarko reviewed the authenticated access record, the guard’s account, call timeline, locksmith’s findings, missing duplicate key and Ofori’s changing statements. No single item answered every question. Taken together, they placed Ofori at the residence during the critical interval, showed that the door could have been secured from the corridor, and weakened his claim that he had left before the fatal encounter. Nyarko considered the evidence sufficient to support arrest and referral for prosecution, subject to the remaining legal checks. She also recorded the weaknesses the defence could fairly raise: uncertain custody of the duplicate key, limits in the call data and the absence of an eyewitness to the killing. The allegations would still have to be tested in court.

The room was no longer an impossible puzzle. The leading reconstruction was ordinary and deliberate: Ofori entered with legitimate access, confronted Agyeman over the old file, and left during the interval supported by the records. Investigators believed the study might then have been locked from the corridor with the duplicate key. The missing key and broken storage seal were consistent with that theory, but neither established who had used the key or when the door had been secured. The team recorded the sequence as its best-supported explanation, not as an account anyone had witnessed minute by minute.

Ofori's arrest did not settle every question. Asare still had to answer for the confidential review, and the role of others in preserving the false records remained under investigation. Daniel began the difficult process of reclaiming his history without surrendering the family bonds that had shaped his life. Adwoa gave a formal statement. Mabel prepared her report, separating what the evidence established from what remained uncertain.

Badu placed his father's letter in the case file. Emmanuel Badu had left neither a simple confession nor a clear defence, only a warning: the person who keeps a secret is not always the person who creates it.

Before the case could proceed, Nyarko required a disclosure schedule covering both material that supported the prosecution and anything that might assist the defence. The access log, call data, locksmith's report and witness accounts all had limitations; those limitations had to be recorded plainly, not concealed behind the preferred conclusion. Ofori's lawyer requested the underlying records and said the defence would challenge the interpretation of the access log. Further testing and disclosure would continue before the allegations were examined in court.

Mabel published only after giving the relevant parties an opportunity to respond. She described Ofori's arrest as an allegation under investigation, not a conviction, and kept Daniel's private records out of the article. The failures in the

Haven House inquiry were now public, but she did not claim that every participant had been identified or every question answered.

In his final note, Badu separated the child-record histories he could trace from the missing fifth. Surviving records supported Daniel's altered identity; Mabel's statement established that she had seen a file removed from Room Four. Neither revealed whom the note meant by "the fifth child." Badu left the question marked unresolved rather than filling the gap with a guess.

You have found only the first truth.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Emmanuel Osei Kojo Ninsin writes mystery fiction exploring truth, memory, institutional power and justice.

About the *Author*



Emmanuel Osei Ninsin is a young Ghanaian, educator, student leader, and aspiring lawyer with a deep passion for justice, human rights, and the power of education.

Born and raised in Ghana, Emmanuel has always believed that education is the key to a better life — not just for himself, but for everyone, especially the less privileged. His journey from humble beginnings to greater heights has been shaped by faith, hard work, and the support of family, mentors, and friends who believed in his dreams.

Currently a student at the University of Cape Coast (UCC), College of Distance Education (CODE), pursuing a Bachelor of Education in Social Studies, Emmanuel is committed to using his knowledge and experience to create positive change in society. He hopes to one day study law, become a renowned lawyer, and advocate for the rights of the oppressed, ensuring that justice is not a privilege, but a right for all.

Beyond his academic and professional goals, Emmanuel is a proud Jehovah's Witness, a devoted son, a friend, and a believer in the transformative power of education, integrity, and faith.

> *"Education is not just a tool for personal success, it is a bridge to a better world."*
>
> *— Emmanuel Osei Ninsin*